

5 Classes in Marxian theory

The theory of class

Concepts of class are central to Marxist theory and hence to Marxist analyses of concrete social situations. Within the Marxist tradition there have been quite different readings of Marx's own notions of class as well as different interpretations and elaborations of these notions. While one general orientation has prevailed in that tradition, recently some influential formulations have advanced a basic criticism of it as well as of Marx's own notions of class. They also offer alternatives. We sympathize with the view that traditional Marxist notions of class are generally vague and inadequate. As for Marx's own work, however, it does develop a complex, carefully specified concept of classes. Marx's conceptualization stands, we believe, as a critique both of the traditional Marxist theory of class and of the recent efforts to remedy its vagueness and inadequacies.

Most Marxists have traditionally attributed to Marx a dichotomous theory of class, that is, a theory that societies are predominantly characterized by two opposing classes.¹ Most non-Marxists make much the same attribution.² There are some minor variations on the theme that Marx works with a "two-class model." Many Marxist writers have acknowledged that groups designated as "peasants" or as a "petty bourgeoisie" ("old" and/or "new") of craftspeople or other self-employed producers of commodities exist as classes outside of the basic two in capitalism, namely, workers and capitalists. But their existence is traditionally dismissed or de-emphasized on the grounds of an intrinsic polarization of society and social change around the two primary classes: workers and capitalists (Miliband 1977: 20–22). The Marxist tradition, and Marx himself, are thus widely understood to mean by the term "class analysis" an approach characterized by this basic focus on two classes.

Recent Marxist critics of the traditional two-class focus share a concern to specify additional classes in capitalism beyond the workers and capitalists. Despite some differences among them, their common goal is to elaborate a Marxist social theory built upon a complex conceptualization of several classes. Nicos Poulantzas works with a complex concept of class "places" as distinguished from class "positions."³ His "places" exist at each of the three levels of society: economic, political, and ideological. At each level there is a dichotomy

between the dominating and the dominated. In the case of capitalism the capitalists are dominant at each level, the proletarians are dominated at each. For Poulantzas these two classes present no analytical problem. However, they strike him as insufficient to carry out an adequate class analysis of capitalism. Other groupings exist who are not similarly “placed” at each level, that is, they are dominant in some while dominated in others. Poulantzas conceptualizes these as the old and new petty bourgeoisie, classes beyond the basic two of that predominant Marxist tradition he criticizes. Poulantzas emphasizes the importance of these extra classes in terms of Marxist theory and practical politics. The thrust of Poulantzas’ work is to produce a Marxist analysis of contemporary capitalism by means of his concepts of several class places whose occupants varyingly take the opposed class “positions” in actual social struggles.

From an appreciative critique of Poulantzas, Erik Olin Wright (1979: 61–96) derives his three basic classes: bourgeoisie, proletariat, and petty-bourgeoisie. However, he adds three more (which he terms “contradictory class locations”) situated structurally among the first three. He also specifies several class locations of positions “which are not directly defined by the social relations of production”; these include housewives, students, and others.⁴ Barbara and John Ehrenreich (1977: 7–31) theorize in terms of four basic classes: workers, capitalists, petty bourgeoisie and the “professional-managerial class” whose importance their work underscores.

Common to all these authors is a focus upon the power or dominance relations among persons. They redefine class in terms of those relations but not only at the economic level, which they criticize as the unacceptably exclusive concern of the Marxist tradition. For these critics class relations exist also at the political and ideological (or cultural) levels where social dominance occurs. Marx and Marxism are seen as focused too narrowly: merely upon the economic aspects of dominance relations and therefore upon two simple classes. The critics reconceptualize classes to include dominance relations at the other social levels; this permits them to theorize multiple classes incorporating the contradictions among the several levels.

Our purpose here is not to examine such critiques of traditional Marxist class theory. Rather, the brief mention of them is intended to set the basis for our demonstration of how very differently Marx conceptualized the multiplicity of classes in capitalism. In our view Marx’s concepts provide the basis for a complex class analysis that is different from the dichotomous theory of traditional Marxism *and* from the kind of alternative theory exemplified by the authors mentioned above. In any case, Marx’s concepts of classes merit far more careful and detailed discussion than any of these critics devoted to them. Not surprisingly, Marx’s complex class analysis is far more consistently grounded in Marx’s value theory than the alternative formulations of the critics. After sketching Marx’s analysis, we propose to indicate some of its distinctive analytical capacities as compared to those alternative formulations.

Class process and conditions of existence

As we read Marx’s work, class is one distinct process among the many that constitute life. The class process is that “in which unpaid surplus labor is pumped

out of direct producers” (Marx 1967a: 3, 791). It is different from all the other distinct processes comprising social life. These include both natural processes such as breathing, photo synthesis, eating and rainfall, and social processes such as thinking, speaking, voting and working.

Processes never exist alone; they do not occur by themselves. Rather, the concept of process is an analytical device to pinpoint the constituent aspects of relationships in society. Particular relationships are understood, defined as particular sets of processes. Aspect and process are conceptualized as synonyms.

To take the example of the class process, it invariably occurs together with distinct processes of transforming nature, with distinct processes of exerting and obeying authority among people, and with distinct processes of language, to take just a few cases. On the other hand, any particular relationship between persons may, but need not always, include the class process. Two people going fishing are involved in a relationship—a set of processes—that may or may not include a class process. If it is a case of two friends sharing leisure time, no class process is involved. If surplus labor is extracted, a class process is involved.

Each process existing within any particular society is both influenced by and influences all the other processes comprising that society. As Althusser (1963: 87–128) suggests in his use of the term “*overdetermination*,” Marx affirms the notion that each process has no existence other than as the site of the converging influences exerted by all the other social processes.⁵ Of each process it can be said that all the other processes that combine to overdetermine it are its “conditions of existence.”⁶ Thus, the conditions of existence of the class process in society are all the other, non-class processes, without whose particular characteristics and interaction the class process could not and would not exist. In turn, the class process is a condition of existence of each and every other social process.

Fundamental and subsumed classes

Marx’s theory of the class process of extracting surplus labor involves the conceptual division of individuals in society into paired groupings occupying the positions of performers of such surplus labor, on the one hand, and extractors, on the other. These paired groupings we designate, following Marx (1973: 108), as *fundamental classes*. Marx distinguishes different forms of the fundamental class process: primitive communist, slave, feudal, capitalist, ancient, and others. Societies will likely exhibit more than one form at any time and hence more than one set of the corresponding pairs of fundamental classes.

Marx (1977: 325) makes reference to surplus, as opposed to necessary, labor. The latter is the time-measured expenditure of human brain and muscle required to reproduce the performers of surplus labor. What expenditures of brain and muscle these performers can be variously induced (in and through their social relationships) to perform over and above this necessary amount is defined as *surplus labor*. Nothing is fixed or exogenously determined in this Marxian concept of the distinction between necessary and surplus. What is necessary labor presupposes historically variable social standards for the reproduction of the

performers of surplus labor, hence for the reproduction of each form of the fundamental class process.

The adjective “fundamental” is ascribed to those sets of performers and extractors of surplus labor to underscore Marx’s differentiation of them from the second type of class which he begins to formulate in Volumes 2 and 3 of *Capital*. The second type, which we shall call *subsumed classes*, refers to persons who *neither perform nor extract surplus labor*. Rather, they carry out certain specific social functions and sustain themselves by means of shares of extracted surplus labor distributed to them by one or another fundamental extracting class. The social functions performed by subsumed classes, as elaborately specified by Marx, are understood as constitutive of, as well as dependent upon, the fundamental class relations between performers and extractors of surplus labor. They are constitutive in the sense of providing certain of the conditions of existence—non-economic as well as economic—of the fundamental class process. Without their cut of the extracted surplus labor, subsumed classes cannot reproduce themselves and their social activities. In turn, without the reproduction of certain of its conditions of existence by subsumed classes, no fundamental class process can be reproduced over time. Fundamental and subsumed classes determine and depend upon one another. Their relationship is complex, contradictory and on a terrain of class struggles which are different from, although interactive with, the class struggles between performers and extractors of surplus labor.

The distinction between fundamental and subsumed classes is the distinction between the production and distribution of surplus value. To underscore the importance of this distinction, we will henceforth refer to the extraction of surplus labor as the *fundamental class process* and to the distribution of surplus labor as the *subsumed class process*. It follows that all other natural and social processes may be referred to as non-class processes.

Although Marx focused overwhelmingly upon the capitalist fundamental and subsumed classes, his basic conceptual approach to class analysis had a broader scope. Any particular form of the fundamental class process has its natural and social conditions of existence. The latter include the economic, political, and cultural processes which overdetermine that particular form of the fundamental class process. Each non-class process must occur socially in one of two ways. It can occur within a particular relationship whose constituent processes include neither a fundamental nor a subsumed class process. Alternatively, it can occur within a particular relationship whose constituent processes do include either one or the other class process.

For example, educating children is a distinct, non-class process, but it is also one condition of existence of any form of the fundamental class process. This educational process may occur within particular relationships that do not involve a class process, either fundamental or subsumed. Thus, education of children may be accomplished within the personal relationships of childhood playing. Alternatively, such education may be performed by specially selected persons sustained in that function by a share of already extracted surplus labor (e.g. teachers in tax-supported public primary schools). In this case, the process of educating

children occurs in a particular relationship that includes as well the subsumed class process. Finally, the process of educating children may occur in a relationship that also includes a fundamental class process as when, say, a capitalist enterprise sells education as a commodity. The process of educating children might occur in more than one such relationship simultaneously.

Society, for Marxian theory, is always a complex formation of interacting fundamental and subsumed classes; it is a social formation. Social analysis involves the specification of the relations among those classes comprising a particular social formation. Thus, Marxian theory can periodize history in terms of which form of the fundamental class process may have been prevalent—in terms of how most of the surplus labor was extracted—vis-à-vis other forms existing within a particular social formation. We give the name of the prevalent form to the social formation as a whole, for example, a capitalist social formation denotes one in which the capitalist form of the fundamental class process prevails over other forms existing within it. Different transitional periods in a social formation may then be specified in terms of a prevailing fundamental class process giving way to the prevalence of a different fundamental class process or in terms of particular forms of the fundamental class process passing out of existence altogether or newly emerging. Indeed, one major task of Marxian theory must be to specify whether and how both sorts of transition are occurring within any particular social formation under scrutiny.

Marx (1967a: 2, 129–52) repeatedly noted that individuals within a social formation usually occupy multiple, different class positions, both fundamental and subsumed. Thus, Marxian class analysis is doubly complex. First, it must distinguish the various fundamental and subsumed class positions comprising any social formation it proposes to examine. Second, it must specify the pattern of occupation of these different positions by the population of the formation. It follows that Marxist specifications of actual class struggles must presuppose just such complex class analyses of their participants.

In Volume 2, and especially in Volume 3, of *Capital* Marx discussed several different subsumed classes: in this case all are subsumed to the capitalist fundamental class process. Three of these are analyzed in great detail: merchants, money-lenders, and landlords. Two receive relatively brief treatment: money-dealers and supervisory managers of joint-stock companies. All of these subsumed classes are treated as directors of social processes which are conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process. As directors, they may employ or direct laborers to perform these processes. Laborers performing these processes may also be employed by capitalists, for example as salespeople and financial clerks. Such employees, regardless of immediate employer, comprise another subsumed class defined by Marx (1967a: 2, ch. 6; and 3, parts 4–6).

Marx explained how merchants and their employees—whom he defined narrowly and exclusively as commodity buyers and sellers—produce neither value nor surplus value and how they obtain their shares of the surplus value extracted by the fundamental class of capitalists. In varying detail he showed much the same for the other directing and directed subsumed classes. We shall

refer, then, to two basic types of subsumed classes: Type 1 comprises the directors of social processes which are conditions of existence for the capitalist fundamental class process; and Type 2 the directed performers of such processes (the latter may be employed by Type 1 subsumed classes or by capitalists).⁷

Merchanting was defined by Marx as strictly the buying and selling of capitalistically produced commodities. He *implicitly abstracted* from the many noneconomic processes included in the relationships among and between “merchants” and other human beings within capitalist social formations. He *explicitly abstracted* from the processes other than buying/selling, such as storage, transport, etc., usually attached to actual functioning merchants as a social group. Marx (1967a: 2, 136–152; and 3, 267–268) designated these other economic processes as connected to commodity production; if merchants undertook commodity production, they would then also occupy a fundamental class position. For theoretical reasons which we seek here to identify, Marx explicitly reduced his concept of the merchant process to doing nothing other than buying and selling commodities in the market.

What we believe Marx wanted to emphasize is that competitive accumulation by capitalists necessitated their ability to sell commodities as fast as they were produced. Delays caused by efforts to locate final purchasers interrupted or slowed the production process, reduced the turnover rate of capital, reduced the annualized rate of profit and thereby worsened the competitive position of any capitalist afflicted by such delays. The evolved solution was the merchant who, as the possessor of a quantum of the money commodity (merchants’ capital), served the capitalists by immediately buying their outputs (Marx 1967a: 2, 111).

Conceived in this way Marx’s merchants direct the circulation of commodities, the process of realizing the surplus value from the capitalist fundamental class process. Realization (and hence circulation) is a condition of existence for the capitalist fundamental class process. Marx’s merchants represent one possible form of the realization process, of that specific condition of existence. The realization process may be performed, of course, by alternative subsumed classes, some of which Marx mentions, such as salesmen employed directly by capitalists (our Type 2 subsumed class).

Merchants, strictly defined as pure buyers and sellers of commodities, deploy a quantum of value in money form (merchants’ capital) in a manner that produces no surplus value (Marx 1967a: 3, 279). The profit which they earn is, Marx explained, simply a transfer from capitalists of a portion of the surplus value which they extract from productive laborers.⁸ Merchants produce no commodities, no value. Any development rendering merchants unable or unwilling to accomplish the merchanting process will likely block or threaten the reproduction of the capitalist class process. Merchants occupy a Type 1 subsumed class position.

Insofar as merchants are organized as independent, private entrepreneurs, their buying and selling activity must involve a distribution to them of surplus value such that their merchants’ capital earns about what it would have if invested in commodity production rather than in merchanting. By contrast, a smaller

distribution would suffice if merchanting were accomplished as a “non-profit” state function. In the latter case the responsible state administrators would occupy the Type 1 subsumed class position of “directors.” Marx analyzed money-dealers and money-lenders (bankers) as subsumed classes in terms comparable to those used for merchants, although the mechanisms whereby they obtain cuts of surplus value do differ significantly.⁹

Marx’s approach to landlords and mine-owners as subsumed to the capitalist fundamental class process was somewhat different. The particular social process that they direct, by virtue of their land ownership (right of exclusion), is that of access to the presumed limited land surface of the globe. Marx argued (1967a: 3, part 6; and 1968: 44, 152–53) that exclusive private ownership of land effectively denies to proletarians the access which would give them the option to cease being proletarians, and secondly, that exclusive ownership also limits capitalists’ access to land. (Rosdolsky 1977: 33–34). In this sense the landowners’ control of access provides certain conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process. To gain access, that is, to induce this subsumed class to control access in particular ways, capitalists distribute a portion of their extracted surplus value to landlords in the form of capitalist rent payments. Such capitalists may be engaged in agricultural or industrial or service commodity production or any combination of these. **Competition among these capitalists and between them and the landlords determines the size distribution of rental payments.** At the same time, **competition among capitalists determines the average rate of profit.** Together, rental payments and the average rate of profit determine the price distribution of land, as rent flows capitalized at the average rate of profit.

Landlords produce no commodities, no values, and no surplus values. If they employ laborers, that is, a Type 2 subsumed class, such as rent collectors, they do not extract any surplus value from them. Logically, we can broaden Marx’s notion of landlords to include similar subsumed classes who function analogously: proprietors of patents, copyrights, trademarks, etc.

The broadened notion of landlords as a subsumed class raises the general problem of monopoly and its relation to the capitalist class process (Marx 1967a: 3, 645). In the sense of exclusive ownership, monopoly conveys directorship over the rental of access to the monopolized item. Monopoly always obtains a share of surplus value extracted elsewhere to the degree that such access is a condition of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process. When such a monopoly is achieved, however temporarily, by any individual or group, we understand the latter to occupy a particular subsumed class position. Such a group may concurrently occupy other fundamental and/or subsumed class positions. For example, capitalists may seek and gain a monopoly of some capital good, thereby adding to the surplus labor they extract directly a transferred portion of other capitalists’ extractions. They obtain such transfers by virtue of their monopoly, that is, of the subsumed class position they occupy in relation to those other capitalists.

When Marx discussed briefly the supervisory managers of joint-stock companies, he extended his notions of classes in two important ways (1967a: 3, 436–37 and 382–88). First, he identified what amounts to another Type 1 subsumed class,

namely, shareholders. When surplus value is extracted in joint-stock companies by means of capital owned by shareholders, then provision of such capital, such means of production, to such companies, has itself become a condition of existence of the capitalistic fundamental class process. As a subsumed class, shareholders' dividends represent their payment out of extracted surplus value for the condition of existence they direct: the process of providing capital for production (Marx 1967a: 3, 436–37).¹⁰ This point is developed further below.

The second extension of Marx's class analysis entailed in his discussion of joint-stock companies concerns subsumed classes who provide other than economic conditions of existence. Supervision, as distinguished from technical coordination, of productive laborers is a process of providing political conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process. Supervision is a process providing certain kinds of social behavior among productive workers without which the extraction of surplus value is jeopardized. Supervisory managers are a subsumed class.¹¹

Our approach implies that a typical capitalist corporation will itself display a complex class structure. Besides the fundamental capitalist class there will be various Type 1 subsumed classes, for example, shareholders and the directors of merchanting, personnel, supervision, advertising, bookkeeping, security, legal services, lobbying, etc., and their respective Type 2 subordinates. The same individuals might occupy the fundamental class position of capitalist extractor as well as one or more Type 1 subsumed class positions. In any case, whatever tensions and struggles come to characterize relations between these two class positions would emerge as "internal" corporate disagreements and conflicts. The capitalist corporation is an institutional site of subsumed as well as fundamental class tensions, alliances, and struggles. The class analysis of such institutions from a Marxian theoretical standpoint presupposes the categories of fundamental and subsumed classes to which this paper is devoted.

Other directors of political processes comprising conditions of existence of the capitalist class process include, for example, the decision-making top levels of state-run police, military, administrative, legislative, and judicial organizations. The political effects—in terms of ordered social behavior—of their various activities secure private property and contracts. Certainly, innumerable commentators on capitalism have long understood the critical implications for the reproduction of capitalism of any inability to reproduce this security, these political conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process.

We may further extend Marx's theorization of what we term subsumed classes to encompass social processes providing ideological or, more broadly, cultural conditions of existence for the capitalist fundamental class process. The Type 1 subsumed class of directors of cultural or ideological processes includes, for example, the administrators of state-run free education, of religious education conducted within the various denominations, of state-run free cultural programs, and of corporate counseling programs for employees. At stake here are concepts of justice, society, work, individuality, suffering, etc., functioning in people's minds to determine how individuals construct and construe their "experiences."

Belief in and thinking by means of specific conceptual frameworks are cultural conditions of existence for the capitalist class process.

Cultural processes comprising conditions of existence for the capitalist class process are as important as its economic and political conditions of existence. Only the combined interaction of them all overdetermines the capitalist fundamental class process.

The Type 1 subsumed classes of directors of the economic, political, and cultural processes comprising conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process are financed by the distribution of the surplus value extracted by capitalists from productive workers. However, the mechanism and the sizes of such distributions vary according to the organizational connections between the subsumed directors and the capitalists.

Some Type 1 subsumed classes are organized as privately owned enterprises requiring private capital investment. Merchants and bankers, for example, must in general receive a sufficient portion of the capitalists' surplus value so that what Marx termed the unproductive capital of the former receives the same average rate of profit as the productive capital of the latter.¹² Such unproductive capital outlays must earn the average rate of profit, or, failing to do so, they will cease to be made. Unless corrected by the appropriate capital flow, that eventuality might well endanger realization and thereby the capitalist fundamental class process.

Those Type 1 subsumed classes that are *not* organized in privately owned enterprises subject to the competitive flows of investible funds fare differently. They dispose of no unproductive capital; they earn no rate of profit. Rather, church, public education, police, military, and other similar administrations receive in general portions of surplus value (extracted by productive capital elsewhere) just sufficient to cover the wage, salary, and materials cost associated with their particular processes.¹³ The mechanisms for transferring surplus value to these Type 1 subsumed classes include chiefly taxation and direct contributions. Finally, those Type 1 subsumed classes directly employed by capitalists—managers of sales, advertising, personnel, etc.—require outlays for their salaries and associated materials costs. These are distributions from their employing capitalists' extracted surplus values, conceptually similar to the taxes and contributions mentioned above.

The processes directed by different Type 1 subsumed classes produce no commodities, no values, and they involve no extraction of surplus value from their direct performers. Indeed, such direct performers comprise our Type 2 subsumed class. As this typology implies, the Type 2 subsumed class occupies a position within the complex class structure of capitalism that is different from both the fundamental classes and the Type 1 subsumed classes.

Members of the Type 2 subsumed class are the actual directed performers of processes—economic, political, and cultural—which interact to overdetermine the capitalist fundamental class process. The wage and commodity costs necessary to their performance are paid for out of surplus value produced in and distributed from the capitalist fundamental class process. They may function as employees of the capitalist class itself or of the Type 1 subsumed class.

What determines their subsumed class position is not who their employer is but rather the relation between the social process they perform and the capitalist class process of extracting surplus value. The following examples of the Type 2 subsumed class derive directly from Marx (1967a: 3, *passim*) or from the discussion in this chapter:

- Salesperson employed by capitalist
- Secretary to advertising manager employed by a capitalist
- Bookkeeper employed by merchant
- Bank-teller employed by bank-owner
- Rent-collector employed by land-owner
- Maintenance worker employed by a church
- Public primary or secondary school teacher
- Local firefighter
- Cashier at retail store
- Office/clerical worker employed by public welfare agency
- Foot soldier

Productive and unproductive labor

Our interpretation of Marx's theory of classes implies a distinct perspective on the continuing discussion—clash—of conceptions of productive and unproductive labor. Within the Marxist tradition that discussion has usually been linked closely to contesting specifications of what is meant by “the working class.” Our perspective on classes and on productive and unproductive labor also involves a particular understanding of Marx's concept of working class.

Marx devoted considerable attention to the matter of productive and unproductive labor.¹⁴ He distinguished between them according to whether they were employed to produce surplus value or were not. His formal definition of productive labor is quite clear:

Productive labor is therefore—in the system of capitalist production—labor which produces *surplus-value* for its employer.

(1963: 396) (Emphasis in original.)

The result of the capitalist production process is neither a mere product (use-value) nor a *commodity*, that is, a use-value which has a certain exchange-value. Its result, its product, is the creation of surplus-value for capital.

(1963: 399, and 1977: 644) (Emphasis in original.)

What is less clear and has provoked most of the debate within the Marxist tradition is rather the substantive definition of unproductive labor and the specification of its place in the social class structure. Yet, despite some ambiguous and contrary usages there is, we believe, a definite notion of unproductive labor

developed in *Capital*, Volumes 2 and 3. Simply, unproductive labor is that which produces neither value nor surplus value. Its wages are defrayed by the transfer to it of a portion of surplus value extracted by capitalists from productive laborers.

In Volumes 2 and 3 Marx (1967a: 2, 131–32, and 3, 279, 294, 299, 383–84) devoted considerable attention to what he termed “unproductive capital”—chiefly merchants’ and money-lenders’ capital. In our terms, he analyzed two Type 1 subsumed classes who provide certain economic conditions of existence for the capitalist fundamental class process. The employees of these merchants and moneylenders—our Type 2 subsumed classes—were shown by Marx explicitly to be unproductive laborers.¹⁵

We generalize Marx’s line of argument as follows: unproductive laborers are all Type 2 subsumed classes. Such a general definition encompasses Marx’s treatment of unproductive laborers hired by merchants and moneylenders, but it also permits us to include the hired laborers providing all the other economic, political, and cultural conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process.

Now Marx himself noted the “complexly interwoven” acceptable and unacceptable definitions of productive and unproductive labor in Adam Smith and many other writers (1963: 155 ff.). In Marx, too, there are ambiguities occasioned by certain of his own departures from his own strict definitions. One of these concerns the applicability of the productive/unproductive distinction to performers of surplus labor in non-capitalist (i.e. feudal, slave, etc.) vs. capitalist fundamental class processes. He insisted that the former, while possibly producing feudal, slave, etc., commodities, have

nothing to do with the distinction between *productive and unproductive labor*... they therefore belong neither to the category of *productive* nor of *unproductive labor*, although they are producers of commodities. But their production does not fall under the capitalist mode of production.

(1963: 407) (Emphasis in original.)

Marx here wanted to limit the categories of productive/unproductive labor to *capitalist* fundamental and subsumed classes; it is a limitation he imposed repeatedly. Yet he made some well-known contrary statements also:

A singer who sells her song for her own account is an unproductive laborer.

(1963: 401)

A jobbing tailor who comes to the capitalist’s house and patches his trousers for him, produces a mere use-value for him, is an unproductive laborer.

(1963: 157 and 1967a: 2, 410)

Such singers and tailors are performing surplus labor within non-capitalist fundamental class processes. While they happen in these examples to be selling commodities, they are not commodities produced in and by a capitalist fundamental class process.

By Marx's definition, such singers and tailors could not be termed either productive or unproductive. Yet in his statements he did just that, as have other Marxists after him (Braverman 1974: 411–15). As we read Marx, such statements represent steps in his struggles with the many and varied formulations of the productive/unproductive labor distinction argued by his predecessors. They are steps which do not square with his own definitions. Marx apparently recognized this problem in noting that for his predecessors from Smith through Richard Jones the productive/unproductive labor distinction "expresses the whole difference between capitalist and non-capitalist modes of production." He immediately contrasted his own "narrow sense" standpoint:

On the other hand, the terms productive and unproductive laborers in the narrow sense [are concerned with] labor which enters into the production of commodities . . . and labor which does not enter into, and whose aim and purpose is not, the production of commodities.

(1971: 432)

The commodities Marx here refers to are capitalist commodities, products of the capitalist fundamental class process.

Our interpretation resolves the contradiction between Marx's strict definition and his "on the one hand, on the other" ambiguity. We adhere to the strict definition and restrict the term "unproductive" to Marx's "narrow sense" above, that is, to our Type 2 subsumed classes (subsumed to the capitalist fundamental class process). Laborers performing surplus labor in non-capitalist fundamental class processes and laborers subsumed to such processes are then sharply distinguished from the *unproductive* laborers subsumed to the capitalist fundamental class process. Beyond resolving the ambiguities in Marx's text, we are concerned to make this distinction to aid in the analysis of different actual and potential alliances within the working class. Different specifications of unproductive labor imply different specifications of possible alliances within the working class, as developed further below.

There is a second ambiguity in Marx's formulation which needs to be resolved. It concerns whether productive labor is to be understood from the standpoint of the capitalist employer or from the standpoint of the use made by the purchaser of the capitalist commodity produced by the laborer.

For example, the cooks and waiters in a public hotel are productive laborers, in so far as their labor is transformed into capital for the proprietors of the hotel. These same persons are unproductive laborers as menial servants, inasmuch as I do not make capital out of their services, but spend revenue on them. In fact, however, these same persons are also for me, the consumer, unproductive laborers in the hotel.

(1963: 159)

In our view Marx here was mingling two different senses of the word, "productive," and thereby inadvertently introducing some understandable confusion. As noted

earlier, Marx defines productive labor from the standpoint of its production of surplus value for its employer, regardless of the use made by those who purchase the commodities embodying that surplus value.¹⁶ It is thus a different question, and not immediately germane, whether particular commodities are purchased as elements of constant or variable capital or not. If they are purchased for such a purpose, Marx speaks of productive consumption in the sense of involvement in the future production of further surplus value. The alternative—commodities purchased for all other purposes, that is, goods and services exchanged against “revenue”—is deemed unproductive consumption. Now it is clear and fully consistent for Marx to distinguish productive from unproductive *consumptions* in this way. However, he would have violated his own concepts if he had deduced the unproductiveness of labor from the unproductive consumption of the commodities embodying that labor.

Unproductive labor and unproductive consumption are two different concepts: we deny that the one can be deduced from the other.

Our notion of Type 2 subsumed classes as unproductive laborers rectifies certain ambiguities and generalizes certain of Marx’s basic definitions. Moreover, our inclusive concept of subsumed classes permits a direct, explicit integration of the non-economic conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process under capitalism with the economic conditions (commodity circulation, credit extension, etc.) upon which Marx focused. Finally, our specification of unproductive laborers as Type 2 subsumed classes highlights their contributing role as well as their cost to the extraction of surplus value, capital accumulation, and, indeed, to the development of the capitalist social formation as a whole.¹⁷

Our connection of productive and unproductive labor to the capitalist fundamental and Type 2 subsumed classes carries an implication of two different classes as do certain of Marx’s remarks (1963: 200, 228; 1973: 468; and 1967a: 3, 491). Yet, the question posed by this usage is the relation of such classes to the general and singular notion of a “working class.”

Our approach suggests that the “working class” has to be conceived of as a variable alliance of distinct classes changing continuously through history. Within capitalist social formations, such alliances might involve the fundamental class of *productive* laborers together with the Type 2 subsumed classes of *unproductive* laborers. They might also involve the performers of surplus labor within the non-capitalist fundamental class processes present in the capitalist social formation (as well as perhaps certain of their subsumed classes). To analyze a construct such as “the working class” at any moment of a capitalist social formation amounts to an analysis of whether and what alliances existed then among the various fundamental and subsumed classes. This would be a Marxist class analysis of the structure, contradictions, and dynamic of the working class.

Our reading and development of Marx’s work on productive and unproductive labor differs sharply from other recent Marxist treatments of this issue. There are some important implications to be drawn.

One major issue in recent Marxist discussions of productive and unproductive labor concerns the connection between that distinction and some notion of the

membership of the working class. Thus Wright (1979: 48–50, 90) affirms a unity of the working class on the grounds that no “fundamentally different *class interests* at the economic level” exist between productive and unproductive labor. For Wright, both share a structurally determined (derived) interest in “constructing socialism” or a different “mode of production” from capitalism. Despite the differences between productive and unproductive labor, their common fundamental interest necessarily and always places them both in the working class. Braverman (1974: 423) also arrives at a notion that productive and unproductive laborers “form a continuous mass of employment which, at present and unlike the situation in Marx’s day, has everything in common.” In contrast to Wright, Braverman, and others (Carchedi 1977: 89–91) Poulantzas does make the productive/unproductive labor distinction serve as a “determinant of a class boundary.” Poulantzas insists that only productive workers “form part of the working class,” and that to include in the working class all wage-earners is theoretically impermissible and politically dangerous.¹⁸

The debate over the membership of the working class has actually been the context for Marxist discussions of productive and unproductive labor for some time. Sweezy (1956: 280–84) argued that unproductive laborers comprised “the so-called ‘new middle class’”; he found that there existed “an objective bond linking their fortunes with those of the ruling class.” Recent formulations among British Marxists renew the debate with minor variations on the theme. John Harrison (1975), Ian Gough and Harrison (1975), Gough (1972), Bob Rowthorn (1974), and Alan Hunt (1977) argue that finally *all* labor in the capitalist mode of production is productive because it all contributes to surplus value production albeit in different ways, direct and indirect. These different ways are deemed not to “disclose a class boundary between the working class, and some other and opposed class” (Hunt 1977: 94). Gough and Harrison admit that such a notion of productive labor is a departure—necessary, in their view—from the differentiation between productive and unproductive labor given by Marx.¹⁹

Very few of the authors prominent in the Marxist debates mentioned here devote much substantive attention to the logic and structure of the productive/unproductive distinction per se. Some, such as Sweezy and Poulantzas, adhere more or less to Marx’s definition of productive labor in order to derive from it a rather exclusive notion of the working class. Others, such as Gough and Harrison, tend to depart more or less from Marx’s definition in order to derive a relatively inclusive notion of the working class. The theoretical objective common to most Marxist writers is one sort of derivation or the other; there is no great concern to detail and explore the complex and changing relationships between productive and unproductive labor.

Our formulation of the productive/unproductive labor distinction builds from a particular reading of Marx’s texts in terms of fundamental and subsumed classes. We differ from the authors and the debate discussed above by virtue of our focus upon the distinction in detail, upon the need constantly to reassess the changing relationships between productive and unproductive laborers. More importantly, we differ in refusing to conceptualize the working class as *either* inclusive *or*

exclusive of unproductive laborers. We do not *derive* a notion of the working class from the categories of productive/unproductive labor, nor do we read Marx as proposing to do so.²⁰ Rather, to specify the working class means, to us, to specify a particular social situation in a capitalist social formation. It means to analyze the historically unique relationships among and between productive and unproductive laborers in that particular social situation. The goal of such an analysis is to determine both the actualities of and potentialities for alliances among fundamental and subsumed classes, alliances always overdetermined by the whole range of natural and social processes. Our approach does not presume that an actual historical working class comprising both productive and unproductive laborers is either necessary or impossible at any level (i.e. “immediate or fundamental” in Wright’s words). That would amount to assuming the analysis instead of producing it. It is the virtue of Marx’s distinctions between productive and unproductive labor that they provide important conceptual means for the analysis of the complex class alliances comprising all working class movements.

A second major theme in Marxist discussions of productive and unproductive labor concerns the relation of this distinction to some criterion of social usefulness of the goods and services embodying such labor. It is thus often affirmed that insofar as certain produced goods and services are judged to be unproductive or, more generally, socially wasteful, then the labor they embody is unproductive. Such affirmations probably stem from Marx’s references to “unproductive consumption” cited above. Where we read Marx as generally maintaining, despite lapses, a conceptual separation between the productiveness of labor and that of consumption, many Marxists have resolved the matter rather differently. They either use, side by side, two different concepts of (or “standpoints toward”) productive/unproductive labor, or they go so far as to make a concept of social usefulness into the final determinant of the distinction.

Ernest Mandel (1968: 191) is perhaps most explicit in his insistence that Marx’s “two standpoints” on the concepts of productive and unproductive labor “must not be confused.” He states that one standpoint refers to whether there is “production of new value” and the other refers to whether consumption of the product of such labor serves “the general interests of society.” Mandel uses the latter to distinguish productive from unproductive labor; on this particular point, we read Mandel as inconsistent with Marx’s argument. Similarly, Paul Baran has argued that notions of productive labor must be based on “independent, rational” judgments about what is “socially useful” (1957: 26). Other Marxists define such social interests more narrowly as capitalist interests in maximum capital accumulation. Then labor is productive when it produces goods and services which are productively consumed. Michael Kidron (1974: 38) concludes that “productive labor today must be defined as labor whose final output is or can be an input into further production.” Gough (1972), Harrison (1973), and Paul Bullock (1974) favor jettisoning Marx’s strict definitions; they redefine productive labor as that which produces the elements of constant and variable capital. For these writers, labor engaged in luxury and armaments production, for example, is unproductive because they deduce unproductiveness from the final use of the commodities.

The tendency to move away from Marx's basic definition of productive labor as that which produces surplus value for its employer is frequently the consequence of a particular approach to Marxist theory. That approach is essentialist. Its proponents search for and usually find one aspect of capitalist society which then functions for them as an essence, that is, the determinant of the other social aspects. For example, those for whom capital accumulation functions in this essentialist manner want to derive the productiveness of labor in terms of its relation to accumulation; the relation to accumulation (essence) determines the productiveness or not (phenomenon) of labor. Similar forms of Marxist essentialism were encountered above. For example, Wright sought to derive the working class (phenomenon) from what he terms "fundamental objective interests" (his chosen essence), while Poulantzas tended to derive the working class (phenomenon) from the productiveness of labor (essence) at the economic level (he has still other essences at his other two levels).

Essentialist modes of reasoning within the Marxist tradition have complex consequences. One of these is worth attention to underscore our difference from such reasoning generally and from its conclusions about the productive/unproductive labor distinction in particular. The overwhelming majority of the Marxist writers who have touched upon the productive/unproductive labor issue have determined that unproductive laborers in their varying definitions all exert a drag upon capitalist society's real interests (or "society's general interests" in some formulations). That is, while "necessary" to capitalism they slow accumulation and represent the costliness of capitalism's irrational necessities. Exposing this irrationality and calculating its "waste" of resources have been mainstays of Marxist critiques of capitalism for some time, as creatively exemplified in the work of Baran and Sweezy.

While we fully agree with the appropriateness of attacking capitalist deployment of resources from a Marxist critical standpoint, we think it is unacceptably one-sided (essentialist) to see unproductive labor as only a negative influence on surplus-value extraction and capital accumulation. As emphasized in our formulation of fundamental and subsumed classes, unproductive laborers perform processes indispensable to the extraction of surplus value and, hence, to the accumulation of capital. Such performance is, after all, the condition for their existence as unproductive laborers, as recipients of a share of the surplus value extracted elsewhere from productive laborers. By the same token, the unproductive labor performed is a condition of the capitalist class process of extracting surplus value in the first place. Each kind of labor, each class position (fundamental and subsumed) is necessary for the existence of the other: they are mutually constitutive and, hence, mutually determinant.

Thus, for example, the unproductive labor of a merchant's clerk (Type 2 subsumed class) requires the distribution of a share of capitalists' surplus value to merchants. However, the unproductive labor also makes possible an increased turnover rate for productive capital, that is, an increased capacity for productive capital to extract surplus value per unit of time (Marx 1967a: 2, 132). Similarly, the unproductive labor of municipal employees, say, teachers and firefighters, involves distribution of surplus value via taxation. Yet, these unproductive laborers provide certain conditions of existence for surplus value extraction.

Their contributions to productive laborers' use-value productivity and to the diminution of productive capital losses from fire both condition the extraction of surplus value.

Finally, we may consider briefly the controversial issue of luxury commodity production. Such production involves productive labor if carried on in capitalist enterprises. At the same time, the consumption of such commodities is unproductive: they do not participate as elements of constant or variable capital in the production of surplus value elsewhere in the system. However, the unproductive consumption of the luxury commodity is but one important aspect of its existence alongside another: the productive labor embodied in it. Neither aspect can or should be reduced to the other (essentialism). Both aspects will participate in shaping, for example, these laborers' consciousness and political activities, quite possibly in different or even contradictory ways. (Marx 1967a: 2, 410).

Our formulation of the productive/unproductive labor distinction in terms of fundamental and subsumed classes avoids essentialism. It provides a particular way of understanding the mutually constitutive relationship between both types of labor. Finally, it provides an approach that captures both the positive and negative aspects of the relationship or, in other words, its contradictory aspects.

Marxist class analyses

In this section we offer some brief examples of how we would use our concepts of fundamental and subsumed classes to produce Marxist class analyses. We begin with a brief discussion of the production and distribution of surplus value showing how each of these processes is a mutually constitutive moment of capital's existence. Next, we sketch analyses of certain topics chosen to illustrate our approach: state taxes, child-rearing, credit, and monopoly. Finally, we demonstrate how one of surplus value's conditions of existence, the accumulation of capital, is the site of particular complex contradictions because of the assumed existence of state taxes, child-rearers, credit, and monopolists.

The origin of surplus value resides in the capitalist consumption of the purchased commodity, labor power: "The process of the consumption of labor power is at the same time the production process of commodities and of surplus value" (Marx 1977: 279). Clearly, the conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process include the purchase of labor power, the purchase of means of production socially necessary to set the labor power in motion, the sale of the produced commodities as well as other economic and non-economic conditions.

An explanation of the capitalist fundamental class process presumes that the continuing extraction of surplus value requires the reproduction of its conditions of existence. To accomplish this, the produced surplus value must be distributed to the subsumed classes who provide these conditions. We may then summarize the relationship between the production and distribution of surplus value, the fundamental and subsumed classes, as $S = \Sigma SC$ where ΣSC refers to the total distribution of surplus value to various Type 1 and 2 subsumed classes. To specify the existence of surplus value for the capitalist is to specify its class distribution.

Thus, surplus value finds its way to capitalists insofar as they occupy subsumed class positions (also see note 21).

Now, the left-hand side of the above equation refers to the fact that the capitalist receives surplus value for doing neither any form of necessary or surplus labor nor any kind of process involved with managing, owning, expanding, lending to, or purchasing for the production process. That is precisely Marx's definition of and revolutionary insight into capitalist exploitation, that is, the capitalist fundamental class process. By definition, surplus value is a reward to the capitalist for performing no labor or condition of labor of any kind whatsoever. The moment of exploitation is that of distribution of surplus to a variety of different subsumed classes that make possible the existence of exploitation.

This formulation states that the capitalist fundamental class process is different from, but dependent upon, the processes of owning, supervising and purchasing of capital. Thus the capitalist fundamental class process can exist even if the individuals appropriating surplus value do not themselves own, supervise, or purchase capital. Other individuals, for example, capital-lenders and managers, may occupy the subsumed class positions performing these processes in a variety of forms. Alternatively, one individual may occupy all these different class positions including the fundamental one. Early capitalists typically owned their capital, lent it to themselves, personally supervised and managed the production process, and did the actual purchasing of constant and variable capital. Each of these non-class processes is a condition of existence for the capitalist fundamental class process. In our example, a share of surplus value was paid by the capitalist to himself for performing each of them. Further, our capitalist may even have performed productive labor (i.e. the coordination process) hence receiving the value of the labor power he sold to himself. By contrast, as Marx noted, the modern joint-stock corporation increasingly delegates all of these non-class processes to the subsumed class of managers (1967a: 3, 370–390 and 435–441).

We may emphasize the mutual importance of both fundamental and subsumed classes by combining some subsumed class payments into the composite category of profits while leaving others to stand by themselves:

$$S = \pi + R + i = \sum SC$$

where

S = the produced surplus value,

π = profits,

R = payments to landlords,

i = payments to providers of different forms of capital (including shareholders).

Capitalist profits π may be further subdivided into the various Type 1 and 2 subsumed class allocations: salaries of managers for supervising, taxes paid the state for providing various economic and non-economic processes, board of directors fees for directing corporate enterprises, fees to merchants for various circulation processes, payments to monopolists for access to monopolized

necessary inputs, payments to capitalists and others for providing or displaying personal conspicuous consumption (Marx's "unproductive consumption" of the capitalist),²¹ payments to child-rearers for nurturing future productive and unproductive laborers, and payments to managers or others for purchasing labor power and means of production for both simple and expanded reproduction (the accumulation of capital). Any one individual may occupy several of these subsumed class positions, thereby receiving an income composed of different payments.

In the following examples we will hold R constant in the above value equation and focus only on the constituent parts of π and on i . In particular, π will be further divided simply into subsumed class payments for purchasing means of production and labor power and those for providing a number of other economic and non-economic processes of the sort listed above. To summarize, let

$$S = \beta\pi + (1 - \beta)\pi + R + i = \sum SC$$

where $\beta\pi$ is the share of profits distributed to, say, managers, that is, those who purchase new means of production and labor power, and $(1 - \beta)\pi$ the share distributed to performers of child-rearing, of state services, and so forth. The subsumed class receiving $\beta\pi$ may utilize a portion of it for accumulating capital: $\beta\pi = \Delta C + \Delta V + Y^B$ where $\Delta C + \Delta V$ refers to the accumulation of capital, and Y^B to the salaries of this subsumed class of managers.

No social process is more important than any other: accumulation is no more or less important than, say, the supervision of capital; all are conditions of existence of the extraction of surplus value. But each process is different, and in this difference resides its unique effectivity. Only the subsumed class payment to managers for purchasing means of production and labor power (simple and/or expanded reproduction) makes available to the capitalist the commodities needed to extract surplus value. In any capitalist enterprise, the fundamental class of capitalists may also manage this purchasing. If so, they also occupy a subsumed class position and receive a share of the surplus they extracted to purchase (1) constant and variable capital and (2) their own means of consumption (see note 21). In any case, the purchase of C and V is an exchange process, not a fundamental class process. The self-expansion of capital resides in the consumption of labor power—the unique and defining function of the fundamental capitalist class.

In what follows we propose to focus on the particular non-class process of capital accumulation, but not because we think it any more essential for the existence of surplus value than other processes. On the contrary, we want to show how the state, child-rearing, etc., are as crucial, although in different ways, for the extraction of surplus value. This can best be shown by specifying clearly how these other conditions of existence of the extraction of surplus value also overdetermine the accumulation of capital, which is itself one such condition of existence. Any rise in other subsumed class payments at the expense of the process of accumulating capital constrains capitalist development in certain ways. Similarly, any rise in accumulation of capital at the expense of taxes to the state, of payments to child-rearers, etc., constrains capitalist development in different ways.

Contradictions between capital, state, and household

In any capitalist social formation the state is an institution that provides certain economic, political, and cultural processes which are conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process. State functionaries, comprising Type 1 and 2 subsumed classes, administer and carry out particular economic processes (control of money supply, regulation of commerce, maintenance of public roads, etc.) and cultural (free public education, support of research, free public libraries, etc.) and political (passing of, administering and ruling on laws, protecting property, etc.).²² These subsumed classes, and various social processes which they perform, exist on the basis of tax payments which are distributions from surplus values. In turn, these tax revenues give rise to state demands for commodities thereby affecting the markets for both labor power and materials.

Let SC_1 be total payments to the state derived from three different class sources: SC_{1a} refers to direct taxes paid to the state out of π by the fundamental capitalist class; SC_{1b} refers to direct taxes on wages of productive laborers; SC_{1c} refers to direct taxes on subsumed class income. Consider a rise in SC_1 . If taxes fall on capitalists directly, then surplus value must directly be distributed to the state. If, however, taxes fall on subsumed classes, then a portion of the surplus value initially transferred to them is now retransferred to the state. If taxes fall on productive laborers, matters are more complex.

We divide productive workers' wages, W , into two components: the value of labor power, V , and a portion of surplus value, SC_{1b} , that passes to such workers but is then transferred by them to the state in the form of taxes. Simply put: $W = V + SC_{1b}$. Here we have changed the working assumption of $W = V$ made by Marx in the discourse of *Capital*, Volume 1. This assumption, appropriate to a two-class specification, must be changed once subsumed classes comprising the state are introduced and the transfer position of productive workers is designated.

To summarize the consequences of a rise in SC_{1b} , we must allow for the divergence of the realized price from the value of labor power. Let α be the ratio of the price of labor power to its value. We then must amend the above equation for wages as follows: $W = \alpha V + SC_{1b}$ where $\alpha \geq 1$ iff $P_{1p} \geq V$.

Define:

$$\begin{aligned} P_{1p} &= \text{the price of labor power,} \\ S/V &= \text{the value rate of exploitation,} \\ S^R/P_{1p} &= \text{the realized rate of exploitation.} \end{aligned}$$

Using this new value equation and the above notation, a rise in SC_{1b} has the following consequences:

- 1 assuming V and W have not changed, the price of labor power, P_{1p} , falls initially below its value ($\alpha < 1$), thus raising the realized rate of exploitation, S^R/P_{1p} , above the unchanged value rate, S/V ;
- 2 reactions to (1) may stimulate workers to try to raise W (to offset the increased SC_{1b} and the decreased P_{1p}) thereby raising P_{1p} back up to at least V ;

- 3 if W does *not* rise sufficiently, then there is the possibility that V falls to the lower P_{lp} and consequently S/V rises to the somewhat higher realized exploitation rate.

Now, result (3) deserves further attention. We have shown that, assuming no other changes in the rate of exploitation or organic composition of capital, the accumulation of capital would *not* be reduced by as much as might be expected following the assumed rise in taxes. Indeed, if the pre- and post-tax wage (W) were the same, and if V fell eventually to the implied lower P_{lp} then the accumulation of capital would not be reduced at all; higher taxes would then have been defrayed by increased surplus value extraction.

This approach to a tax change seeks to make class sense of the different fundamental and subsumed class reactions to the implied deviations of prices (i.e. to realized class incomes) from values (i.e. from the value distribution). There is no one inevitable sequence from changes in taxes to changes in the rate of exploitation (in the distribution of income between the two fundamental classes). Productive workers would only bear the burden of higher subsumed class payments (in this example, taxes) to the degree that S^R/P_{lp} rises to offset the higher SC_{1b} . To be very clear on this important point, we mean by “burden” that a higher subsumed class payment out of capitalist extracted surplus value is at least partially defrayed by realizing more surplus in the post-tax situation by means of the reduced P_{lp} (i.e. S^R/P_{lp} has risen). Capitals are thus *realizing* sufficient extra surplus value at the lower price of labor power to pay the higher taxes without a major lowering of the accumulation of capital. In turn, only if the value of labor power falls to the lower price of labor power (or some combination of fall in V and rise in P_{lp}) can one argue that capitals have been successful in altering V in a basic, structural sense. Assuming unchanged commodity exchange values, this reduction of V must be the result of a fall in the “real wage,” that is, a changed “historical and moral element” reducing the real wage bundle of use values, thus favoring capital. Only in this sense, that is, under these particular class reactions, can capital “pass on” a subsumed class payment in a basic manner.

A rise in SC_{1a} (i.e. a tax increase on capitalists’ profits) will have none of the above effects directly. Instead, the lowered realized profit rate may lead to capitalist pressure to alter W and thus produce a reaction by productive workers. In contrast, using productive workers as transfer agents for conveying surplus value to subsumed classes seems to be a more effective way to change the rate of exploitation and thus to a degree at least postpone, if not avoid, reduced capital accumulation consequent upon a tax increase.

For each such transfer position the wage equation must be so changed: $W = \alpha V + \Sigma SC$ where ΣSC refers to various transfers of surplus value by productive laborers to state functionaries (taxes), to child-rearers (costs of rearing future productive and unproductive laborers), etc.

Child-rearers provide economic, political, and cultural processes needed to make available future sellers of labor power. Let us assume a Type 1 subsumed class of child-rearing spouses of productive laborers. Such spouses provide the

various processes of nurturing, teaching, feeding, and doctoring children within households.²³ If costs of child-rearing rise, and if W is unchanged, then capital has once again used productive labor's role as transfer agent to offset the higher claim on surplus value. The logic here parallels our example of taxes levied on productive workers' wages.

These two examples of state and household exemplify the ceaseless contradictions that comprise the relationships between and within fundamental and subsumed classes. The utilization of more surplus value to support any one of the conditions of existence of the fundamental class process jeopardizes the support of the remaining ones. This, in turn, jeopardizes the reproduction of the fundamental classes. To reproduce state functionaries and household child-rearers requires distributed shares of surplus value not then available for capital accumulation. Yet, state and household involve social processes which are conditions of existence for the extraction of surplus value upon which capital accumulation is premised. Our analysis thus shows how each social process both encourages and discourages the reproduction of capitalist exploitation.

Other contradictions between capital and subsumed classes

In recent United States history higher subsumed class payments associated with rising taxes, higher costs of raising children, rising interest rates on loans to capital and increasing monopoly prices on means of production purchased by capital seem to be especially relevant. Let us now elaborate our approach by turning to a class analysis of the latter two.

A subsumed class that lends money to a capitalist for the purchase of means of production and labor power provides a particular economic condition of existence for surplus value extraction. A rising interest rate (in the previous value equation, a change in i) for providing such a service to capital acts to distribute surplus value away from all other subsumed classes to these money-lenders. The effect upon any one of them, say, managers whose function is to purchase new capital, depends upon particular assumptions made about the different subsumed classes' reactions (tensions, struggles) to a cut in their respective payments. For example: there is no presumption that a rise (fall) in finance charges to capital (i) must inevitably reduce (increase) accumulation of capital ($\beta\pi$).

Currently, a likely strategy for capital may well be the attempted "shift" of higher subsumed class demands onto productive laborers by raising the rate of exploitation. Suppose higher costs of child-rearing exceed any rise in wages (W). In response to workers' demands for rising wages to meet, at least partially, the increased child-rearing costs, capitalists argue that such an increase is not possible because of the impact of higher costs of borrowing money upon capital accumulation. To meet the demands of increased wages *and* interest rates, they claim, would necessarily reduce capital accumulation, thereby threatening the jobs of the workers. If this strategy is successful, then capital has used one subsumed class demand (money-lenders) to lessen the impact of another (child-rearers)

upon itself. Assuming as a consequence that V does in fact fall to the lower P_{lp} then capital has raised the rate of exploitation, a higher S/V providing extra surplus value available for distribution to all subsumed classes.

Finally, let one or more individuals hold exclusive control over the access to a particular necessary means of production. For example: let the price of the i th means of production deviate from its exchange value because of this Type 1 subsumed class having a degree of monopoly power. Payments to acquire this monopolized commodity must then include a portion of surplus value, equal to the difference between the i th commodity's monopoly price and its exchange value, which will be transferred to the monopolist in return for access to the i th commodity. If such a subsumed class raises its monopoly price differential over exchange value, then there is a distribution of surplus value from all capitals purchasing the i th commodity to this subsumed class. The direct effect of this will likely be to reduce accumulation. However, the mass of surplus value has not been altered; hence, the indirect effect of this changed distribution of surplus value upon the accumulation of capital depends upon how the different recipients utilize their shares. Without further assumptions, there is no unambiguous answer.

Rising monopoly prices in consumer goods industries would have different consequences. For example, rising prices on wage goods when one or more individuals hold exclusive control over the access to a particular socially necessary means of subsistence do not involve fundamental or subsumed class processes. The logic here is similar to the case of money-lenders providing productive laborers with consumer loans. That rising consumer prices and interest charges have complex effects upon all social processes is not the issue; all processes have such effects. The processes of consumer lending and wage good monopolization are not themselves processes of extraction or distribution of surplus value. Rising monopoly prices on wage commodities generate incomes to those having the monopoly power (those with the power to enforce an unequal exchange). Such received incomes are neither subsumed nor fundamental class payments.

The state, child-rearers, money-lenders to capitalists, and monopolists controlling access to means of production demonstrate the complex class tensions, compromises, and struggles involved in the distribution of value within a capitalist social formation. Indeed, a full class analysis of these four subsumed classes would have to account for the struggles among them and show how they are cause and effect of the struggles among and between fundamental and subsumed classes. An analysis of class conflict between capital and productive labor must be completed by the analysis of conflicts among, for example, the state, household, money-lender, and monopolist to discover the complex different effects upon, that is, the overdetermination of, the accumulation of capital.

Currently, the rise in taxes, costs of rearing children, interest charges to capitalists, and monopoly prices on means of production and wage commodities have set off a number of conflicts between and among the different subsumed and fundamental classes. Suppose, for example, that productive laborers have bargained effectively for higher wages (W) in response to rising monopoly prices in consumer goods industries, higher taxes to the state, and increased costs of

raising children.²⁴ Suppose, further, that the higher W is not sufficient to cover both the latter two new subsumed class demands and the increased monopoly price differential. Thus, P_{1P} falls below V and pressures develop within the household over the domestic distribution of the paychecks as well as over tax payments to the state and payments to monopoly capitalists for needed means of subsistence. If V does indeed fall to the lowered P_{1P} , then these two increased subsumed class demands would be defrayed in part by lowering the productive workers' share out of wages. Labor may then be provoked into using its transfer agent position against capital by actually diminishing the amount paid to child-rearers. Labor may also clamor for lower taxes and lower monopoly prices on consumer goods.

One possible, although by no means necessary, result might be the emergence of a complex class alliance of certain capitalists, money-lenders, monopolists, child-rearing spouses *and* productive laborers against the state. Such an alliance might argue for a cut in taxes with the same state services or even, if necessary, a cut in services as well. Different fundamental and subsumed classes have allied against one subsumed class, state functionaries, to make them the scapegoat. Capital joins the alliance to protect its surplus value, the wage-good monopolist joins to protect its privileged, unequal exchange position, and the other subsumed classes join to protect their cuts out of surplus value at the expense of the scapegoated subsumed class (the state).

Were this alliance to force state functionaries to provide the same processes at lower costs, then capitalists would benefit most if wages (W) fell by the amount of the associated tax reduction. Or both capitalists and productive labor could *share* in what was no longer paid out of surplus value to the state (here W would fall, but by less than the fall in taxes). If, however, in response to a cut in taxes state services were cut, then one of capital's conditions of existence might be threatened. New forms of conflict, compromise, and even commodities might arise. Perhaps capital might begin to provide certain of the former state services in capitalist commodity form.

Our illustrative class analysis underscores the complexity of any category such as the working class. To make our point: if one conceives of the capitalist working class as being a complicated alliance of productive workers and Type 2 subsumed classes, then what we have shown as a conflict over taxes could easily form a barrier to the formation of such a working class. Indeed, the object working class is as much a source of conflict, struggle, and compromise as is a scheme of taxes or any other object in the social formation.

Class struggle

What is class struggle? Perhaps no other question in Marxism has been as theoretically and politically important. Indeed, different answers often define the broad boundaries of different Marxist approaches. This is not surprising since the Marxist tradition has been the site of debate and struggle over dissimilar notions of class and class struggle. Moreover, different political objectives and strategies

are usually involved in the debates. Thus, we conclude our interpretation of the Marxist theory of class with our particular understanding of class struggles.

For us, Marxist theory begins with the notions of the fundamental class process and contradiction. It aims to deploy and build upon these two concepts toward an elaborated conceptualization of the contradictoriness of fundamental and subsumed classes. The elaboration, in turn, seeks to pinpoint exactly the possible class alliances and struggles that may emerge in the social formation being theorized. Such alliances and struggles are understood to be mechanisms of any possible revolutionary transition to a different social formation. We therefore use the words “class process” and “contradiction” as key concepts in producing both a Marxist theory of, and interventions in, class struggles.

We conceive each and every class and non-class process of the social formation to be in a process of contradictory change. The word “overdetermination” means precisely this: that each social process only exists, only “is,” as the locus of effects of all other social processes similarly constituted. Any particular social process, then, is the overdetermined result (site) of all these influences; further, each constituent influence propels the social process in different (contradictory) directions. Thus, to specify any process in this way is to specify the complex contradictions that constitute its very existence and, by logical extension, its complex influences upon all other processes.

The fundamental and subsumed class processes in any social formation define the different class positions occupied by individuals. These class processes and positions are conceived to exist as the combined effect of all other social processes. Overdetermined in this way, each class position is constituted to be in tension, movement, and change. The tension and change are produced by these interacting effects constituting the complex contradictions of both the fundamental and subsumed class positions. As a result, any individual occupying one or more class positions is understood to be subject to, partly constituted by, the contradictions and changes characterizing such positions.²⁵

Our discussion of Marxist value equations above demonstrated the contradictory relation of the appropriation and distribution of surplus value: to appropriate surplus value is to distribute it to subsumed classes. It follows that fundamental and subsumed classes condition each other’s existence and the behavior of each toward the other. Surplus value extraction is then conceived as the site of particular contradictions (e.g. among and between capitalists and productive laborers) resulting from its overdetermination by the subsumed class process and all other non-class processes in the social formation. The subsumed class process is comparably understood as the site of its particular contradictions (e.g. among and between capitalists and both Type 1 and Type 2 subsumed classes).

Struggle emerges out of the changes in any social process as a moment of that process. We use the notion of struggle or conflict to refer to a particular moment or conjuncture in which the overdetermined contradictions embedded in social processes have fused to motivate intense collective effort to change the process in question. Class struggle is struggle over the class process; the adjective “class” refers to the object of the struggle, namely, the fundamental and/or subsumed

class processes. The goal of class struggles may involve quantitative and/or qualitative changes in the extraction and/or distribution of surplus labor. For example, *capitalist* fundamental class struggles may focus on a quantitative change in the extraction of surplus value, say, by altering the length of the working day and/or the wage rate. Alternatively, such a struggle may focus on a qualitative change in the form of extracting surplus labor, say, a change from the capitalist to a different fundamental class process.²⁶

Conceived in this way, struggle between and among individuals holding various fundamental and subsumed class positions is always a possibility, but never an inevitability. For example, to specify the capitalist fundamental class process is to specify a tension and contradictory relation between the capitalists and productive laborers over the length of the working day, etc. The conflicting aims and behaviors of the different class occupants may or may not result in a class struggle. Indeed, it is a continuing objective of Marxism to assess the continually changing social formation to see whether such a possibility exists and to show its particular features in order to draw strategic conclusions.

We reserve the notion of class struggles, then, to specify struggles over either the processes of surplus labor extraction or surplus labor distribution. Non-class struggles refer to objects of struggle within all social processes (economic, political, cultural, etc.) other than the fundamental or subsumed class processes. These non-class processes also define non-class positions which individuals occupy in varying patterns. In summary, struggles in and over any social process will, in any case, involve individuals who occupy a variety of class and non-class positions.

It follows that the object of any struggle (class or otherwise) cannot serve as a sufficient condition to determine the class positions of the individuals struggling. A person's class position is defined by his/her participation in class processes, not by the attitude of such individuals toward struggles within the class or non-class processes occurring within the social formation. By the same logic, a person's attitude toward class struggle is overdetermined and thus not reducible to his/her class position. For example: one side of a religious struggle may be individuals occupying a fundamental class position of extractors of surplus labor while on the other side are other individuals who occupy this fundamental class position but have a conflicting religious position. In this example, those who share a common class position do not share a common religious (i.e. non-class) position. This split in the ranks of surplus labor extractors may well be matched by splits in the ranks of performers of surplus labor, subsumed classes, etc. Various splits will typically characterize struggles in and over any social process, *including* the fundamental and subsumed class processes themselves. It is, of course, possible that all individuals holding a common class position may also hold a common non-class position, say, within a religious process as in the example above. However, this is but one of an infinity of possible alignments.

We wish to emphasize that struggles over conditions of existence of surplus labor extraction are *not* equivalent to or necessarily productive of struggle over that extraction. For example, the struggle over processes of schooling among administrators, teachers, and students, and the struggle over the distribution of

surplus value between capitalists and their bankers have differential effectivities on the fundamental class process. In different ways both struggles change the fundamental class process. But such struggles and their respective effects may or may not contribute to a fundamental class struggle; no necessity is involved. Whether such a contributing or causal relation occurs depends on all the other social processes (in struggle or not) which together overdetermine the fundamental class process.

Finally, our approach serves to underscore the central point that Marxist notions of class struggle refer to struggle in and over two different class processes: fundamental and subsumed. Even if there were no struggle over the extraction of surplus labor, there still might be subsumed class struggles which might contribute to the condition necessary to set in motion fundamental class struggles. In any capitalist social formation at any moment of its development, the absence of any struggle over extraction of surplus labor may coincide with the presence of significant subsumed class struggles. To ignore subsumed class struggles, theoretically and/or politically, is to miss this opportunity for social change.

6 Power, property, and class

Among Marxists and non-Marxists alike, the term “class” appears often within their analyses of society. By itself or with adjectives such as “working,” “ruling,” “under-,” or “capitalist,” the term is clearly central to most Marxist and not a few non-Marxist arguments about social structure and social change. Yet reviewing those arguments yields a curious problem. The meanings assigned to the term are definitely not the same. Moreover, debates over many topics other than class per se can be seen to stem largely from disagreements—infrequently acknowledged as such—over what class is.

We share with many a central focus upon class as an indispensable concept for analyzing society. Thus the multiplicity of concepts of class inside and outside the Marxist tradition poses problems. Are there some concepts of class that prevail over others within Marxist literature? Are there criteria for preferring theoretically one against another of such concepts? We think that these questions demand answers. Otherwise, class analyses will continue to display inconsistent and often confused usages of one of their most central terms.

We intend to show that there are some basically different concepts of class at play in Marxist writings. We believe that a writer’s choice, whether conscious or not, of one such concept rather than another will lead him or her to correspondingly different theoretical and political conclusions. In other words, it matters which concept of class is used to make sense of social structures and strategies for social change. We will cite examples where largely unexamined commitments to particular concepts of class have played major roles in shaping key theoretical and political struggles waged by and also within the Marxist tradition. We intend an intervention in that tradition which will clarify its usages of class and also reestablish the importance of one particular conception: the surplus labor theory of class.

An analyst can group persons within a community or society according to any one of a literally infinite number of possible characteristics. A group, or “class” in this abstract sense, could be conceptualized as all persons sharing a common muscular build, bone structure, vocal tone, athletic prowess, skill at various functions, degree of religious or secular education, level of prestige or wealth, or any other possible characteristic. Grouping people in such ways has been a hallmark of most sorts of social analysis including those called “class” analyses. Often

other terms for similar kinds of grouping—strata, elites, fractions, sections—are woven into analyses also utilizing class.

Class in particular has long been a term narrowed by actual usage to designate a few specific kinds of groupings.¹ Especially since the eighteenth century, there have been three rather distinct groupings meant by the term class. Class is sometimes used to designate groups of persons in society according to the property they do or do not own. Varying qualities and/or quantities of property are used to categorize persons into classes. A second and different usage holds class to mean a group of persons who share the fact that they either do or do not wield power or authority in society.² Different kinds and amounts of social authority are here understood to define class boundaries. Third, there is a notion of class as concerning the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor (defined and discussed below). Classes are then defined as groups of persons who share the common social position of performing surplus labor or of appropriating it from the performers or of obtaining distributed shares of surplus from the appropriators.³

A fourth kind of approach amounts to composite conceptualizations of class: various mixtures of the basic three notions. These involve defining class in terms of power *and* property or surplus labor production *and* property or all three together. For example, one such composite approach conceives of the capitalist class structure as “a system rooted in a dichotomy between possessing masters and subject dispossessed.”⁴ Writings in the Marxist tradition often signal composite conceptualizations by defining classes as persons who share common positions in or connections to the “relations of production” or “mode of production.” Upon inspection, classes defined in terms of relations of production usually turn out to be composites whose authors variously emphasize the power, property, or surplus-labor components of such relations of production (classes).

In singular or composite definitions, the three distinct concepts of class—qua property, power, and/or surplus labor—prevail both within and without the Marxian tradition. However, they are irreducibly different and not to be conflated. Persons with property may or may not also wield power and vice versa. To own property in a particular society need not empower the owner to employ another human being or to participate in state decisions; that would depend, for example, on ideological and political conditions in that society. To be propertyless need not require a person to sell labor power; that would depend, for example, on whether propertyless persons had socially recognized access to income from other sources. To wield state powers of all sorts need not require ownership of property; that would depend on the social rules whereby power is granted to individuals. In sum, the ownership of property (whether in means of production or more generally) is neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition for the wielding of power and vice versa.

Class analyses using one definition will yield different results from analyses using another. No little political importance attaches to this conundrum. Moreover, as we shall show, class designations according to surplus labor production/distribution will not necessarily correspond to the class designations

drawn according to either the property or the power concepts. Usages of class that do not recognize and address these differences invite all manner of misunderstandings.

In our view, distributions of property and power have long been social conditions used to define class. Radicals and conservatives among the ancient Greeks classified persons according to the property they owned and attributed great analytical significance to such classes. Conceptualizations of class in terms of property ownership have recurred periodically ever since. Similarly, concepts of class defined by the qualities and quantities of power wielded by social groupings are endemic through the literature for centuries. However, the concept of class as surplus labor has a special relation to Marx.

Marx conceived of class in a unique manner as the production and distribution of surplus labor. Of course, Marx was aware of and deeply impressed with the early class-analytical literature. His work is filled with allusions to classes in terms of property and power. However, he was also sharply critical of his predecessor class analysts' concepts on the grounds that they had missed something crucial to the success of their—and his—goals for a more just and free society. They had underestimated or missed altogether the economic process of surplus labor production and distribution. By missed, Marx meant that their analyses of contemporary society overlooked the structural position of the surplus labor process. Thus, in his view, their projections of strategies for social change inadequately addressed the changes in the surplus labor process needed to sustain the anticipated socialist or communist society.

Marx's goal was never to deny or displace the importance of property and power in the structure of contemporary society or in the plans for the sort of socialist society he longed for. Rather, he sought to add something to the understanding of his fellow revolutionists and radicals, namely a worked-through grasp of the surplus labor process and the ways in which it both supported and depended upon the processes of property and power (among the other social processes that concerned him).⁵

A few examples may clarify the important implications of these different concepts of class. Consider the debates over the class structure of the Soviet Union. On one side the argument is advanced that it represents a classless society because private property was abolished there. Defenders of this view operate with a property concept of class. Opponents often do likewise with the more subtle argument that what was abolished was merely *de jure* private property while *de facto* it still persists in the USSR and hence so do classes. Similarly, social-democrats around the world frequently equate socialism or the transition from capitalism to socialism, with the socialization of property in the means of production; again concepts of class qua patterns of property ownership figure significantly.

More prevalent in recent debates over the Soviet Union's class structure has been argumentation deploying power rather than property concepts of class. Such formulations often attack the property theorists of class by claims that notwithstanding the socialization of private property, a ruling class still exists in the

USSR. These are then demonstrated by reference to patterns of power and authority there. The term class is ascribed to groupings found to possess and wield more or fewer quanta of power regardless of who owns or is separated from property.

The debates over the USSR's class structure teach that not only are different concepts of class at play (with an array of variations, of course) but also that the same argument often contains confused and confusing mixtures of these concepts. Further, the debates' focus on property and power leads those on all sides to play down or ignore what we understand as class: the processes of producing, appropriating, and distributing surplus labor in the USSR. Our interest here is not to deny the importance of property and power to any assessment of the USSR, but rather to correct a defect typical of most assessments, namely their neglect of the surplus labor type of class analytics. Which alternative conceptualization of class is used affects an individual's political practices in regard to the USSR: a potent political issue since 1917.

As a second example, consider the attraction of Marxists to the social analysis of what are usually called the "middle classes" in capitalist societies. Do they really exist between the two main classes? Are they friends or foes of the working class or might they go either way depending upon circumstances? How do we properly allocate those who do not fall neatly into either main class into the various possible categorizations of middle class? To answer such questions, Marxists and others have deployed class analytics which again demonstrate their prevalent commitment to discussions limited to matters of property and power.

In general, most Marxist treatments start from a dissatisfaction with the typical dichotomous class model ascribed to Marxism. They decry efforts to collapse a complex class structure into a bipolar confrontation. Often taking a cue from Marx's distinction between bourgeoisie and petite bourgeoisie, notably a quantitative distinction, they seek to show how gradations beyond a mere two can admit of middle classes. Does the notion of a petite bourgeoisie refer to the smallness of the quantity of means of production owned? Are middle classes then persons situated somewhere between propertylessness and some large quantum of means of production whose owner is considered to be a bourgeois? Much debate based on such conceptions of middle classes has drawn sharply opposed conclusions regarding whether and how working classes can approach such middle classes in terms of class-struggle alliances.

On the other hand, class-as-power theorists frequently oppose the property theorists; they rather favor investigating the power/authority nexus. Can we locate persons who are neither pure order-givers nor pure order-takers, neither ruling nor ruled classes? Are there such middle classes who take as well as give orders, and if so, who exactly are they and how do they figure into class struggles? From these theoretical roots has sprouted an ingenious sequence of analyses of complex, non-dichotomous class structures. Not a few theorists combine, sometimes explicitly, both property and power to generate matrices of multiple and complex classes. Again, different proposals for political actions and alliances flow from power than from property analyses of middle classes.

While we share the desire to move beyond the sterility of simple two-class models of social structure, we regret that there has been relatively little theoretical movement beyond the old concepts of class as property and/or power. Our goal is to elaborate Marx's beginnings in constructing class groupings in terms of how persons perform, appropriate, or receive distributed shares of surplus labor. Thus, if performers and appropriators of surplus labor comprise two classes of society, then another sort of class is defined in terms of the recipients of distributed shares of the appropriated surplus labor. "Middle" is then certainly not an appropriate adjective since it precisely suggests a class location in the space between two others, a location that makes much less sense in our approach.⁶

The problem of reductionism

The discussion of class is beset not only by different and often clashing definitions of class. There is also a major problem of how to theorize the relationship between class and non-class aspects of society. Some authors reduce their particular definition of class to an effect of other, more fundamental aspects of society. Others, equally reductionist, reverse the argument and make their notion of class into the key cause while the rest of society is reduced to its effect. Much of the Marxist tradition has been understood to argue reductively that class structure ("the base") determines social structure ("the superstructure") and class struggle determines historical change. Indeed, many debates in and over the Marxist tradition have turned precisely over whether the economy determines the society (economic determinism or reductionism) or whether the economy is itself determined by/reduced to the effect of other social aspects (e.g. the political, the cultural, or the natural).

We find this reductionism to be problematic because of its a priori presumption that some causes must outweigh others in determining an effect. Reductionism has, in our view, contributed to disastrous theoretical and political consequences as changes in one social factor—the presumed "most effective cause"—have been expected to usher in all manner of necessary effects which never materialized.

In any case, whether reductionism is acceptable or not, it is certainly not the only way to theorize the relationship between class and non-class aspects of society. It can be replaced analytically by a non-reductionist perspective. Class, however defined, can be understood as the effect of many different social aspects with none of them playing the role of "most fundamental" determinant. Similarly, class can also be understood as itself a cause affecting all the other aspects of society. The stress here is upon class as one among many causes of social structure and history; it need not be seen reductively as *the* cause. Social aspects, then, may all be approached as necessarily both causes and effects at the same time.⁷

Our point here is to emphasize that discussions of class can and do vary in two major ways. They display different definitions of class. They also differ on whether to link class and non-class aspects of society reductively or not, in a relation of determinism or overdetermination. Our critique of the prevalent Marxist and non-Marxist treatments of class takes them to task on both counts: (1) for their definitions of class

as power and/or property concepts, and (2) for their reductionism. Our alternative below reflects this critique.

A non- or anti-reductionist approach to class eschews in principle the analytical search for last, final, or ultimate causes or determinants. Hence it can never find class or any other social aspect to be such a cause. Instead, the goal is to explore the complex way in which a chosen set of social aspects interrelate as simultaneous causes and effects. Marxists can then choose, for diverse reasons, to explore sets that include class without this implying any reductionist conception of class either as *the* determinant cause or as the effect of something else designated as such a determinant cause. Notwithstanding pronouncements in favor of complex conceptions of causality, reductionist celebrations of “key explanatory variables” dominate discussions of class. Thus, a property theorist of class will likely make power and surplus labor mere effects of property distributions. A power theorist will reply that property distributions and the structure of surplus labor production are necessary consequences of particular power relations. Finally, the class-as-surplus-labor theorist can insist that allocations of power and property follow from individuals’ different relationships to the production and appropriation of surplus labor. These three groups are thus locked into a debate over whether class, as each defines it, is key cause or mere effect.

There are also more subtle kinds of reductionism found particularly in Marxist discussions of class. They occur in conceptualizations of class as a composite entity composed of economic, political, and cultural constituents. Indeed, such composite conceptualizations often emerge as critical reactions against uni-dimensional concepts of class as either power, property, or surplus labor groupings. The reductionism surfaces in arguments among proponents of such composite theories over which aspect of class is “the most fundamental” in determining that a class exists (rather than merely a group of persons).

One example of this is the influential formulation of the distinction between class “in itself” and class “for itself.” The former is thought to be structurally defined in terms of power, property, surplus labor, etc. The latter is defined as the former plus an element of self-consciousness: class for itself as an ideological (cultural) as well as economic and political entity. Classes, in effect, are defined to exist at two levels, one more complete than the other. Proponents of such formulations have often been reductionist in them, striving to make consciousness the key determinant of class in the second and fuller sense.⁸

The prevalent forms of class analysis

Our brief overview of the most prevalent forms of class analysis requires several preliminary observations. First, writers and texts are rarely pure exponents of one conception of class. They typically exhibit more than one. Thus, when we cite an author to exemplify one conception, we do not mean to imply that he or she never formulated another view of class. Second, this is far from a complete or exhaustive literature review; we range broadly across the literature to cull typical examples of the most prevalent formulations. Finally, our survey divides these

formulations into three types: conceptions of class as property, as power, and as a complex composite entity of several different elements. We begin with illustrations of the property approach.

A well known and influential recent study of the links between Marxist and feminist analyses asserts that “a Marxist definition of class rests on relationship to ownership of the means of production.”⁹ Indeed, innumerable Marxist texts for a hundred years contain virtual identifications of class structure with property distribution. In a famous article Paul Sweezy posed the following basic question: “What is it that determines how many classes there are and where the dividing lines are drawn?” He responded directly and precisely: “Generally speaking, the answer is obvious (and is borne out by all empirical investigations): the property system plays this key role.”¹⁰ Thinkers as diverse as Oskar Lange, Ralf Dahrendorf, C. Wright Mills, Anthony Giddens, Robert Lekachman, and E. B. Pashunakis made clear statements defining class quite strictly and narrowly in terms of property ownership.¹¹

One of the most thorough and theoretically self-conscious explorations of a property concept of class occurs in the recent work of Paul Hirst and Barry Hindess. In several books, they develop, correct, and elaborate “concepts of possession and separation from the means of production... central to the analysis of economic classes.”¹² The property theory of class also appears in some variant forms. One of the most widespread shifts the definition of class away from ownership or separation from the means of production to more general differentiations either between wealth and poverty (“rich” and “poor” classes) or between high and low incomes (non-wage vs. wage earners). In particular, the latter criterion of class—as a matter of one’s position in the hierarchy of income levels—is very widely used in both Marxist and non-Marxist discussions. Expressions such as “the class of poor people” or “middle class” or “wage-earning class” or “the rich” denote a theory allocating individuals to classes according to either the size or type of their current income/asset positions.¹³ In any case, whether “property” referred to means of production, wealth in stocks of commodities, or levels of income flows, most interpreters have attributed such property theories of class to Marx. He was understood to conceive such classes as prone to struggles for redistributions of property and/or income. These struggles functioned as the “motor” of social change historically. As we shall argue, ours is a very different interpretation of Marx on class.

Instead of defining class in terms of property, it may be conceived as a matter of wielding power over persons, controlling other people’s behavior. Groups of persons are then treated as classes to the extent that they share a common status as either wielders of power or subject to the power of others. The social distribution of authority defines class positions. The adjectives that usually signal the presence of power theories of class are “ruling” vs. “ruled” or “dominant” vs. “dominated.” Class struggles then become struggles over power, especially though not exclusively state power. The powerless classes struggle to acquire power while their adversaries struggle to retain or expand their power.

Non-Marxists have long been particularly interested in affirming pointedly political concepts of class which they often distance sharply from property

concepts which they ascribe to Marx and Marxists. A canon of such interpretation is, for example, Gaetano Mosca's view of class analysis as a specifically political science focused on the issue of who rules whom.¹⁴ C. Wright Mills oriented many in the United States with a class analysis summarized in his famous term and 1956 book title, *The Power Elite*. Ralf Dahrendorf offers a particularly clear formulation which directly confronts alternative notions of class:

But Marx believed that authority and power are factors which can be traced back to a man's share in effective private property [ownership]. In reality, the opposite is the case. Power and authority are irreducible factors from which the social relations associated with legal private property as well as those associated with communal property can be derived.¹⁵

Here Dahrendorf moves from a rejection of the property notion of class to a general theory of classes as constituted in and through power struggles per se. Whenever people associate into groups to contend against other groups over any particular objective(s), these groups are classes. "If, in a given society, there are fifty associations, we should expect to find a hundred classes, or conflict groups in the sense of the present study."¹⁶ Dahrendorf reduces property distribution to an effect of power and authority relations.

Many Marxist theorists have recently moved toward a kind of political conception of class not far removed from Dahrendorf's approach. One stimulus has been a feeling that particularly in Western capitalist nations, a broadly comfortable "middle income class" has made issues of income and wealth less urgent and less central than issues of inequitable power distributions. Thus activist and analytical focus shifted from struggles over property to struggles over power and its social distribution. Property seems to have given way to power—in the home, at the workplace, in the state—as the cutting edge of social struggles animating socialists and thus Marxist theorists.

Another motivation toward a power theory of class among Marxists has come from their conclusion that classlessness and its rewards did not appear in societies that nationalized or socialized ownership in the means of production. Rather intolerable power distributions—if not property distributions—were seen to remain in such societies. This interpretation connects to the critique of capitalist society which attacks its property allocation but even more its unjust distributions of power and authority. Marx's writings are then probed for analyses of classes as groups which either possess or are separated from power over the social behavior of others (or Marx is faulted, as in Dahrendorf, for insufficient attention to power). In any case, analytical focus shifts toward comprehending social dynamics increasingly in terms of power centers, more or less understood as ruling classes, counterposed to relatively powerless and dominated classes.

Groups of distinctly powerless persons move to the center of Marxist analyses. General concepts such as oppression, which function in terms of powerful/powerless dichotomies, or more specific concepts such as patriarchy, which build upon a gender distribution of social power, then prevail in Marxist discussions.

Ernesto Laclau endorses "the Marxist conception of classes according to which they constitute themselves through the act of struggle itself."¹⁷ Struggle between social groups implies dispute over objectives; one group contests with another to attain their different objectives in some specific social context. Struggle is first of all a matter of power. Which struggling group of persons wins its objectives depends on their relative power positions in that society at that time. To define classes in terms of actual social struggles amounts to a form of the power conception of class.

This is significantly different from the non-Marxist power theorists such as Dahrendorf. Where the latter make the structural allocation of power the definition of class, Marxists such as Laclau argue that classes do not pre-exist actual struggles over social issues. Classes are rather the social entities constituted by and in the process of actual struggles; they are "effects of struggles." Bob Jessop and Adam Przeworski work with similar formulations: "class struggle is first of all a struggle about the formation of class forces before it is a struggle between class forces."¹⁸ Jessop arrived at such a formulation by rejecting what he saw as the unacceptable Marxist tendency to reduce complex social power struggles to mere effects of class understood in property or surplus labor terms. Marxists, he reasons, need to overcome their denigration of power and produce social analyses that integrate class and non-class relationships. In seeking to right the analytical balance which he thinks is tipped too far towards property concepts, Jessop stresses power.¹⁹

Not surprisingly, the theoretical pendulum that swings from property to power concepts of class soon provokes the reverse movement. Alex Callinicos criticizes the theoretical move toward a focus on power as a departure from Marxism which he sees as properly oriented elsewhere, chiefly on property (the social distribution of means of production) and also on surplus labor production.²⁰ His reaction against analyses of class qua power/domination/ subordination propels him to reaffirm a concept of class as primarily property and secondarily surplus labor production. Another sort of pendulum swing runs from the non-Marxists A. A. Berle, Jr and Gardiner Means to the Marxists Paul A. Baran and Paul M. Sweezy. The former saw modern capitalists as defined no longer by property but rather by power: business-owners replaced by non-owning corporate executives.²¹ The latter reacted by declaring that "far from being a separate class, they [corporate managers] constitute in reality the leading echelon of the property-owning class"; for them property and power are indissolubly linked in the definition of class.²²

Besides the theorizations of class that define the term quite straightforwardly in terms either of property or power, there are what might best be described as complex, multi-dimensional conceptions of class. These conceptions insist that class cannot be defined simply as either a property, a power, or even a surplus labor matter. Rather, class is celebrated as a specific but complex social phenomenon with several component elements: class becomes a composite term to denote part or even all of "the social relations of production."²³ Composite conceptions of class are sometimes attributed to Marx and sometimes offered instead as improvements on a narrow, uni-dimensional concept attributed to him.

Many who prefer composite concepts of class not only criticize the narrow conceptions as inadequate, they also differ among themselves about which among

the component elements of class are the most important. They disagree about which component to emphasize as the key element of class. Interestingly, most of such writers favor either power or property as the chief components of class. Then there are some who emphasize still other components of their composite concepts of class as the most important.

For example, Nicos Poulantzas has made major contributions to Marxian class analytics, summarized in the rich and condensed "Introduction" to his *Classes in Contemporary Capitalism*.²⁴ Poulantzas there advances arguments involving several definitions of class. His is certainly a composite conceptualization. He gives a special place and emphasis to ownership of the means of production. He also writes of "the decisive role of the division between manual labour and mental labour in the determination of social classes." And he devotes much attention to relations of "domination/subordination" in constituting classes as well. Despite the coexistence in his work of such different conceptualizations, it displays a clear movement toward power becoming the dominant component of class.

Poulantzas' work represents a move away from property and narrowly economic concepts of class toward power concepts. In his distinction between class places (given by the social structure) and class positions (given by conjunctural struggles in a society), what is most striking is the centrality of the concept of domination/subordination to both place and position. Classes in his sense of class places exist at three social levels: the economic, political, and ideological. At each level, Poulantzas juxtaposes a dominant and a dominated group, that is, classes. At the economic level, the dominant are exploiters while the dominated are exploited; this is his acknowledgment of the economic (surplus labor) aspect of class. At the other levels he cites domination and subordination—in terms of political control and ideological influence—as the contrasts defining class places. Actually classes then would appear to be defined by reference necessarily to all three levels.

Now what all levels have in common is precisely not property dimensions nor dimensions in terms of the production or distribution of surplus labor. They all share the dichotomy of domination/subordination, a concept of power among persons. Poulantzas' prevalent notion of class places thus centers on powerful/powerless differentiations. In this sense, his is a power theory of class. When he turns to an analysis of class positions—the actual sides taken in what he calls "conjunctural struggles"—he emphasizes that persons in one class place can and do often take positions in social struggles that do not "correspond to its interests." The key point here is Poulantzas' evident determination to call the sides taken in social conflicts—power struggles—class positions, that is, classes in the sense developed further by Laclau, Jessop, and Przeworski. Poulantzas' theory of class places and class positions raises concepts of power above those of property or surplus labor as most central and basic to class analysis.²⁵

Another Marxist approach to class as a complex composite is typified by E. P. Thompson's *The Making of the English Working Class*. This work inspires and serves as a model for many Marxists precisely because it succeeds in presenting the interplay among economic, political, and cultural processes which combined to create (or "overdetermine") the English working class. Thompson's

work involves his strong desire to escape the simple, economistic definitions of class which, in his view, mar the Marxist tradition. Thus, his emphasis shifts rather to the consciousness component of his complex notion of class: "Class is defined by men as they live their own history, and, in the end, this is its only definition."²⁶ The shift of emphasis in Thompson's composite view of class becomes a reductionism: class is only finally historically real and effective when its key constituent element, class consciousness, has been fashioned. Of all the components of class, consciousness is the most important, at least from the standpoint of concrete historical class relations.

Another composite conceptualization of class is carefully crafted to include property, power, and surplus labor appropriation and yet also to reduce the composite to its political component: power. "Class relations are forms of domination involving the expropriation of surplus labor time through the operation of property relations in the means of production."²⁷ In this statement, the essential social force has become interpersonal relations of domination; these are understood to shape social structure and change. A critique of economic determinism propels its proponents to a political (power or domination relations) determinism instead. For Bowles and Gintis, class is certainly a composite relation of production involving power, ideology, and economics in the narrow sense of surplus labor appropriation. However, they proceed to reduce the extraction of surplus labor itself to an effect of power. They reason that after the economic process of buying labor power is completed, the capitalist still must exert effective power in order to obtain surplus labor. For them, power is the essence of class, its determining component.²⁸

One kind of composite conceptualization of class that has drawn increasing attention recently focuses upon the division of labor between mental and manual exertion. Such theorizations typically see in modern science and technology a major component of class definitions and distinctions. The French upheavals of 1968 spawned a host of reformulations of class in terms that combined older criteria (property, power, etc.) with a special emphasis upon science and technology in shaping what were understood as class divisions between manual and mental labor.²⁹ Interestingly, dissident theorists in Eastern Europe seem also to attach importance and even an ultimately determinant role to mental/manual labor divisions as the key components of classes. In Rudolf Bahro's view,

If the classes bound up with private property are destroyed or rendered impotent, the earlier element of the division of mental and manual labour emerges once again as an autonomous factor of class formation.³⁰

As noted, among the theories of class as a composite entity many include surplus labor production as one component. Some even make the extraction of surplus labor the most important and determining of the several elements that define class. An exemplary formulation is the following:

Marx's emphasis on consciousness and community clearly suggests, therefore, a complex rather than uni-dimensional theory of class. Class is never

a single homogeneous structure, but rather a cluster of groups.... Thus the ruling class is never a simple homogeneous whole, but consists of contradictory elements—the representatives of heavy industry and light industry, finance capitalists—although the whole, the unity of the various competing elements, is held together by one overriding interest, the exploitation of labor power.³¹

What is striking about the theorizations of class as a composite entity is the prevalent tendency to establish a most important or ultimately determinant element within class. Class is many things of which one is the dominant element. It is usually property or power, which is not surprising given the widespread conceptualizations of class as uni-dimensionally property or power. In general then, the prevalent theories of class either define it narrowly as a matter of property or power distribution or more broadly as a composite of several elements within which power or property are the ultimate determinants. There are relatively few exceptions to this prevalence in either Marxist or non-Marxist literature (although, as noted, many Marxists include and some emphasize surplus labor appropriation in their conceptualization of class.)

An alternative and non-reductionist concept of class

An alternative concept of class, derived from Marx, may be distinguished along two dimensions. We understand class to be defined narrowly in terms of the specific processes of producing and distributing surplus labor. Second, we understand class to be neither reduced to an effect of any non-class aspect of society, nor are any non-class aspects reducible to the mere effects of class defined in surplus labor terms.

Since our reading of Marx and the specific concept of class we find there has been presented exhaustively elsewhere, only a brief summary is appropriate here.³² We use the word class to mean a very particular economic process: the production of surplus labor. In all human societies, some people directly produce goods and services. Part of what they produce they also consume: we follow Marx in labeling this consumed portion the fruit of the *necessary labor* of the direct producers. However, these direct producers also perform labor beyond this necessary amount: the surplus labor. The process of performing or producing this surplus labor is what we mean by class: the class process.

What is necessary labor in any society at any particular time depends on the entirety of that society's history to that time. It is a quantity complexly determined and in no way reducible to any physical or subsistence minimum. Moreover, the existence of a surplus labor production process raises immediately the questions of how much surplus labor is performed, who appropriates its fruits, and how they are further distributed throughout the society. The production and appropriation of surplus labor are two sides of the class process. A human being can function on one or the other or both sides; he or she may produce or appropriate surplus

labor or do both. The class process defines, thus, two different class positions: performer and appropriator of surplus labor.

This leaves the question of the distribution of surplus labor's fruits from its appropriators to other persons. This is itself a distinct social process: the distribution of already appropriated surplus labor (or its fruits). Although different from the production/appropriation of surplus labor, it is closely related.

We may say that there are two kinds of class processes. The first or what we term the fundamental class process is the production/appropriation of surplus labor. It defines two fundamental classes: producers and appropriators. The second, which we call the subsumed class process, refers to the distribution of surplus labor from its appropriators to others. It defines two subsumed classes: distributors and recipients of surplus labor. Any individual may occupy all, none, or any combination of these class positions. Class analysis is precisely the effort to think about society by focusing upon which people occupy which class positions and with what social effects.

The appropriators distribute the surplus labor (or its fruits) to persons who perform other (non-class) social processes without which the production/appropriation of surplus labor would be jeopardized or not occur at all. That is, for direct producers to perform surplus labor, a great many other processes must be in place. Cultural, political, natural, and economic processes of all sorts literally create the conditions for, that is, bring into existence, the fundamental class process. However, for many of these conditions to occur requires human labor, and this human labor needs to be sustained. It is sustained precisely by means of distributions to it of surplus labor appropriated from the direct producers.

Subsumed classes are those people who do not produce or appropriate surplus labor, but rather live by providing the conditions of existence for the production/appropriation of surplus labor. Fundamental and subsumed class processes thus require each other if each is to continue to exist, if the social class structure which they comprise is to be reproduced. We find useful Marx's shorthand differentiation between laborers performing surplus labor in the capitalist fundamental class process (producing surplus value) and laborers providing conditions of existence for the fundamental class process: "productive" vs. "unproductive."³³

Fundamental and subsumed class processes are distinct; they relate differently to the society within which they occur. A person occupying a subsumed class position is dependent upon different social forces and individuals as compared to someone occupying a fundamental class position. Class analysis aims to understand precisely what difference it makes whether and how a person participates in different class processes. This is, we believe, the contribution offered by Marxist theory to social revolutionary movements. Its point is that surplus labor production, appropriation, and distribution exist and that the class processes affect people in specific, different ways which must be understood and integrated into revolutionary strategies if they are to succeed in constructing a just society.

This kind of theory of class does not reduce all the myriad non-class aspects of social life to mere effects of some ultimately determinant set of class processes. Nor do we reduce class processes to being mere effects of non-class processes

such as interpersonal power/authority relations or consciousness, etc. The logic used in linking class and non-class aspects of social life is not determinist or reductionist; rather it is overdeterminist in the sense developed below.

Overdetermination denotes a complex general approach to causation as a seamless web of cause and effect tying together all aspects of any society. Its predecessor term was the “dialectics” so much discussed and debated in the pre-Second World War Marxist tradition. That tradition has since been enriched and transformed significantly by the particular contributions of Georg Lukács and Louis Althusser, who adapted Sigmund Freud’s term “overdetermination” to characterize a strictly non-reductionist (or anti-essentialist) notion of social causality.³⁴ Indeed, overdetermination expands the idea of causality into the more encompassing notion of constitutivity: each aspect of society exists—is constituted—as the effect of all the others.

Given the commitment to overdetermination, our alternative class theory neither requires nor permits an assertion that class is the central moving force of social history. Rather, class exists as the effect of all the non-class aspects of the social totality and at the same time its existence has constitutive effects on all of those non-class aspects. Thus, power, property, technology, and consciousness are all social processes irreducibly different from one another and from the class process. Our analytical goal is always to produce the complex, mutually constitutive relations between these class and non-class processes.

We are not arguing that the surplus labor definition of class is somehow right while alternative definitions are wrong. Our preference for the surplus labor definition reflects our appreciation of Marx’s unique contribution in discovering a distinctive social process: class qua surplus labor production.

Capitalists and productive laborers are understood as the two fundamental classes of the distinctively capitalist fundamental class process. They are the appropriators and producers of surplus labor respectively. In order for this capitalist form of surplus labor production to exist, all manner of non-class processes must be in place. They comprise the conditions of existence of the capitalist fundamental class process. It is constituted as their effect.

Some of these conditions of existence will not be in place unless resources are made available to sustain them. To accomplish this, the capitalists must distribute portions of their appropriated surplus value to individuals who perform those non-class processes without which surplus value production could not occur. For example, corporate personnel managers perform specific political processes of governing the group behavior of productive laborers such as designing and enforcing work discipline. Owners of property perform a specific non-class political process of providing capitalists with access to such privately owned property. Bankers provide an economic process of extending credit to capitalists. This discipline, property, and credit are only three conditions of existence of the production/appropriation of surplus value. To secure them, the appropriators of the surplus distribute portions of it to these managers (salaries), owners (dividends), and bankers (interest): the latter thereby enter into the subsumed class process as recipients of surplus.

Finally, consider religious institutions which perform various rituals and instruct the faithful in moral living. If and when such religious activities are conditions of existence of capitalist surplus labor production/appropriation, in the sense of shaping the willingness of productive laborers to produce surplus for others, the institutions may obtain contributions from capitalists out of their surpluses. By virtue of performing certain religious (non-class) processes, they can and do enter into the subsumed class process.

Our alternative theory of class specifically links the fundamental and subsumed class processes to a host of non-class processes. The linkage between political, cultural, and economic (including class) processes is one of overdetermination: each distinct process exists as the combined effect of all the others. No reductionism is possible here, no ranking of the relative effectivity of one vs. another process. The point is to affirm and integrate class processes into the conception of the social totality to be changed; it is not to deny, denigrate, or subordinate the social effectivity of non-class processes. To collapse class into processes of power or property or consciousness would then precisely lose the specific difference and unique contribution of this theory and of Marx's original insight.

Implications of different class theories

If we can gain agreement that the processes of power, property, surplus labor production and distribution, consciousness and so on are different, then certain conclusions may reasonably be drawn. Calling them all "class" conflates and confuses what would better be kept clearly distinct. More important, a change in any one of these processes leaves open the question of just how that change will impact upon the other processes. For example, a change in power processes, say toward more democratic control over the state, may or may not alter the fundamental and subsumed class processes from a capitalist to a communist form. A change in laborers' consciousness can affect processes of property in different ways depending on all the other processes comprising the full social context of the change in consciousness. A transition from private to socialized property in the means of production—a change in the process of property—may or may not change the class processes from capitalist to communist; that depends on all the other processes in the society at the time of such transition.

The crucial point here is that no invariant relation exists between class and non-class processes. The relations between any two social processes (e.g. class and consciousness or property and power or power and class) vary according to the ever-changing configurations of all the other social processes that mediate such relations. We may not deduce change in one social process as some invariantly necessary consequence of a change in another.

The examples of the Soviet Union and France can underscore the significance of both the specificity of our definition of class and its anti-reductionism. A revolution can basically alter property ownership after 1917 in the USSR. An electoral victory for François Mitterrand can similarly alter French ownership of

banks and large corporate enterprises in the 1980s. In each case, our theoretical framework asks about the impact of the change in property upon class, that is, the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor. How was the capitalist form of the class processes changed? Was it abolished? Given the changes in class that did result from the change in property, how secure is the change in property itself?

These questions would less likely arise for theorists who hold a change in property distribution *to be* a change in class, who conflate class and property. They might well equate the USSR with classlessness because it socialized means of production. They might also think that any further discussion of classes in the USSR would be unnecessary, absurd, or indicative of hostile intent. Theorizing similarly, social-democrats in France might judge socialism in France to be definitively launched by the property nationalizations there. In both cases, and despite oppositions between social-democrats and defenders of Soviet socialism, the analyses make changes in property more or less tantamount to socialist class transformation. By contrast, we would have to ask: under what conditions will nationalization or socialization lead toward rather than away from a strengthened capitalist class structure? Such a question is as urgent for us as it is remote for property theorists of class.

The French example is especially instructive here. The Mitterrand government's actions have transformed France's class structure according to some conceptions of class. Its additional distributions to certain social-welfare recipients of state subsidies plus the provision of a legally mandated fifth week of paid vacation for employees moved significantly toward less inequality of income. If class is defined in terms of income distribution, such alterations of income distribution amount to a significant move toward class change and hence socialism. Where property rather than income distribution defines class, Mitterrand's nationalizations of banks and the large industrial groups are widely seen as changing France's class structure.

French Socialists and Communists could and did eventually dissolve their governing alliance in a dispute frequently debated in terms of class qua property or income distribution. Defenders of Mitterrand argued that the property nationalizations proved the socialist content of government policy notwithstanding the income effects of closing large steel and other French factories thought to be inefficient. Some Communist critics of Mitterrand countered that the factory shutdowns and indeed the general policy of switching government support to high-tech investments had income effects amounting to an "abandonment" of socialist goals and commitments. Increasingly, Communists attack Mitterrand as not really socialist, as carrying out a capitalist restructuring program strengthening France's unequal income distribution, that is, its capitalist class structure. Mitterrand's defenders reply that their high-tech investment program and industrial streamlining pave the way for higher, more secure incomes for workers and thus the promised transition toward socialism which, they insist, cannot be won other than by a successful restructuring of industry first.

By the same token, changes in power relations, say toward democratic control of state policies, pose the question of the impact these changes may have upon class processes. We can entertain no presumption that any simple cause and effect relations leads from a particular political change to a particular class change.

We must ask how the social context of the political change mediates its effects upon class to understand what the class changes are or might be. Such a question is urgent for us, while it makes little sense to power theorists of class. For them, the democratization of power (the demise of the ruler's authority) is or leads necessarily to the end of the ruling/ruled "class structure."

Again, contemporary France offers useful examples. Both defenders and critics of Mitterrand sometimes appeal to power considerations to substantiate their arguments about class and socialism. Defenders point with pride to the government's commitments to "autogestion" (worker self-management programs), to specific achievements in integrating women into government employment and abolishing capital punishment, and to the simple fact of a government run by socialists. These factors, they claim, warrant the label socialist because they are transformations of France's class structure. Detractors insist that Mitterrand has betrayed socialism precisely because autogestion remains an abstract ideal and not an effective worker-power program being implemented anywhere and because power relations generally in France seem unchanged. These critics argue that a socialist government which does not radically alter power relations (i.e. class relations) is therefore not socialist.

Our argument with these debates in France is not that they do not concern social issues of vital importance; they do. However, they literally ignore the issue of class as the production and distribution of surplus labor. They make judgments about socialism in France and the role of the Mitterrand government without substantive interest in class as we understand it and hence without attention to the impact of the Mitterrand policies upon production and distribution of surplus in France. Socialist and Communist parties make political decisions which do impact France and beyond in momentous ways *usually without sustained discussion and inquiry into the issue of surplus production and distribution.*

In our judgment, this makes it likely that French socialism of the Mitterrand government variety will founder for the sorts of reasons Marx suggested long ago. Many of its plans to change France will fail because it fails to consider and directly address the production and distribution of surplus. Further, the changes which the French socialists can make in France will, we believe, be very vulnerable to reversal in large measure because they were not secured by accompanying and mutually supportive transformations of surplus production and distribution. In sum, the lack of awareness about the multiplicity and complexity of class definitions has had and will have major negative implications for modern socialism.

To approach the issue from another vantage point we may ask: is a change from capitalist to communist class processes possible without certain changes in the configuration of non-class processes within a society? Our answer must be "no." For example, it may be that specific changes in social processes concerned with gender relationships would provide conditions for a change in the class processes

of Western capitalist societies today. A change in popular consciousness about what “male” and “female” means (i.e. a change in certain cultural processes) alongside a change in the authority distribution process within families (a change in political or power processes) might combine with a change as women sell more of their labor power as a commodity (a change in the economic process of exchange) to jeopardize capitalist class processes. With other changes in still other social processes—which our class analysis seeks to identify—such altered gender relationships might provide the conditions of existence for a revolutionary change to a new social system including a different class structure.

It follows that practical work must aid those particular changes in social processes which the proposed class theory connects, as conditions of existence, to the desired revolutionary social change. In turn, the practical work changes the theory in terms of how it understands the complex linkages between class and non-class social processes. Theoretical and practical work depend upon and shape one another, subject to the mediations exercised upon both by all the other processes comprising the social context of Marxism.

The implications of Marxist theory as here understood are particularly important for practical politics by the current movements for basic change to a more just society. As in Marx’s time, the theory aims to add two basic ideas to the thinking of those movements: (a) class is a distinct process of surplus labor production/distribution which is different from the important processes of power, property, consciousness, etc., and (b) the analytical method of linking distinct processes together into a social totality is overdetermination rather than reductionism. We believe that these ideas form a basis for unity within current movements and thereby enhance their chances for success.

Unity around these two ideas would not preclude significant differences among Marxists over which particular social processes occupy their analytical and practical energies. The differences would then concern matters of focus. Some would continue the Marxist focus upon class, upon the forms and interactions of the fundamental and subsumed class processes within a society. They would presumably be animated by the feeling that these were the urgent insights that needed to be contributed to revolutionary movements. Others within such a unity would analyze the society via different foci. Processes of power or property or consciousness, etc., would be their concern; insights about those processes would be their contribution. However, the unity of all would consist in the common recognition of the existence of fundamental and subsumed class processes and the common commitment to non-reductionist ways of thinking.

Of course, the differences will occasion debate and disagreements. Different foci will influence social analyses and the practical and theoretical conclusions reached. This will pose thorny problems in terms of strategic and tactical decisions. However, these are useful as well as unavoidable disagreements. They involve disputes over how to see and affect the non-reductionist linkages between class and non-class processes. They are all disputes over these particular issues. They are all conditioned by commitments to basic social changes, although the changes sought will also reflect the different foci.

The unity underpinning the differences and debates will take several forms. First, we might finally set aside our sterile disputations over which aspects of society (power, property, class, etc.) are “the most important” or involve “the most fundamental contradiction.” Which social struggle is “ultimately determinant” on historical change will cease to engage debate. Our commitments to different foci will be understood as results of our unique overdeterminations as individuals and not as signs that we do or do not grasp the essential determinants of history. We will all be aiming to understand the complex linkages among class and non-class processes in the societies we want to change.

Second, whatever the term “class” comes to mean, we will be unified by having learned Marx’s lessons about the production, appropriation and distribution of surplus labor. We will integrate his insights into all the others born of peoples’ struggles for social and personal justice. Our movements will understand and include the class processes in their strategies for change and proposals for the future. Third, unifying commitments to class as surplus labor and to overdetermination would sharply and clearly differentiate Marxist from bourgeois theories which rarely share either of those commitments and never share both.

7 Communism

Between class and classless

Neither Marx nor Engels ever presented a systematic analysis of what a communist society might look like. However, the class analytics developed by Marx have been extended and developed in various particular ways to produce analyses of communism and of such characteristics as collectivity and classlessness (Dobb 1966; Preobrazhensky 1966; Bukharin and Preobrazhensky 1969; Sweezy and Bettelheim 1971, 1985a, b; Bettelheim 1976, 1978; Muqiao 1981). We differ from these writers in how we read and understand Marx's class analytics. Thus we also differ in how we rely upon and use those analytics to define communist class structures and the different forms they can take. Our approach can distinguish in new ways the different possible forms or types of collectivist class structures. We also can produce a new understanding of a "classless" communism and the relation of Marxian theory to such a society.

The concept of class used in our analysis is based on our reading of Marx, especially *Capital*, and our reading differs from those of many other writers, both Marxist and non-Marxist (Resnick and Wolff 1986, 1987: chap. 3). Unlike them, we do not treat classes as groups of people acting in society. Rather, we approach class as a specific kind of process among the many that exist in any society. This enables us to distinguish between and connect the class and non-class processes that always together shape any actual groupings of persons in social life.

We define class as the processes whereby some people in society produce more than they consume—the "surplus"—so that others who produce no surplus can appropriate, distribute, and receive that surplus. Our class analysis seeks to determine who produces surplus in any particular society, who gets this surplus, to whom portions of this surplus are distributed, how such surpluses are transmitted and for what purposes. Such a society's particular processes of surplus production, appropriation and distribution comprise its "class structure." Everything else in society—all its other economic, natural, political and cultural processes—are understood to be non-class processes. They are just as important for Marxian class analysis, as we understand it, since they are more than causes and effects of class processes; they constitute a society's class structure. In short, class and non-class aspects of any society overdetermine each other; neither is more influential than the other in shaping social history.¹

If class, understood in terms of surplus labor, is no more important a cause of social development than any other aspect of society, why do we stress it in our analysis of communism? We want to add something new and distinctive to the vast literature on communism produced over the last hundred years. Other analyses have focused on the philosophical, religious and ethical dimensions in both theories of and practical experiments in communism. Likewise, much attention has been devoted to political and bureaucratic issues involved in social administration, the law, economic planning, and cultural practices of all sorts pertaining to communism. Among the producers of this immense literature, which includes both Marxist and non-Marxist approaches, some stress ideas of class to make sense of communism; many do not.

However, even those who have used class in their studies of the theories and practices of communism (Dobb 1966; Preobrazhensky 1966; Sweezy and Bettelheim 1971; Bettelheim 1976, 1978; Muqiao 1981; Mandel 1985) have rarely if ever used class in the sense that we propose. In their analyses, which emerge from their readings of Marx, class refers to groups of people who wield unequally and unfairly distributed power (“ruling versus ruled classes”) and/or unequally and unfairly distributed property (“haves versus have-nots”). In the property-focused argument, class is usually said to have disappeared to the extent that collective replaces private property. Communism is social ownership of productive property. In the power-focused argument, classlessness is understood differently, as a fully egalitarian, democratic distribution of power. Communism is then that society which has abolished power elites of all sorts. In contrast to such approaches, we treat communism in terms of (1) class processes rather than groups, and (2) class as the processes of production, appropriation and distribution of surplus labor rather than as processes of property or power.

To the vast literature on the theories and practices of communism, we propose to add something new. We will analyze its class structure in terms of the production and distribution of surplus labor, in terms that are based upon the indispensable analysis of capitalism’s class structure which we find in Marx’s *Capital*. We believe that the new insights obtainable from this approach open up important new theoretical and political possibilities, as we suggest below. That is why we stress class analysis, not because of any spurious claim that class aspects are more important to social development than property, power or all the other non-class aspects. Instead, we follow Marx in stressing class because others—and especially fellow radicals committed to basic social changes toward a free and just society—often downplay, neglect or even deny the surplus labor dimensions of the theory and practice of communism. It is more than an irony of history that such a Marxian class analysis has so rarely been applied to the kind of society most associated with Marx’s name and work.

Valuable theoretical work in the Marxian tradition and practical efforts to construct communist class structures in various parts of the world make it possible now to produce fairly concrete images of some basic types of communist class structure. Our presentation of these aims to supplement and to challenge the images of a just society that the Marxian tradition has always inspired. This is

hardly a mere exercise in projecting “utopian visions.” The practices of Marxists have been shaped by their images of the society they aim to build no less than by their political judgments, theoretical formulations, and artistic productions. We hope to change those images and thereby to alter the ways that Marxists intervene in and transform current history.

There is still another reason for proposing the following class analysis of communism, namely, to fashion a new answer to an old question. How are we to assess the current structures and dynamics of those communities who proclaim themselves to be socialist or communist or in transition to one or the other? It is of course legitimate for them to be assessed in terms of their specific histories, their degrees of cultural creativity, personal freedom, political participation, economic security, national independence, and so forth. However, we want to add another, different standard to these, namely, the standard of how such communities arrange socially for the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor. By adding such a standard, we can assess how actual social experiences of socialism and communism compare to the types of communist class structure developed here through the application of Marxian class analytics. Different standards produce different notions of success and failure for societies.

As we argue below, Marxian class analysis suggests that there are different forms or types of communist class structure. These are the specifically collective ways of producing, appropriating and distributing surplus labor which distinguish communist class structures from the various forms of the capitalist, feudal, slave and other kinds of class structures. However, the uniqueness of Marxian analysis lies not only in its distinctive theorization of the basic types of communism’s collective class structure. It lies as well in its formulation of yet another form of communism in which class processes disappear altogether: “classless society.”

The remarkable Marxian commitment to dialectics can lead its class analysis to a type of communism in which even the collective production, appropriation and distribution of surplus labor cease to occur in society, much as the processes of human slavery disappeared at certain points in human history. We show how Marxian theory reaches this conclusion about a classless form of communism. We also show how this conclusion requires that the theory’s own categories of necessary and surplus labor correspondingly change their theoretical roles and cease to be the focal points of its social analysis. Communism, we argue, may develop into a particular form in which not only surplus labor disappears but also the Marxian theory focused upon necessary and surplus labor undergoes basic changes. This is, after all, as it should be. If Marxian theory is committed to the ceaseless change of human society, the forever coming into being, changing, and demise of all aspects of society, then this must apply as well to Marxian theory itself. And this occurs in conjunction with one possible line of development in communism.

The argument here represents, then, more than the application to communism of certain class analytics based on a particular reading of Marx. It represents as well the discovery of the limitation of those analytics, a limitation linked appropriately to the social development of communism. The resultant class-analytical

images of the various forms of communism will, we hope, provoke productive debates over and transformations in the theory and practice of communism.

The communist form of class processes²

As we have argued elsewhere (1987), class analysis begins by inquiring whether and how individuals in a society participate in the two possible kinds of class processes. The fundamental class process refers to their involvement in the production and/or appropriation of surplus labor. The subsumed class process refers to their participation in the distribution of already appropriated surplus and/or in the receipt of such distributions. Any person's involvement in either or both of these class processes produces his or her class position(s) in that society: a fundamental class position as surplus labor producer or appropriator and a subsumed class position as distributor or receiver of that surplus labor.

We follow Marx in differentiating one class society from another on the basis of the forms in which surplus labor is appropriated and distributed. A communist form of the fundamental class process is then one in which individuals who perform the surplus labor also collectively receive it. In like fashion, a communist form of the subsumed class process is one in which these collective receivers of surplus labor also collectively distribute it. They do so to secure particular non-class processes that are necessary for the existence of that specific form of collective appropriation.

The existence of these two class processes in communism imposes upon us an unexpected inference: a communist society may be a class society. It also follows that parallel to all class societies, it too may experience class struggles—in this case, struggles over the collective appropriation and/or distribution of surplus labor. Collectivity refers only to the form of surplus labor appropriation; it does not mean the absence of contradictions and conflicts, class or otherwise.

To us this is a surprising result since we, like many in the Marxian tradition, expect that the transition from capitalism to communism leads to the end of class and class struggle. Yet the presence in a communist society of a distinction between necessary and surplus labor must mean that individuals there participate (as they do wherever this distinction arises) in the production, receipt and distribution of that surplus. It follows, therefore, that they occupy class positions; in this case, communist class positions.

The presence of classes in communism, however, does not imply the presence of private (i.e. in the sense of individual) appropriation of surplus labor. The type of communism defined so far eliminates that form, replacing it with the collective form: appropriation of surplus labor by collectivities of individuals. Collectivity becomes, then, one of the defining characteristics of this type of communism. To underscore this point, we shall consider another type of communism in which this distinction between necessary and surplus labor is not present, and thus collective appropriation, class, and class struggle all disappear. However, let us first examine this collective appropriation of surplus labor for it has rarely received the attention in Marxist literature that it deserves.³ We think that as a result of this neglect, much of the complexity and contradictory nature of communism has been missed.

Collective appropriation and communism

Let us begin by noting that individuals in communism labor generally for a certain number of hours per day producing use-values. One portion of these hours (x) produces a bundle of use-values that is deemed historically to be necessary for the social reproduction of communist laborers. However, suppose that they continue to work for additional hours (y) above and beyond the hours and use-values deemed necessary for their social reproduction. Following Marx, this additional amount of hours worked by them (y) is called surplus labor. In the communist society being considered, the products of this surplus labor are received collectively by these same workers. Thus this form of the fundamental class process deserves the label communist because it aptly describes how the surplus labor and its fruits are appropriated: collectively.

We mean by collective appropriation that the fruit of communist surplus labor is received by individuals who may literally come together as a collective to receive it. In some historical cases this can take the form of members of the commune gathering at particular intervals to receive as a group the surplus portion of the produced use-values. Produced goods and services are physically brought to them so that they may then collectively distribute them (the subsumed class process), partly to themselves and partly to still other members of the commune. In different historical circumstances, it may not be practical to assemble the collective appropriators and the collective surplus in one place at one time. Then, specific procedures and understandings would have to be developed, including dissemination of all relevant information, to ensure that such members are the first receivers and distributors of the surplus. In such cases, communal members' appropriating and distributing positions would be akin to those held by members of boards of directors in modern industrial corporations (Resnick and Wolff 1987). They are understood to be the first receivers and distributors of the surplus and this understanding is supported by whatever educational, cultural, political, and economic procedures are deemed necessary in the society. And parallel to the role of managers of such corporations, agents of collective appropriators may be appointed to manage collective appropriation. Presumably, the matrices of tensions between appropriators and managers in the two different class structures would reflect their differences.

Once received by the workers who have produced it, the surplus labor is distributed to secure whatever non-class processes are deemed necessary to insure that the communist fundamental class process continues to exist. In other words, this distribution secures those non-class processes of social life that induce communist laborers to work those extra hours (y) beyond what is necessary (x) to their reproduction as laborers. This distribution of the received surplus labor warrants the label communist in the present context because these workers not only receive collectively the surplus labor—the fundamental class process—but also distribute it collectively—the subsumed class process—to secure its conditions of existence.

Communist class processes differ from all others in that surplus appropriation is collective rather than private. This means that in communism (1) the producers

are also the appropriators of their surplus and (2) the appropriation is done collectively, not individually. In a capitalist society, for example, different individuals typically occupy the two fundamental class positions; in the communisms considered, the societal rule is for the same individuals to occupy both fundamental class positions. However, it is of course possible, although perhaps rare, that in capitalism the same individual may occupy both the position of receiver of surplus value (capitalist) and coworker alongside other productive laborers employed by this same capitalist. While capitalist appropriation can thus on occasion mean that the same person both produces and appropriates surplus labor, the appropriation is then private in the sense of being individual rather than collective. Similarly, in what Marx termed the “ancient” class process (individual self-employment) the producers and receivers of surplus were always the same individuals, and thus the surplus appropriation was individual, not collective. Despite a similarity to communism in that the producers and receivers of surplus in these particular examples are the same individuals, they remain strikingly different since only communism involves collective appropriation.

Thus we may conclude, even at this early stage of our argument, that the notion of collectivity permits an initial differentiation of a communist from a non-communist society, despite the presence in both of a class structure. It follows that in a society in which this collective appropriation does not take place, there must be either some form of private appropriation or the complete absence altogether of appropriation: classlessness.

Types of communist class processes

As with the feudal, capitalist and other kinds of class processes, the communist fundamental and subsumed class processes may take on a variety of different forms or types. Consider a type I communist fundamental class process: all adult individuals in society participate collectively in that class process as appropriators of surplus labor, but only some individuals (a smaller number) perform surplus labor. In this type, all individuals in society collectively appropriate and thus distribute surplus labor, but not all produce it. The form is communist by virtue of its communal appropriation: workers who produce necessary and surplus labor also appropriate that surplus collectively.

In a second type of the communist fundamental class process, only those particular individuals who perform surplus labor collectively appropriate it. Others in society may not participate in the communist fundamental class process at all: they neither perform nor appropriate surplus labor. Because of this, they do not distribute the surplus either. Like the first type of communist fundamental class process, this second type still warrants the label communist because it too specifies communal appropriation, although a number of individuals in this second type do not participate in the communist fundamental class process at all.

Both types exhibit communist class positions. In type I, each and every adult member of society occupies a communist fundamental class position as a collective appropriator of performed surplus labor and a communist subsumed class

position as a collective distributor of that which has been appropriated. In contrast to this full participation of society's members, type II excludes some members from occupying either the fundamental class positions or the subsumed class positions as initial distributors of surplus labor.

The difference between these two types of communism produces a different set of contradictions and tensions within each. For example, tensions may arise in the first type of communism between producers of surplus labor and those who, like the producers, appropriate it but do not share in its production. The second type of communism deals with this particular problem by its imposed equality of collective receivers and producers: no individual can participate in surplus labor appropriation without also helping to produce that same surplus. Yet this very equality may breed its own set of contradictions, for it effectively excludes perhaps significant numbers of individuals in the society from any initial claim to surplus labor whatsoever. Whereas type I's societal rule guarantees to all citizens—no matter what their age, physical condition, concrete work performed, or any other characteristic—the appropriator's first claim to the surplus, no matter who participates in its production, the restriction imposed in type II does not. Consequently, tensions may arise in type II between such excluded individuals and the producers/appropriators of surplus over exactly how, and to what degree, and, indeed, *if* the former are to be sustained by distributions of this surplus.

This economic difference between these two types of communism should not be confused with the important political differences that may also exist between them. The key point here is not to confuse the *appropriation* with the *control* of surplus. For example, consider a type I communism where *all collectively appropriate* the surplus but where *only the producers of surplus have the power or authority to order appropriators on how to distribute* the surplus among subsumed classes. In other words, only producers may have the legally enshrined power to decide how the surplus is to be distributed. Here, producers control but clearly are not the only appropriators of surplus. To take a contrasting example, a type II communism may exist with power vested in all citizens to control the distribution of the surplus. In this case, only producers of the surplus would be the initial appropriators and distributors of that surplus, but all citizens in the commune would have the power to order them as to how it would be distributed. We thus see in these examples the impossibility of invariably linking different kinds of political arrangements (decision-making behavior) to different types of fundamental class processes (appropriating behavior). Power relations and class relations are neither identical nor deducible from one another.

Both the Marxian and non-Marxian traditions have found it difficult to maintain these distinctions between class and power. For example, to argue that those we designate as appropriators could not remain so if they lack control over surplus labor is to endow the political process of control with a social significance or effectivity greater than all other social processes. In contrast, we argue that appropriators continue to receive surplus because of the effectivity of all social processes. Power is not more or less influential in shaping the fact of their appropriation than are, say, ideology, art, ownership patterns, and the division of labor.

In our example above, we showed that the wielding of power over surplus does not necessarily imply appropriation of that same surplus. Power is not the most important influence, whether in the first or last instance, on individuals' class positions.

Unlike many other approaches, this anti-essentialist understanding of the relationship between power and class underscores the different effectivities of social processes other than power in shaping class. Of course, were one or more of these other non-power social processes to take over the privileged status of essence in social theory—now held so widely by power—we would offer a similar criticism of them. However, it is the current essentialist role of power in social theory that requires confrontation and criticism, since adherents of that role thereby foster the very absolutism of power that they seek otherwise to overthrow in society.

Cultural processes in communism

What non-class social processes might be present in a society whose combined effectivity creates the conditions of existence of a communist fundamental class process (types I or II)? What motivates individuals to produce surplus labor for a collective appropriation? Posing the question in this way seems to invite an obvious answer: individuals “naturally” desire to appropriate that which they have produced. Yet, if this were so obvious, then the existence of non-communist fundamental forms of surplus labor appropriation—capitalism, feudalism, and slavery—would be problematic. For in these forms of private appropriation, individuals produce surplus labor for the private appropriation of others. The giving of something (the fruits of the y hours of surplus labor effort) for nothing in return is the precise meaning that Marx attached to the fundamental class process, that is, the process of private appropriation that he called exploitation (1977, chap. 9). Why might individuals prefer a situation in which they produce surplus labor for others rather than for themselves?

One possible answer is that individuals may understand communism to be an evil. They understand it to be inconsistent with or inevitably a danger to their freedom. They would thus have little desire to participate in such a society. Instead, they might well prefer any society other than the communist, despite the fact that in these societies they might understand themselves to be exploited by others rather than the community of themselves.

Their preference might emerge from a theory of society that denies the social existence of exploitation, no matter what its form. With a theory that conceptualizes a society in terms of an inherent harmony among its parts, no aversion to private exploitation need exist. Added to this may be the presence of a variety of different cultural forms in society that effectively construct the label communism to stand for something inherently evil because of its conflict with human nature or with God's will.

Even if other societies were understood, however vaguely, to include something called “private exploitation,” whereas communism were understood just as vaguely to exclude it, individuals might still prefer one or more of them to

communism. They might see the latter and its “communal appropriation” as utopian dreams that are unrealizable in this world. What would be “realistic” for them might well be to struggle for a relatively humane and democratic capitalism as against less desirable forms of capitalism and against feudal and slave social formations.

For communist fundamental class processes of types I or II to exist requires a variety of cultural processes (i.e. non-class processes that generate meanings). Some of these must convince individuals that surplus labor appropriation is as real a part of human existence as are the other social processes that they recognize and take seriously. Fundamental class processes must be as relevant to them and their lives as are processes of speaking, eating, laboring, thinking, ordering human behavior and so forth. In addition, arguments must exist that help to persuade individuals that the replacement of private by communal appropriation will eliminate a form of private theft in society that often breeds much misery and despair. Such theft (and its possible effects on the lives of individuals) must come to be recognized in society, just as slavery is now recognized, as a kind of evil that distorts and constrains human development in very concrete ways.

Such arguments, in whatever form they may exist, also must celebrate communal appropriation as providing a way, a possibility, for a new and more desirable era of human behavior to develop. They must connect economic freedom from private exploitation—be it capitalist, feudal, slave or ancient—to the liberation of society from the recurrent social miseries that haunt private exploitation. To exist, communist class processes require that individuals be persuaded that such economic freedom is consistent with and a condition for a new system of political and cultural freedoms that permit all individuals to struggle effectively and participate fully in social life.

Cultural processes that provide such effects tend to orient individuals toward the communal appropriation of surplus labor. They may also motivate those individuals to struggle against the continued existence or emergence of non-communist class processes. They are indispensable non-class parts of a communist society whose presence helps to secure the very existence of the communist fundamental class process.

Individuals who provide these cultural conditions and receive a distributed share of the collective surplus labor for so doing occupy communist subsumed class positions in society. They produce and disseminate the various cultural artifacts—documents, art, songs, histories, books, movies, and so on—that help to produce in individuals the class consciousness, motivation, and education necessary for the continued existence of the communist production and appropriation of surplus labor. Without the subsumed class labor of these individuals, the labor of the fundamental class might not be forthcoming and the survival of communism would be problematic.

We may extend this dependence of the communist fundamental class process on particular cultural processes by considering a number of other non-class processes whose effectivity is crucial to its existence. Each of them produces effects that push individuals to produce surplus labor for the collective. Their

participation in a communist fundamental class process is thus overdetermined by the combined effectivity of all of these non-class processes—not only the cultural, but also a variety of different political and economic non-class processes. All of them produce those complex cultural, political, and economic influences that form the conditions of existence of the different types of the communist fundamental class process.

Political processes in communism

Such political processes include particular rules, laws and, generally, an ordering of human behavior whose combined effects support a communal appropriation of surplus labor. For example, laws may exist that effectively give all individuals in a society power over property in the means of production. This would exclude the private ownership of productive property: no individual could exclude others from the collective ownership of productive property. For the production of necessary and surplus labor to take place, the collective owners would then have to give the collective appropriators and laborers access to productive property. In return, collective owners might receive a share of the fruits of surplus labor from the appropriators, a sort of communist dividend.

With such communal ownership, all members of the society would occupy communist subsumed class positions—as collective owners of property—if they receive a distributed share of the appropriated surplus labor for making their property available to the communal appropriators and laborers. However, only in type I would they also occupy the additional subsumed class position as distributors of the surplus and the fundamental class position as appropriators of that surplus. In type II, some individuals, as we have seen, occupy neither any fundamental class position nor the subsumed class position of surplus distributor; in a world of communal ownership, however, all would occupy the subsumed class ownership position.

Communal ownership of productive property might reduce the economic pressure on individuals to sell their labor power to others since they would not be divorced from the means to reproduce their social existence. Other laws in society might directly prohibit the sale and purchase of labor power as a commodity. No individual could alienate that which is not owned privately by that same individual. Political processes generating such laws would seriously undermine the possibility of capitalist exploitation, just as laws outlawing the sale and purchase of human beings makes slavery problematic.

Paradoxically, such laws direct our attention back to political processes governing other forms of non-capitalist societies such as the feudal and the slave. Feudal serfs and slaves lacked the freedom to sell what they did not own—their own labor power. Moreover, at least in the initial stages of both types of societies, serfs and slaves lacked the freedom to own property. These sorts of non-freedoms characterize communism as well, and partly because of that may undermine its appeal as an alternative society to those who live under capitalism. Certainly, few would wish to recreate in a communist society some of the more onerous

conditions of either a feudal or a slave society. After all, transitions from the latter types of societies to capitalism have long been celebrated for ridding human existence of those very conditions.

However, all political processes such as laws and rules are specific to the society in which they exist. Notions of freedom and non-freedom do not transcend historical moments; like all aspects of a society, they are peculiar to the society that gives birth to them and, in turn, is shaped by them. It follows that slave and feudal non-freedoms are specific to those societies; indeed, they are two of the political conditions necessary for their respective class processes to exist and be reproduced over time. In parallel fashion, the communist non-freedoms listed above are not only specific to the communist society; they also serve to secure particular conditions necessary for the communist class processes to exist.

Slave and feudal non-freedoms help to secure slave and feudal surplus labor, respectively. In like manner, capitalist non-freedoms, such as the inability to buy and sell human beings or to socialize productive property without compensation, help to secure capitalist surplus labor. These are some political conditions of various forms of private exploitation of some individuals by other individuals. In contrast to this, the inability to alienate property in communism helps to secure an entirely new kind of human freedom: the freedom from one human being privately exploiting another. In that precise sense, slavery, feudalism, and capitalism are more alike than they are different from one another. They share in common the horror of private exploitation. Individuals in society—lord, slave master, capitalist—receive the fruit of another's labor without providing anything in return.

By contrast, non-Marxian approaches may well understand particular freedoms and non-freedoms to be conditions, perhaps even essential conditions, for the achievement of maximum wealth and happiness of a society's citizens. In such views, only a capitalist society can foster the institutions capable of producing and maintaining these freedoms. In contrast, Marx and Engels' (1978) insight was to argue that the freedoms of capitalism helped to secure a form of disguised slavery for the workers. For Marxism, the absence of such freedoms in communism helps to produce the end of such slavery in all its forms, including the capitalist.

Besides laws and rules concerned with the ownership and alienation of forms of property, communist politics must decide who in society shall occupy the various class and non-class positions there, what shall be the division between necessary and surplus labor, how much of the produced surplus should be distributed to various occupants of subsumed class positions, and so forth. Individuals who establish these and other laws and rules, adjudicate disputes over them, and enforce them would occupy communist subsumed class positions if they receive a distributed share of the communal surplus labor for so doing.

In their unique ways, all of these political conditions are necessary for the existence of the communist fundamental class process. Some individuals in society must perform the necessary subsumed class labor to insure that such political processes take place. Without their subsumed class labor, the communist fundamental class labor of others would be jeopardized.

The powers wielded by individuals working at various levels and in different subdivisions of this subsumed class position may produce all kinds of contradictions, tensions, and even struggles within the society. These are, of course, vitally important in shaping the histories of actual communist societies. However, these powers, this bureaucracy, and its contradictions are distinct from the appropriation of surplus labor and the fundamental classes who respectively produce and receive it. In dealing with concrete cases of socialist and communist societies, no point seems to be more important than this one. Too often, in Marxian and non-Marxian approaches to the examination of such societies, either class is reduced to power or the two are collapsed into each other. The result is to equate the end of communism to the rise of bureaucracy and its concentrated power. In such approaches, individuals who occupy subsumed class positions in the communist bureaucracy are collapsed into fundamental classes by virtue of the power they wield in society.

Economic processes in communism

The final set of non-class social processes to consider are economic ones. These involve the distribution of the communist society's productive resources and the production and distribution of its goods and services. Such production must take place in order for the communist fundamental and subsumed class processes to exist. Their existence is likewise overdetermined by the distribution of means of production and of produced goods and services to reproduce the labor of the fundamental class as well as the different kinds of labor of the subsumed classes.

A communist fundamental class process is also partly an effect of the division of labor in society. For example, some laborers may produce only food in rural areas while others are only engaged in the production of cloth in urban areas. Individuals in the country may spend their $x + y$ hours producing only food whereas their town cousins spend their $x + y$ hours producing only cloth. Assuming that both food and cloth are required to reproduce such laborers (and thus their participation in the communal class processes), food must be distributed to the specialized cloth producers and cloth to the specialized food producers. In a word, use-values must flow between town and country to support this division of labor, and these flows participate in overdetermining this society's class processes.

These economic divisions of labor, like the political divisions between those who wield power and those who do not, can become the source of considerable tension and even struggle in society. The latter, however, are distinct from, although variously related to, those tensions and struggles that occur over the class processes. What must be kept in mind in considering such divisions and their contradictory effects is the Marxian distinction between possible conditions of existence of the communal appropriation of surplus labor (the division of labor or the flows of use-values) and that appropriation itself. A struggle may erupt in a communist society over the terms (established, for example, by subsumed class officials) under which cloth exchanges for food. This struggle might pit laborers

in the countryside against those in the towns, a classic problem in the development of an economy. This struggle over the terms of trade (and the social consequences that follow from it) is a non-class struggle. It differs from struggles that may develop over class issues—the communal appropriation and/or distribution of surplus labor.

The existence and specific qualities of the communal fundamental class process also depend on (i.e. they are overdetermined by) the productivity of labor in the production of use-values. For example, a rise in such productivity will increase the quantity of goods and services to be distributed and may thereby facilitate the reproduction of communism. However, like changes in other economic processes (flows of use-values, division of labor, etc.), changes in the productivity of labor are distinct from changes in the communal fundamental class process. The increase in productivity, and the enhanced wealth it brings to the communist society, may, in some circumstances, become a danger to the continued existence of this class process, and thus to the continued existence of communism. More productive workers, for example, might demand private benefits therefrom and agitate for a greater share of surplus labor, or even for some private appropriation of surplus labor.

The point here is not to oppose increases in productivity, but rather to stress that changes in productivity, just like other economic changes in the communal society's division of labor or distribution of food and cloth, are distinct from, though related to, changes in its fundamental class process. In the Marxian perspective, we emphasize the consequences of non-class processes in shaping the class processes. Therefore, economic questions of productivity, like the political questions of freedom and of democratic decision-making, are specifically linked to the society in which they occur in terms of its class structure and dynamic. The determination of how a particular change in any non-class process has an impact on the survival of communism depends on a concrete analysis of its contradictory effects upon the class processes of the society in question.

Individuals in society who plan, organize, supervise and execute the allocation of labor, means of production, and produced goods and services will occupy communal subsumed class positions if they receive a share of the communal surplus labor for so doing. Such planners and managers secure conditions of existence of the communist fundamental class process. They participate in cultural and political processes as well as economic processes, since the production and allocation of goods and services require plans and documents to be prepared, instructions to be given, orders to be carried out, and so forth. Like any complex activity, "economic planning" as a general concept or activity cannot be reduced merely to its economic components (Ruccio 1986).

We have assumed, finally, that all of the above-mentioned economic processes can occur in communism without any need for markets and commodity exchange. The existence of commodity exchange, like any other social process, is overdetermined by a myriad of causes. It is, of course, possible that these economic processes—division of labor, flow of use-values between town and country, production of surplus labor and product, and so on—along with other concrete

political and cultural processes may all combine to produce within communism a commodity-exchange process.

Parallel to all other social processes, the presence of markets in communism would exert its particular effects on all the other processes of that communism. For example, commodity exchange and markets might (although they need not) act to increase productivity by, say, encouraging competition and the economic survival of the most able producers. The resulting increase in wealth could strengthen the communist fundamental class process. On the other hand, commodity exchange could also undermine the communist fundamental class process by fostering those non-class processes more conducive to private than to collective appropriation. Thus there is no essential contradiction between commodities and communism, between market and plan, despite the presumption of such essential contradictions in so much of the literature.

If we were to assume that there were no markets or commodities present, then their absence would preclude value and exchange value from existing within the communism being considered. There is no question that concrete labor would take place, use-values would be produced, and surplus labor and product would be generated. However, despite the existence of a communist surplus, there would be no surplus *value* because of the absence of the exchange process. This suggests the importance of the influence of any one process—here the commodity-exchange process—to the existence of all others. Without the presence and thus the particular effectivity of the former, there could be no value, exchange value, and surplus value.

The same logic applies to the effectivity of each and every other process in society. Omitting any one of them changes the character of all the others. Omitting the economic process by which the purchase and sale of labor power takes place, for example, helps to support but by no means guarantees the existence of the communist fundamental class process. The latter requires all the causes so far mentioned (as well as an infinite set of others). Thus, there can be no single, essential cause of communism.

Communist variations, development, and change

Communist social formations, like all others, are capable of great variations in structure, development, and change. Likewise, possibilities of transition from non-communist to communist social formations are matched by possibilities of the reverse sorts of transition. Consider, for example, the presence or absence of a formal state apparatus. If such a state exists, the communist fundamental class process may occur within the state (e.g. within state-run productive enterprises), outside it, or both, thereby generating three more variant forms of communism. In parallel fashion, communist social formations may include productive enterprises, households, political parties, churches, and so on, in which different mixtures of class and non-class processes occur, thereby creating a rich diversity of possible forms of communism.

It follows that it is possible for forms of communism to display apparent similarities with forms of capitalism, feudalism and other social formations.

There can be, for example, particular household structures, patterns of state power, cultural practices, and so on, that display some similarities although they exist and function within the contexts of fundamentally different class structures.

Unlike many other approaches to social analysis, Marxian theory does not proceed from such similarities among the non-class components of social life to shift its focus away from class. It does not, for example, argue that a powerful centralized bureaucracy found similarly in a form of communism and a form of capitalism implies a convergence or a general dissolution of differences between the two class structures. While we share a deep antipathy to undemocratic structures of power, that does not warrant either (1) confusing power structures with class structures or (2) displacing class in favor of power as the focus of analysis simply because two particular forms of different class structures display non-class similarities at some moments. After all, the point of class theories like Marxism is to keep the structures of the production and distribution of surplus labor in the forefront of social analysis.

Each variation of communism produces its unique contradictions that shape the unique movement of that society. Consider a variation of type I communism in which individuals in a communist party have been empowered by the collective to plan, direct, and control the collective appropriation of surplus labor. To sustain their complex activities, portions of surplus labor are distributed to them. They thus occupy communist subsumed class positions in a party which may exist both inside and outside a state.

To whatever other contradictions exist within the society, we must add those emanating from the relationships among these subsumed class party officials and between them and occupants of the communist fundamental and still other subsumed class positions.⁴ Suppose that party officials wish to increase communist accumulation just when an increased demand on the surplus is presented by, let us say, military officials and/or educational authorities who occupy subsumed class positions within the state.⁵

Various reactions are possible, each of which sets in motion still other contradictions and new reactions. Taken together, these contradictions, created reactions, and new contradictions comprise the development of society. One possible reaction to these competing party, military, and educational demands may be struggles by each subsumed class to increase its share of communist surplus at the expense of the others. Their strategies may include appeals to communist ideology, threats of foreign encroachment, manipulation of prices and budgets, and even force. This conflict over distributed shares of the surplus is a form of subsumed class struggle in communism: a struggle over the communist subsumed class process. The development of any particular communism emanates partly from the specific contradictions among its subsumed classes.

A different reaction might involve pressuring for more surplus labor from the producers to meet all the party, military, and educational demands on it. Party officials might exert such pressures alone or with the support of the military and educational authorities. Such pressures, in turn, have contradictory effects. Direct laborers may now produce an expanded surplus for the collective. On the other

hand, changes in the rate of surplus appropriation may well generate negative reactions. The producers may resist the pressures and, in one way or another, struggle against them. This would be a fundamental class struggle in communism: a struggle over the communist fundamental class process. The pressures, producers' varying reactions to them, and the consequent possibility of subsumed and/or fundamental class struggles together shape this communist society's development.

In each possible variation, class and non-class contradictions and struggles help to produce communism's change, development, and perhaps a transition to a qualitatively different kind of society. Of course, social change may involve more than the interactions between communist class and non-class processes. It would also include interactions with and among the non-communist class processes and the classless communism that might exist in a society. Marx evidently favored a transition to the latter type of communism, although he never offered any theoretical treatment of it. However, our rethinking of certain categories that he established makes possible the following sketch of classless communism.

Classless society

In Marx's famous letter to Joseph Weydemeyer (March 5, 1852), he insisted that the discovery of class and class conflict was not his but belonged rather to bourgeois historians. His new contributions, he argued, were three: a specific definition of class in terms of production relations; the concept of the dictatorship of the proletariat; and lastly, the notion of such a dictatorship as transitional toward "the abolition of all classes . . . a classless society." While he wrote extensively on class analysis, he said little about either the dictatorship of the proletariat or classlessness. Does Marx's work on class provide us with some means for constructing at least an initial analysis of proletarian dictatorship and classlessness?

We think it does. The preceding sections of this chapter used Marx's original contributions to construct a particular class analysis of communism. We intend here to begin to develop his other two contributions. First, we propose to use our class analysis of communism to sketch a more concrete notion of a classless society than Marx or Marxists have yet produced. Then, in the paper's conclusion, we suggest a class conception of various dictatorships of the proletariat.

The very phrase, "classless society," defines a social arrangement in terms of what it is not. What is missing in such a society is the distinction between necessary and surplus labor, that is, the fundamental class process. By contrast, feudalism, capitalism, slavery, still other class structures, and even the two types of communism sketched above, are all approached by Marxian theory in terms of the division between necessary and surplus labor. Using that theory, Marxists then proceed to work out the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor for each society's distinct class structure. However, both private and collective structures of appropriation presume the existence of a surplus and thus a specific apparatus of necessary and surplus labor, fundamental and subsumed class processes, and so on.

In a classless society no division between necessary and surplus exists. The production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor disappear from the social scene. They pass from history in the same sense that political forms such as absolute monarchy or cultural forms such as religious rituals of human sacrifice have faded from the twentieth century. Indeed, the absence of class processes is the only possible meaning of a “classless” society, given Marx’s theory of class and the various forms of class societies.

That meaning in turn provokes the following sorts of questions. What social changes may make possible a transition from class to classless societies—as distinct from transitions *within* class societies—such as those from private to collective appropriations of surplus labor? How would labor be organized and divided among production tasks in societies where class processes are absent? How are such societies different from those where some form of the class process is prevalent?

Not only can Marxian theory conceptualize a society in which class disappears, it also understands that the disappearance of class would react back upon class analysis itself. Marxian theory would change—in particular by abandoning its focus on class—and focus instead on new problems and new objectives generated by the particular contradictions of classless societies. The theory can thus envision the conditions of its own historical change. Marxism can apply its commitment to dialectics, that is, to the ceaseless transformation of all things, to itself as well.

The absence of the necessary/surplus labor distinction means that all human labor applied to the production of use-values for social utilization (as means of consumption or means of further production) is necessary. In the terms of our notation above, $x + y = x$. No labor is surplus: $y = 0$. The absence of the distinction between necessary and surplus also influences the allocation of laborers among the different kinds of goods and services being produced. These goods and services include more than those directly consumable and their means of production; they also include all the processes of distribution, economic planning, political administration, aesthetic creation, and so on. In other words, *all* human labor—whether allocated to the production of food and cloth, or to the production and dissemination of cultural artifacts and political laws—is necessary labor.

Classlessness has its particular conditions of existence. Compared to any class-structured society, for example, a classless society would require very different kinds of allocation of work tasks (what and how to produce) and allocation of products (who gets what). Who does what kind of work for how long and in what way would depend on the needs and wants of all concerned, *excluding* any need or want to produce or procure a surplus. No person’s desire for profit, rent, interest, and so on, could be effective, could actually determine what work anyone performs or what products anyone gets. That is a condition for classlessness to continue. Another condition of existence of classlessness might be the systematic rotation of all work tasks among individuals to prevent any technical divisions of labor from hardening and possibly becoming class divisions (cf. Bukharin and Preobrazhensky 1969: 115ff.) The absence of class implies as well as presupposes the liberation of all work from its historic subordination to class.

Classlessness also has its cultural conditions of existence. For example, there would have to be education of all in the multiplicity of tasks to be accomplished if rotation were to be possible. There would need to be education for all in the coordinating and designing of tasks as well as their performance. In short, the mass de-skilling characteristic of capitalism would have to be replaced by an equally mass development of the population's productive, design, and managerial skills. With or without rotation, another cultural condition of existence might well be a broadly held ethic that places the highest priority on the equality of all in relation to production and its fruits and on classlessness as the means to achieve that equality. Such an ethic would have to place comparable value on certain democratic political conditions that are both the objectives of classlessness and themselves conditions of its existence.

For classlessness to survive, still another condition is for politics to be the direct social means to decide the what, how, and for whom of production. These latter must be the direct objects of political processes without any regard to the maintenance of any class structure. Politics must at last take all its social conditions under its procedures without the constraint of maintaining any existing class structure. Politics must prevent any rule of class maintenance—such as the rule of profit maximization or the rule that one person can own another—from interfering in the social decisions about economics or anything else. The absence of class implies as well as presupposes the liberation of politics from its historic subordination to class.

Classlessness has its particular social effects. While these will of course vary with the specific social contexts within which class processes cease to exist, it may be useful to mention here some possible effects of longstanding concern to Marxists. These possible effects have long made classlessness a goal of Marxists.

A social transition to classlessness removes one factor contributing to hierarchical divisions among individuals performing various tasks in the division of labor. Workers need no longer be differentiated, consciously or unconsciously, according to whether they produce or appropriate surplus or live off surplus produced by others. Since the history of class-structured societies suggests that individuals who appropriate surplus and/or live off the surplus of others tend to arrogate disproportionate political power and cultural benefits to themselves, classlessness can contribute toward more democratic political and cultural life.

Similarly, the absence of the necessary/surplus division of labor strengthens the scope and depth of collectivity in its gathering of *all* expenditures of human brain and muscle as equivalently under the continuous consideration, control, and transformation of politics. The production, distribution and consumption of all goods and services, when classlessly organized, become more readily objects of democratic decision-making. No imperatives of maintaining a given class structure block movements toward a more democratic politics. In this sense, classlessness represents a social step toward the rule of “from each according to ability, and to each according to need.”

For the foreseeable future, one condition for the emergence of classless communism may be the widespread use of a kind of Marxist theory which can

conceptualize both the differences between capitalist and communist class structures, and between them and classless communism. Alternative conceptions of communism—those focused on property ownership (who owns), those based on power (who rules) or those based on surplus (who appropriates)—foster different social transitions. Thus, theories which do not recognize the varieties of class processes and the possibility of their disappearance will, in our view, likely do little to facilitate a transition to classlessness, and may do much to block it. Our particular class-analytical approach to communism aims to revive, provoke, and clarify the debates over the relation of communism to the future of modern society.

The classless society is a different kind of communism from the types of collective surplus labor appropriation discussed as communist class structures. Moreover, the overdeterminist logic of Marxian theory permits no presumption of any necessary historical movement from private to collective class societies or from the latter to classless society. What Marxian theory does make possible is the application of its class analytics to shed new light upon socialism, communism, societies such as the Soviet Union, China, and so forth.

Differences between socialism and communism

Usages of the terms socialism and communism differ greatly. As very broad “isms,” they invite commentaries which emphasize economics, politics or culture according to the orientation of each commentator’s approach to social analysis. However, for virtually everyone interested in socialism and communism, the terms are passionately intertwined with visions of the future varying from the most beautiful to the most horrible. The futures each of us seeks, and those that we dread, play their more or less subtle roles in influencing our interpretations of these terms.

For writers whose focus is power—how it is organized and constrained, who wields it over whom, and so on—socialism and communism are defined in terms of the distribution of authority between state and citizen and among groups and individual citizens. Freedom, democracy, and political participation and control are the concepts that provide standards for defining the two terms and thus for assessing the claims of actual societies that they are socialist or communist. For writers whose focus is culture, the definitions of socialism and communism often turn on issues of consciousness and ethics: how these social arrangements are informed by distinct conceptions of humanity. Actual societies labeled socialist or communist are then evaluated in terms of whether their citizens are “new men and women” in terms of their attitudes toward life and community, their broadly defined interpersonal ethics.

For writers concerned primarily with economics, socialism and communism have most often been defined in terms of collectivized property ownership in the means of production. The extent of socially accountable economic planning and the prevalence of moral over material incentives have also served as indices of socialism and communism as has the principle governing the social distribution

of output. Marx's famous metaphor for communism as a society whose slogan is, "from each according to ability, to each according to need," was often understood as a literal definition separating communism from socialism, where the word "need" was replaced by the word "work."

A basic problem has afflicted Marxist, and indeed also non-Marxist, discussions of socialism and communism. The various political, cultural and economic definitions of socialism and communism have not been necessarily consistent with one another. A "socialist" distribution of property ownership could coexist with political power relations or kinds of cultural life that were judged emphatically as non-socialist and non-communist. Kinds of democracy could be achieved which some called "socialist," notwithstanding economic conditions universally understood as non-socialist. In the face of such conceptual difficulties at the level of basic definition, discussion has often taken one of two equally sterile turns. One option has been to insist on one definition as essentially correct or "ultimately decisive," which rendered all others as secondary or irrelevant and their proponents as wrong-headed or guided darkly by ulterior motivations. The other option has been to abandon the project of defining socialism and communism as intrinsically incoherent or practically inconsequential or both in an era of the "end of ideology."

Inconsistency, polarized contests among narrow and deterministic definitions, doubt about the terms altogether—these problems have devalued as well as plagued recent discussions of socialism and communism. Yet defining these key terms remains necessary: it amounts to a coming to terms with (learning and respecting the lessons from) the rich tradition of many peoples' struggles for what they have understood as socialism and communism. It also remains necessary if we are to be clear and persuasive about the kind of future society to which we orient our current activities. The task of defining what we mean by socialism and communism remains a continuing focus of the Marxian tradition. Hence, we must move beyond the unacceptable current state of that discussion.

Toward that end, our specific class analysis of communisms can be extended to conceptualize socialisms as well. Our position is not that this class conception is better than or more decisive than the others that have been and will be offered. We simply want to include it in the ongoing discussions which suffer because it is so often overlooked. Moreover, this class analysis also makes room for the other definitions of socialism and communism to enrich our definition (and vice versa), rather than to dissolve the discussion in fruitless recriminations pitting "correct" against "incorrect" views.

Communism denotes a social formation in which communist fundamental class processes and classless production arrangements predominate (in varying proportions) in the production of goods and services. Residues of non-communist fundamental class processes, if they survive, do not characterize more than a small share of production activities. In addition, political power (in a state, if one exists, or in decentralized sites otherwise) is controlled by groups—a communist dictatorship of the proletariat—committed to enlarge and extend classlessness at the expense of all types of fundamental class processes, communist as well as

non-communist. Of course, such commitments are no guarantee that their objectives can or will be realized. The social extent of classlessness determines whether any particular society will be understood as classless communism or as a communist class structure.

Socialism is different from communism in that it is not itself a class process, a unique form of producing and distributing surplus labor. Socialism also differs from communism because it denotes a social formation in which one or more types of the communist fundamental class process coexist in varying proportions with non-communist class processes. In contrast to communist social formations, in socialism any classless production arrangements, if they exist at all, do so in few instances of production and in more or less embryonic form. Political power is controlled by groups—a *socialist* dictatorship of the proletariat—committed to two broad goals: (1) to enlarge and extend the communist class processes, and (2) to shrink the scope and social influence of the non-communist class processes. These goals may, of course, be in contradiction if and when, for example, the non-communist class processes generate products which are essential inputs into the areas of production organized in communist class structures.

These notions of proletarian dictatorship do not refer, of course, to particular forms of government (parliamentary, autocratic, etc.). Rather, the term refers to the future class or classless structures to which such government is committed and toward which it directs policy (Balibar 1977). Hence, from a class-analytical perspective, the concept of proletarian dictatorship requires adjectives such as socialist or communist defined in the context of the class analysis of those terms themselves.

This way of posing the class definitions and dimensions of socialism and communism rejects any teleological notion that either one leads necessarily to the other. We must reject any theory of stages that makes socialism and communism necessary developmental steps in some unfolding history. Transitions to either can occur from the other; transitions from or to capitalism, feudalism, and so on are equally possible depending on the specific history of a particular society. No historical inevitability is presumed or implied in this formulation. Thus, the notion that socialism is a period of transition to communism can only be understood, from this perspective, as an expression of some groups' intentions; it does not describe any inherent property of socialism as such.

Our specifications of communism and socialism can be applied to societies currently labeled communist or socialist, such as the USSR. First we must determine for any society which precise class processes exist within it. To what extent are classless relations of production present? Is there a movement to communist from non-communist class processes or vice versa? Is there movement from class-structured social arrangements to classlessness or vice versa? Do effective commitments regarding these movements define either a socialist or communist dictatorship of the proletariat? The answers to these questions comprise an assessment of any society's relation to socialism and communism, to communist class structures and to classlessness. Our assessment would differ from those based on alternative Marxist approaches and the specific questions their proponents pose

to reach their assessments (cf. Sweezy and Bettelheim 1971; Bettelheim 1985; Sweezy 1985a,b).

We can integrate social analysis such as ours that focus on class—surplus labor production and distribution—with some of those whose emphases fall rather upon the organization of political power, property ownership, cultural formation, planning, moral incentives, and other aspects of social structure. We appreciate that they enter into their analyses of socialism and communism by focusing upon social dimensions other than class. We recognize as well that much of what they describe as, for example, communist or socialist democracy is as much an indispensable component of the future society we seek as is its communist class structure or its classlessness. If, in turn, their visions of true social democracy, cultural freedom, and egalitarian economic well-being recognize and include communist class structures and classlessness as components of the future they seek, a basis for integration of our theoretical perspectives and practical alliances will exist. We recognize, moreover, that the famous dichotomies that have haunted the Marxist tradition—moral versus material incentives, planning versus market, alienation versus non-alienation, and so forth—will be radically rethought as will be our own class analysis if such an integration occurs.

Such an integration cannot and should not obscure our differences and the exploration and confrontation of them in the ongoing discussion and debate. However, based on such a mutual recognition theoretically, the discussions of socialism and communism can emerge from a long, if sometimes quite brilliant, period of fruitless stalemate. That in turn might augur well for practical coalitions for socialism or communism. Steps in these directions would provide ample reward for the theoretical efforts in this paper.

Acknowledgment

We wish to thank the reviewers of *Rethinking Marxism* for their careful and helpful criticisms of our initial submission.

8 For every knight in shining armor, there's a castle waiting to be cleaned

A Marxist-Feminist analysis of the household

Question: What in your view is the exact connection between patriarchal oppression and capitalist oppression?

Answer: Of course housework doesn't produce any (capitalist) surplus value. It's a different condition to that of the worker who is robbed of the surplus value of his work. I'd like to know exactly what the relationship is between the two. Women's entire future strategy depends on it.

(Simone de Beauvoir, Schwarzer 1984: 38)

Today, nonfamily households (people who live alone or with unrelated people) outnumber married couples with children. The pundits may be saying Americans are returning to traditional lifestyles, but the numbers show that it just isn't so.

(Judith Waldrop 1989: 22)

Households and their profound influence upon modern society have been badly and unjustifiably neglected in social analysis. Marxist theory, and particularly its class analytics, can be applied to contemporary households to help remedy that neglect. Feminist theories of gender, of the social construction of what "male" and "female" are supposed to mean, can likewise yield original insights into the dynamics of households today. We propose here to combine the two approaches into a distinctive Marxist-Feminist theory of the household.

Instead of observing the unwritten rule that Marxist class analysis must stop at the doorstep and must not address what happens inside the household, we investigate the class processes inside. Similarly, we extend some Feminist discussions of the interaction between class and gender in markets and enterprises to an examination of their interactions within households. The resulting analysis shows that households in general, and contemporary US households in particular, display specific kinds of interwoven class structures and gender identifications. The class positions occupied within households depend upon and shape the definitions of gender lived by the members of such households. Moreover, the class and gender positions within households operate as both causes and effects of those positions outside households.

Finally, our theoretical argument and the empirical evidence that we offer will claim that basic class and gender transformations (revolutions) are underway in the United States today. They are occurring inside households—precisely where too many theorists and activists overlook them. Class and gender struggles are fought inside households as well as at other social sites (enterprises, the state, etc.). We shall suggest how those struggles within the households can influence virtually every other aspect of contemporary social life.

Marxist-Feminists have taken the lead in recognizing the importance of the household for social analysis. Unlike more traditional Marxists, they do not reduce the way society defines gender and allocates social positions along gender lines to matters of secondary importance. Nor do they view such matters as deriving from class. Unlike many other Feminists, they refuse to exclude issues of class from the explanation of gender divisions and their social consequences. Finally, their work has helped to put the household high on the agenda for social analysis, taking it out of the shadows to which most Marxist and non-Marxist social theories consign it.¹ However, Marxist-Feminists have not yet been able to integrate well-defined class and gender concepts systematically into a theory which recognizes and incorporates their mutual dependence and transformation. No complex class and gender analysis of the modern household is yet available; hence to begin one is a goal of this book.

We begin with a precise Marxist definition of “class”; the term refers to the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor (Resnick and Wolff 1987: chapter 3). It is thus a set of economic processes—processes concerned with the production and distribution of goods and services. Class is not the name for a group of people.² Women cannot comprise a class any more than men can; rather, women and men participate in class processes in various ways. It follows that wherever class processes may be shown to occur in society—wherever surplus labor is produced, appropriated, and distributed—that is an appropriate site for class analysis. As we shall show, this includes the household. We must then disagree with such Marxist-Feminists as Heidi Hartmann (1974, 1981a,b), Nancy Folbre (1982 and 1987), Zillah Eisenstein (1979), and others who apply class analysis only outside the boundaries of the household and chiefly to enterprises.³ All kinds of class process and all sites are grist for our mill, proper objects of Marxist-Feminist analysis.⁴

We also understand gender as a set of processes. Unlike the class processes, which are economic processes, the gender processes are cultural or ideological processes (Barrett 1980: 84–113). That is, they involve the production and distribution of meanings. By gender processes, we mean the processes of defining one specific difference between people—literally what it means to be female or male—and distributing such meanings socially. Just as one’s life is shaped by the particular class processes in a society, it is also shaped by the gender processes in that society. Indeed, how people produce, appropriate and distribute surplus labor depends on—and helps to determine—how they produce, distribute and receive definitions of what it means to be male and female.

As Marxist-Feminists, we ask the following questions about any site in a society that we may analyze:

- 1 Do class processes occur at this site, and if they do, which particular kinds of class process are present?
- 2 What gender processes occur in this society; that is, what meanings are attached to the concepts of male and female?
- 3 How do the class and gender processes interact at this site to shape and change it and the broader society?

In this book we address these questions in connection with the household in the contemporary United States.

Our Marxist class analytics (Resnick and Wolff 1987: chapter 3) distinguish necessary from surplus labor and fundamental from subsumed class processes. By necessary labor, we mean the amount needed to produce the current consumption of the producers themselves. Surplus labor is then the amount they perform beyond what is necessary. This surplus labor (or its products) is received—"appropriated" in Marxist terms—either by the people who produced it or by others. Those who appropriate the surplus then distribute it to themselves or to others. The organization of the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor comprises what we mean by a class structure.

The *fundamental class process* refers to the producing and appropriating of surplus labor. Individuals who participate in fundamental class processes (i.e. occupy fundamental class positions) do so either as producers or appropriators of surplus labor or both. For example, the worker who performs surplus labor in a capitalist commodity-producing enterprise and the capitalist who appropriates that surplus are occupying the two capitalist fundamental class positions. The *subsumed class process* refers to the distribution of the surplus labor (or its products) after it has been appropriated. Individuals can participate in a subsumed class process (i.e. occupy subsumed class positions) either by distributing surplus labor or by receiving a distribution of it. For example, the creditors of a commodity-producing capitalist enterprise and its hired supervisors obtain distributions (in the forms of interest payments and supervisory salaries, respectively) out of the surplus the enterprise appropriates. The distributing capitalist and the recipients of the distributions (creditors and supervisors) are occupying the two subsumed class positions. The subsumed class process aims generally to secure the conditions of existence of the fundamental class process (the two conditions in our example were credit and supervision). The appropriators distribute their surplus so as to continue to be able to appropriate it.

The Marxist tradition has recognized and specified different forms of the fundamental and subsumed class processes: communist, slave, feudal, capitalist, and so forth (Hindess and Hirst 1975). However, while Marx and Marxists named each form in terms of a historical period in which it was prominent, each has been found, in Eric Hobsbawm's words, to "exist in a variety of periods or socio-economic settings" (Marx 1965: 59). The point for Marxist class analysis is to

inquire about which of the known forms of the class processes are present in any particular society or social site chosen for scrutiny. It aims to assess their interactions and impacts upon the societies in which they occur. What we intend here is to focus Marxist class analysis on households within the contemporary United States.

We use the term “exploitation” in the precise Marxist sense as the appropriation of surplus labor from the direct laborer; it is an economic term referring to the fundamental class process. In contrast, we use “oppression” to designate the political processes of dominating other persons (directing and controlling their behavior). To exploit persons, then, means to appropriate surplus labor from them, while to oppress them is to dominate them. We separate questions about how individuals understand their situation (i.e. are persons aware of being exploited or oppressed and do these conditions occur against their wills?) from the situation itself. We use the two terms to distinguish certain economic from certain political processes, to explore their interactions, and then to inquire about how they are understood.

We approach gender from one Marxist perspective among Feminist theories. Gender refers to certain ideological processes within a culture. These include the production and distribution of sets of meanings which are attached to primary and secondary sex characteristics. Gender processes usually (but not always) pose differences as binary opposites. Biological differences between the sexes function as signs or markers to which meanings of femininity, as opposed to (as the “other” of) masculinity, are affixed. Physical differences serve as rationalizations or explanations for differences (oppositions) attributed to males and females across the entire spectrum of life expressions, from sexual preferences to emotional and intellectual qualities to career orientations.⁵

For us, gender exists in the realm of ideology, not biology. Gender processes project particular ideologies of the differences and relationships between female and male. Men and women engage in gender processes (as producers, distributors, and receivers of such ideologies) at all social sites—enterprises, churches, states, households, and so forth. A society produces multiple and often contradictory gender processes since they are shaped by all the other processes of the society. Legal, financial, ethnic, religious, and many other pressures combine to shape different gender processes projecting different conceptions of women and men. One pervasive gender process conceives of housework and childrearing as “natural” or “preferred” vocations for females, while other kinds of labor performed outside the home are more “natural” or “preferred” for males. An alternative gender process rejects such conceptions and argues instead for a notion of innate equality between men and women. Other gender processes offer still other conceptions of male and female. Individuals are pushed and pulled by the contradictory definitions of identities and proper lifestyles that are projected by alternative gender processes.

How individuals understand gendered identities influences what class positions they will accept or seek. Gender processes are conditions of existence for class processes; they participate in determining them. At the same time, gender

processes in any society are in part determined by the class processes there. How individuals participate in the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor influences their conceptualization of gender. As we shall argue, households are social sites in which gender and class continuously shape and change one another.

Households and class structures

Historically, the term “household” has carried many different meanings. Sometimes it has referred to the living space occupied by members of a family and sometimes also to the family’s working space. However, households have often included persons not considered family members, while family has often included persons not sharing a particular household. Indeed, “family” has been as variously defined as “household.” To begin our class analysis of households in the contemporary United States we need first to specify what we mean.

Our analysis focuses initially on households that display certain basic characteristics. They contain an adult male who leaves the household to participate in capitalist class processes (at the social site of the enterprise) to earn cash income. They also contain an adult female, the wife of the male, who remains inside the household. They may also contain children, elderly parents, and others, but that is of secondary importance at this initial phase of the analysis. The adult female works inside the household in the tasks of shopping, cleaning, cooking, repairing clothes and furniture, gardening, and so on. While such households do not describe the lives of all residents of the United States in both the past and the present, they do describe a household type generally viewed as quite widespread in the past and still significant in the United States today. In any case, our analysis of this type will then make possible a comparative analysis of other types characterizing contemporary households.

A Marxist analysis asks whether class processes exist inside this household type. There seems to be little dispute among Marxists that class processes exist outside the household in the United States. The male is usually presumed to participate in class processes at the enterprises where he is likely to be employed producing surplus labor for a capitalist. But does the female at home participate in class processes as well, and if so, how?

We believe that she does. She is a direct laborer inside the household. She transforms raw materials (uncooked food, unclean rooms and clothes, broken furniture, etc.) by laboring with produced means of production (stoves, vacuum cleaners, washing machines and detergents, various kinds of household hand tools, etc.). The results are use-values consumed by household members: prepared meals, cleaned rooms and clothes, mended furniture, and so on. Moreover, her labor is not only productive of such use-values, it is also divisible into necessary and surplus components. She does not only produce for her own consumption (necessary labor); she also produces more than that. She performs surplus labor. Her husband appropriates her surplus labor in the form of the household use-values that she produces for him. From a Marxist class analytic standpoint, this

wife in this type of household is engaged in a fundamental class process; so too is her husband.

Now this form of the fundamental class process is clearly not capitalist. The husband does not buy the labor power of the wife by paying her wages, no exchange of commodities occurs between them, nor does he sell on the market as commodities the use-values she produces. Since the products of her surplus labor are not sold, her surplus labor has no exchange value as it would have if she were participating in a capitalist fundamental class process. The husband does not engage in the drive to maximize some "profit" derived from her surplus labor, nor does he compete with others to do so. Therefore, if our class analysis of this household is to proceed, we must inquire as to what other, noncapitalist form of the fundamental class process best captures what is happening.

A consideration of the various noncapitalist forms of the fundamental class process discussed in the Marxist literature readily suggests which form best fits our household. It is the feudal form, that particular kind of fundamental class process which takes its name from medieval Europe, although it has existed at many other times both in Europe and elsewhere across the globe.⁶ The feudal form is appropriate because it requires no intermediary role for markets, prices, profits, or wages in the relation between the producer and the appropriator of surplus labor.⁷ The producer of surplus on the medieval European manor often delivered his/her surplus labor (or its products) directly to the lord of the manor, much as the wife delivers her surplus to her husband. Ties of religion, fealty, loyalty, obligation, tradition, and force bound serf and lord as much as parallel marital oaths, ideology, tradition, religion, and power bind husbands and wives in the sort of household we are analyzing here.

Of course, the presence of the feudal form of the fundamental class process is not the same as the presence of the feudalism that existed in medieval Europe. The feudal form will be different depending upon the social context in which it occurs. Just as feudal class processes in seventeenth-century China differ from those in Latin America in the nineteenth century, so do feudal class processes in contemporary United States households differ from those present on medieval European manors.

An objection might be raised to the designation of this type of household class structure as feudal. Clearly this woman's surplus labor helps to reproduce the labor power that her husband sells to the capitalist. If she raises children, she might also be said to produce future labor power for capitalists to hire. Given such a basic importance to the sustenance of capitalism, one might infer that she occupies a position within the capitalist class structure. While we agree that she provides crucial conditions of existence for the capitalist class structure outside the household, that, *per se*, does not suffice to make her part of it any more than slaves in the southern United States whose cotton production was crucial to British capitalism made them occupants of capitalist class positions.⁸ Class refers to particular social processes, and the woman in the household we are examining enters into no class process with capitalists. She does no surplus labor for them, and they distribute no appropriated surplus labor to her. Meanwhile, she does perform surplus labor which her husband appropriates inside the household.

It is conceivable that capitalists, fearing that housewives might not otherwise care for husbands and children, would decide to distribute some of their appropriated surplus directly to women in households. Then, by virtue of receiving such distributions, the women would participate in a capitalist subsumed class process. This conceivable but rarely evident situation should not be confused with notions such as the "family wage."

That males demand and sometimes obtain wages which are defined as partly for them and partly for their families is not equivalent to capitalists distributing directly appropriated surplus to women in households. The capitalist appropriator may distribute surplus to the male laborer or to the woman in the household or to neither. Only if the appropriator distributes to the woman is she involved in a capitalist subsumed class process. If the capitalist distributes to the male laborer, then only the latter occupies the subsumed class position. To collapse a distribution to the male as if it automatically passes to the female is to overlook precisely the sort of analysis of the household we intend.

The capitalist class processes centered in enterprises are distinct from the feudal class processes centered in the laborers' households, however much the two class structures may reinforce each other in particular historical circumstances. Wages are value flows within a capitalist class structure. They are conceptually distinct from the surplus labor flows within feudal class structures. Keeping them distinct is the logical prerequisite here for exploring the social relationship between them in the contemporary United States.

Capitalist and feudal class structures do not exhaust the possibilities within households. One can imagine (and there is historical evidence to suggest) that household members can be involved in slave class processes. Likewise, what Marx called the "ancient" fundamental class process, where direct laborers produce and appropriate their own surplus labor individually, and the communist class process, where direct laborers do the same, but do so collectively, could characterize households (Hindess and Hirst 1975; Jensen 1981; Amariglio 1984; Resnick and Wolff 1988a; and Gabriel 1989). We will return to these latter two class structures to argue that there is now a rapid transition to them in households in the United States.

In the feudal households we have described, the labor performed by women (necessary plus surplus) can be conceptualized quantitatively. Women spend blocks of hours shopping, preparing food, cleaning, repairing, serving, counseling, and so forth. An extensive literature has established that the American woman who is a full-time homemaker spends an average of over eight hours per day (roughly 60 hours per week) cooking, cleaning, preparing food, and so on.⁹ We may suppose that three hours per day are necessary labor, the quantity needed to reproduce the housewife's own existence as a performer of household feudal labor. Then the other five hours would be the surplus labor she performs for her husband.

The woman uses household means of production to provide surplus to the man in the form of services, products, or cash. In the case of services, for example, she cleans the man's living space in addition to her own. In the case of products, she

transforms raw foods into prepared meals for the man as well as for herself. If she sells the products of her surplus labor—sweaters, pies, childcare—she may deliver the cash receipts to the man.

For the feudal (rather than another) fundamental class process to exist in such a household and for women (rather than men) to occupy the class position of household serfs, the conditions of existence for this situation must be in place. That is, there must exist other nonclass processes, the combined effects of which produce such gender-divided feudal class processes in households.¹⁰ We group these conditions of existence into three kinds of social process: the cultural, the political, and the economic.

By cultural processes, we mean the processes of producing and disseminating meanings in society. For example, a woman's performance of feudal surplus labor results partly from explanations in churches and schools that proper womanhood means caring for a home and the people within it while adopting a subordinate position in relationship to the "master of the house." Such explanations also typically deny, explicitly or implicitly, that exploitation or oppression exists in households.

By political conditions of existence, we mean processes of establishing and enforcing rules of household behavior and adjudicating disputes over those rules. Thus, for example, the fact that laws punish physical or sexual assault outside the home while treating such assault within marriage more leniently or not at all, helps to condition household feudalism and women's position as household serfs. The political processes of establishing and differentially enforcing such laws help to define the feudal sphere of the household in which the rights of women in the home are different from the rights of citizens outside of the household. The political power of the lord of the feudal manor similarly facilitated his extraction of surplus labor.

By economic conditions of existence, we mean the processes of producing and distributing goods and services. Thus, for example, the economic processes of paying wages and salaries for female labor power that average 70 percent of that paid for male labor power pressure women into feudal households to achieve desired living standards. The commodity exchange processes outside the household then promote a different kind of exchange inside the household—women's indirect benefits from higher male paychecks in exchange for their production of household surplus labor for men.

Surplus labor appropriated by the husband is distributed by him (in labor service, product, or money forms) to accomplish a number of nonclass processes needed to secure the reproduction of the household's feudal class structure (assuming such reproduction is his goal). The recipients of these subsumed class distributions are expected to make sure that such nonclass processes occur. These occupants of subsumed class positions include individuals both within and without the household.

To ensure that the woman spends time producing surplus labor for the husband, feudal subsumed classes must, for example, secure processes of planning and organizing surplus labor tasks, directing and managing the surplus labor

performed, replacing depleted feudal means of production, and increasing such feudal means. These form a subset of the nonclass processes of household life that must occur for the woman's feudal class position to exist and be reproduced.

One of the many possible divisions of labor within a feudal household might involve the woman performing most of these nonclass processes by herself, her husband only keeping records, while both share the bill-paying. The husband distributes portions of the surplus appropriated from his wife to defray the costs of securing these nonclass processes from those who actually perform them. He distributes a part of his wife's surplus labor time (in labor, product, or cash forms) directly to her performance of particular nonclass processes. He distributes another part to himself to enable him to perform particular nonclass processes.¹¹

Of course, what subsumed class distributions aim to accomplish need not result. There is no guarantee that the needed nonclass processes will be performed properly or at all. For example, in the feudal household we have been considering, the wife may demand and receive a portion of her husband's appropriated surplus (as, say, a household budget) to sustain processes of household management. Suppose that she decided one day not to perform them, not to work beyond securing her own needs. She now cooks meals only for herself and cleans only her own space and clothing. Her husband arrives home to discover that his feudal existence as a surplus appropriator is in jeopardy. His wife is not running an efficient, well-managed, surplus labor operation within the household despite his satisfying her demand for a subsumed class distribution to do so.

His response might be to devote time to disciplining his wife to ensure her performance of surplus labor. He may supervise her directly. If he distributes a share of his appropriated surplus to himself to achieve either of these responses, he would then occupy a subsumed class management position within the household alongside any other class positions he may occupy.

Alternatively, gender processes may push her to discipline herself. She may need little if any motivation from her husband to do so. Such self-motivation can lead her both to produce a surplus and to manage its production efficiently. Gender processes may affirm that the household is the essential support of our society and that the essence of the household is its wife and mother. This might well instill in the woman the idea that her role in life as wife and mother is to shop, cook, clean, and so on, for her family while simultaneously becoming a super manager of all its activities. In such a cultural climate, she may well replicate the highly motivated managers of an industrial corporation.¹²

Men and women may then occupy different class positions within the feudal household—fundamental class positions as producers or appropriators of surplus labor and subsumed class positions as providers of this surplus labor's conditions of existence. To the degree that women occupy feudal subsumed class positions, they act to ensure their own continued exploitation. Men and women may share supervisory power in the household, just as they may share property ownership or anything else. The sharing of power or property does not necessarily lead to a rejection or even a questioning of the continued existence of feudal exploitation

in households. Whether or not it does depends on the entire social context in which the power or property ownership occurs.

The male also distributes portions of feudal surplus appropriated from the woman to people outside the household. Such subsumed class distributions secure other conditions of existence of feudal households. To take one kind of example, consider certain fundamentalist Protestant churches, conservative Roman Catholic churches, and orthodox Jewish synagogues. Feudal households may distribute surplus labor to such institutions in the form of cash, contributions in kind, or women's auxiliary services of all kinds. A nonclass process that all these institutions perform is the preaching of doctrines that prohibit or discourage birth control and abortion. Two effects of these doctrines are unplanned and often unwanted children. The care for such children, urged on women by all manner of other preachings and teachings in those religious institutions and at many other sites in society, ties women to their feudal household roles.

Consider, as one of several possible examples from the religious institutions cited, the orthodox Roman Catholic churches in the United States. They receive distributions of women's household surplus labor in several forms—as services in, for example, fund-raising, cleaning, and teaching; as products in meals offered to clerics and crafts given for the church to sell; and as cash in donations. Feudal husbands have appropriated surplus labor from their wives and distributed a portion of it to secure particular cultural (e.g. religious and gender) processes.¹³ The churches in question preach doctrines prohibiting divorce, birth control, and abortion. They affirm that women are not created in God's image and should be kept from the priesthood and other authority positions within the hierarchy (Adams and Briscoe 1971: 10–14; O'Faolin and Martines 1973: 128–33; Reuther 1974: 41–116, 150–291; Rich 1976: 134–37).¹⁴ Women's true vocation is maternal service as well as service to the husband. Such views are not limited to Catholic churches but exist comparably in fundamentalist Protestant churches and orthodox Jewish synagogues (O'Faolin and Martines 1973: 196–203; Rich 1976: 135; Delaney, Lupton, and Toth 1976: 10). The doctrines propounding these views are cultural conditions of existence for female feudal surplus labor in households.¹⁵ The religious institutions promoting such misogynistic attitudes often count women as the overwhelming majority of their active members.

We may now summarize our discussion to this point of the feudal household's complex class structure. First there are the fundamental class performers of feudal surplus labor—in our example, the women. Opposite them are the fundamental class appropriators of that surplus, the men. To secure certain conditions of existence of the household feudal fundamental class process, the surplus is distributed to persons who will engage in the nonclass processes that provide those conditions. Inside the feudal household, both men and women may provide some of these conditions and thus obtain distributions of surplus to enable them to do so. To the extent that men and women provide such conditions and receive such distributions, they occupy complex combinations of fundamental and subsumed class positions. Feudal surplus may also flow outside the household of its origins when other social sites (churches, schools, the state, etc.) provide its conditions

of existence and receive, therefore, subsumed class distributions. Then a class linkage connects households to other sites.

All sorts of contradictions and changes are occurring inside feudal households and in their relations to other social sites. They contribute to basic changes in the United States where enterprises are predominantly capitalist rather than feudal in their class structure. Before examining the class contradictions and changes, however, we will consider the gender processes conditioning feudal households.

Gender processes and the feudal household

Gender processes determine class processes and vice versa. Sustaining feudal household class structures requires that some people be exploited and that they somehow understand their situation to be desirable or the best available or else unavoidable. Gender processes, among others in the United States, have long inculcated in many women some or all of such understandings. In this way, gender processes have helped to fashion the feudal class structures inside households. Feudal class processes inside households have also contributed to prevalent gender processes in the United States. The exploited situation of women in feudal households has played its role in generating or supporting particular images of women and their proper roles in society. These gender processes have left deep impressions, even on women who have escaped from or altogether avoided feudal class positions.

One especially relevant set of gender processes concerns a particular concept or ideology of love. This concept of love is distributed through romance novels, magazines, legal principles, television and films, sermons, advertising, fairy tales, political speeches, and so forth. It holds that when a woman loves a man, a “natural form” for that love is the desire to take care of that man by marriage, preparing his meals, and cleaning up after him. Men’s love for women does not “naturally” take this form. Instead it is said that males want love and sex from females but are rather more ambivalent about lifetime commitment, via marriage, to financial support for the family (Ehrenreich 1983: 42–51).

Within this ideology of love, particular definitions of male and female are elaborated. Men fear the loss of their freedom, while women strive to ensnare them into marriage. Females want marriage with its assumed home maintenance tasks, childbearing, and childrearing. Males relinquish their freedom somewhat begrudgingly or, in intense love, freely relinquish it. Females seemingly have no freedom to relinquish. This ideology of love affirms that such marriages represent the best possible relationship for men, women, and children from their individual points of view (it secures “fulfilment” and “happiness”). It is also posited as the best in terms of society’s well-being.

In the context of such gender processes, feudal surplus labor production appears as a “natural” outgrowth of female love. It is thus not considered to be “labor” but rather has the meaning of “nest-making,” a biological metaphor signaling the “naturalness” of this way of expressing love. This ideology helps to impose on women their servile status and on men their lordly position within the

household. Through this ideology, the love of one human being for another becomes a means to facilitate class exploitation between them. Even today, when women's exclusive *performance* of most housework is beginning to be questioned, the reality of women's special *responsibility* for household maintenance remains unchanged (Hartmann 1981a: 366–94; Pleck 1982: 251–333; Blumstein and Schwartz 1983: 143–48; Hayden 1984: 81–84; and Hewlett 1986: 88–90).

A second set of gender processes that helps to reproduce feudal households involves the production and spread of biologically essentialist theories in forms that range from scholarly treatises to casual conversations. The gender ideology of biological essentialism has several faces. "Scientific" biological essentialism is represented by, for example, those theories that conceive feudal surplus labor in the household as an outgrowth of genetically programmed female passivity and male aggression (Ardrey 1961; Washburn and Lancaster 1968; Morris 1968, 1969; Tiger 1969; Dawkins 1976; Wilson 1976 and 1978; Lumsden and Wilson 1981; Barash 1982). Females need a protected place to rear children. Males' superior aggression somehow facilitates their roles as protectors of females, whose passivity "naturally" suits them for a private household situated outside of the aggression-ridden male spheres of industry and government. Women are, therefore, genetically suited to childbearing and household maintenance.

Biological essentialism can also appear with a religious face. God created women and men to be biologically different because he intended women to remain in the household rearing children while he intended men to function in the outside world. Such biological essentialism characterizes, for example, many anti-abortion movements: God intends women to bear children and people should not interfere with God's plans. Defining women in this way consigns them to home and housework and can serve to validate a feudal situation. Biological essentialism sometimes wears a psychoanalytic face. In some psychoanalytic schools, women are viewed as naturally passive and masochistic, willing to serve a cause or human being with love and selflessness, while men are naturally active and aggressive (Abraham 1920; Freud 1925; Bonaparte 1934; Deutsch 1944: 219–324 and especially 273). A feudal class position for women in the household would accord well with such views of women's nature. A variation on this theme emphasizes the physical appearance of female genitals as automatically generating the perception of them as castrated, lacking in comparison to male genitals. Females are, therefore, seen to be inferior; females disparage themselves and are disparaged by males. What can compensate females for their castrated anatomy is the ability to give birth, especially to sons (Erikson 1964: 582–606). To have babies and care for them in the household often follows as the social role for women warranted by their natural endowments.¹⁶

Gender processes affirming biological essentialism also surface within arguments about sexual activity. Males' aggressive sexual drives are contrasted to females' presumed lesser sexuality. Sex is described as something men want and women withhold or else they are thought to be suspect, tainted, and evil (Hays 1965; Prusack 1974: 89–116). Such gender processes impart a meaning to

sexuality which implies that “good” women (i.e. those not sexually active) need protection from men’s rapacious desires. They need one man to protect them from all the others. Women who are sexually active outside the household are in dangerous territory, fair game for the others. In the feudal households, they are ostensibly protected in return for delivering their surplus labor.¹⁷

Still other gender processes mix biological essentialism with different notions of how or why women belong in households doing surplus labor for men. There is the view that women are irrational and morally weaker as well as physically weaker than men. Freud attributes women’s inferior judgment to what he calls a lesser female super-ego (Freud 1977). Some writers cite women’s menstrual cycles or childbearing as placing them closer to nature and further from culture (Ortner 1974: 67–88; for a criticism of such views see Coontz and Henderson 1986). In such meaning systems, women belong in the home doing housework and need the supervision of superior males. If they work outside the home, the appropriate circumstances will be household-like situations such as waitressing and nursing within male-supervised institutions.

Gender processes affirming women’s inferiority do not necessarily or automatically relegate women to the household and to housework. The latter must themselves comprise a socially devalued sphere for the woman, as gender devalued, to be assigned to them.¹⁸ Other cultural processes must rank household production and childcare as less important, less prestigious, and less productive. Then the conditions are in place for the feudal fundamental class process to combine with the inferiority status attributed to women to consign them to the role of feudal surplus labor performers.

The gender processes discussed here influence the experiences of women in households and in the class processes occurring there. They contribute to the shaping of women’s conscious and unconscious ideas about themselves and their possibilities as female people. Many women today identify with their mothers who were usually feudal household serfs. They often feel intense pressure to validate their mothers’ lives by following in their footsteps to become future feudal housewives and mothers (Dinnerstein 1976; Chodorow 1978; and Fraad 1985).¹⁹

While our focus here is the interplay of class and gender processes, they are only two kinds of the many processes that shape the feudal household we have been analyzing. We turn next to certain political and economic processes that are conditions of existence for feudal households and for the particular gender divisions of class positions that they exhibit.

Political and economic conditions of existence

Political processes that formally or informally induce women to stay in feudal households performing surplus labor include a variety of laws and regulations. So-called “protective” legislation for women (and not for men) often eliminates women from work assignments necessary for job and income advancement. Many state laws and regulations require men only nominally to support their children financially, while they actually require women to care for children

physically. Laws and informal practices blocking women's access to birth control and abortion keep women at home caring for unplanned or unwanted children.

Many nonlegal regulations and conventions diminish women's options and so reinforce their feudal position in households. Sex discrimination in hiring and work assignment tends to keep women in lower-paid jobs. Corporate career advancement commonly requires adjusting one's life to weekend or evening meetings, unexpected overtime, and after-work socializing. Since such adjustments are difficult or impossible for women with primary childcare and household responsibilities, career advancement is all the more problematic. Sexual harassment can keep women out of the paid labor force altogether (Bergmann 1986: 308). Such conditions keep women dependent on the higher wage and salary incomes of men to raise children and secure desired living standards. That dependence translates into feudal household surplus labor production.

The absence of laws, or the failure to enforce laws, can also push women to "prefer" household to extra-household labor. For example, failure to enforce equal rights on the job can keep women in the household. Without laws requiring job return after paid maternity and paternity leaves and low-cost childcare centers, women are left with the domestic burdens of infant care. The absence of laws providing free healthcare for the elderly and handicapped prevents women with such responsibilities at home from competing as equals in the labor markets.²⁰ A remarkable political condition of existence of the feudal household in the United States is the fact that its housewives are workers for whom virtually no legal protection exists—no minimum compensation, no limit on hours, no requirement for health or pension benefits, no mandatory vacations, and so on (Hayden 1984: 65).

Political processes also include domestic violence, the threat of the use of physical force inside the household to control the behavior of its members. These are the household equivalents of police and military forces in the wider society. The syndrome of the battered wife is now well documented (Chapman and Gates 1978; Dobash and Dobash 1979; McNulty 1980; Pagelow 1981; Roy 1982; and Stacey and Shupe 1983). The class and gender positions of the women within traditional households are effects, in part, of potential and actual physical force used against them there.

Governments in the United States tolerate a degree of violence in the household not tolerated elsewhere in the society.²¹ A male spouse often has state-tolerated, if not officially sanctioned, freedom to dominate his wife physically. If and when the state intervenes in extreme cases, the abuser is often referred by the court to religious officials, psychiatrists, or marriage counselors, rather than being legally tried (Lerman 1981; United States Commission on Civil Rights 1982). Household violence is treated as fundamentally different from violence outside the household. The formal equality of all before the law, long seen as a political condition of existence of capitalism, is not in fact practiced inside the household. This is, perhaps, not surprising since it is feudalism and not capitalism that reigns there.

Indeed, there are arresting parallels between the political power of the man in the feudal household—whether or not exerted through physical force—and that

of the medieval lords of feudal manors. The lords often vested this power, including force, in manorial officials whom they maintained for that purpose (important subsumed classes of that time) (Duby 1968: 228–31; Bennett 1971: 151–92). In the United States today, male spouses may themselves occupy similar subsumed class positions within their households, controlling and perhaps forcing their wives to occupy feudal class positions.

The feudal position of women in feudal households is conditioned by economic processes in the United States as well as by political and cultural processes. The economic processes generating levels and changes in wages and salaries, job benefits, pensions, and social security benefits influence the quality of the feudal housewife's life and her rationale for remaining in such a life. Now that most American women are employed outside the home in addition to their work inside it, these economic processes condition household feudal class processes through their direct impact on wives in paid employment. Since women earn 70 percent of what men earn, and many millions of women hold part-time jobs with few or no benefits, they tend to remain financially dependent on men (Beechey 1987; Beechey and Perkins 1987). In this way, women's economic situations outside the household serve to reinforce their feudal positions within it.

Since infant and childcare are often private enterprises in the United States, their profit-driven prices keep many women at home or induce them to interrupt career progress to care for young children (Hewlett 1986: 82–88). Women stay home since their husbands can usually earn more in paid employment. Further, when women interrupt their careers, they earn even less over their working lifetimes and so heighten their reliance on the male's superior income and benefits. Moreover, evidence suggests that housework among couples is allocated in part on the basis of career success: the partner who has the more successful career does less or no housework (Blumstein and Schwartz 1983: 151–53). Such situations are conducive to feudal household class structures.

The pricing of commodities is another economic process that conditions the feudal household. High prices for meals (restaurants or "take out"), home maintenance services, healthcare, transportation, and care for the elderly or disabled pressure women into the feudal household production of these goods and services in noncommodity form. To take another example, the economic process of lending money is often constrained by criteria, such as job histories and salary levels, that discriminate against women. Without access to credit, women lose another means of moving out of a feudal household class structure.

Property ownership and feudal households

Surplus labor appropriation by males in feudal households may depend in part on differential access to property in the means of household production. There may be laws or customs in society established, adjudicated, and enforced which empower males rather than females to acquire and hold such property. If, in various ways, women are denied access to such property, much as serfs were denied it in medieval Europe, their propertylessness may push them into feudal

household class positions. If, however, women stop being so denied because laws, customs, and economic conditions change, they may acquire and hold property in houses, appliances, and so on. If women also own household property, they need no longer depend on men for the means to enable them to perform necessary and surplus household labor. They might, for example, appropriate their own surplus while working with their own property in their own households. In this case, ancient class processes would replace feudal class processes in households.

This is by no means necessarily the case. Women's ownership and access to property is a change in only one condition of existence of household feudal class structures. Only the political process of ownership (political because it concerns control of behavior, namely people's access to objects) has changed. Since the existence of feudal households cannot be reduced to merely one of the many conditions of their existence, it follows that women's access to property may, but need not, undermine feudal households. Whether and to what extent it does so depends on all the other social processes that produce such households. Since each of these other social processes is continually changing, so too are their influences on the presence or absence of feudal households.

Suppose, for example, that women's ownership of household property coincides with gender processes stressing the propriety of women being mothers and obedient wives. Women may then perform more feudal surplus labor without even imagining the possibility of using their power over property to resist their husbands' demands. If gender definitions stress pride in expertise and dedication to housework, as well as pride in ownership, the female may work extra hard to clean the feudal household of which she is the co-owner. Her co-ownership might then be a condition of existence of more rather than less exploitation by her husband. Similarly, gender processes which affirm that males should be in charge of all financial and property matters may well convince women to relinquish in marriage all control over what they own to their feudal husbands. It may well not occur to a feudal wife to demand any subsumed class payment from her husband for his access to her property. Indeed, women who accept the gender notion of their own incapacity for financial management may willingly and freely convey control over their property to males. The feudal housewife might also fear psychological or physical retaliation from her husband should she protest or struggle against his use of her property, without payment, to exploit her feudally.²²

All the other processes in society, including the conscious and unconscious processes within the family, combine to create gender processes specifying how individuals within households are to relate to, love, and mutually support one another. Within such relationships, joint husband and wife property ownership may be recognized as a progressive form of mutual sharing of material objects complementing the proper social role of each partner in his or her work. Gender processes may define the role of the male as the protector and supporter of the female by means of the sale of his labor power outside the household. The role for the female may be to do the same for the male by means of freely contributing her property and performing feudal surplus labor in the household.

The fact that women acquire property and the “right” to demand payments for making its use available to feudal males will not undermine feudal household class structures if women readily perform surplus labor for their husbands because it is thought to be a “natural” outgrowth of love. Within the ideology of love, it becomes unthinkable for women to use their political power to withhold property or to demand subsumed class payments for access to it. It is unthinkable, in part, because a woman can expect to get no support from others (courts, friends, etc.) if she does this.²³ The same ideology constrains the male appropriator of feudal surplus from making payments. Such actions would threaten and undermine the very social roles each has come to accept as a combination of nature, love, and socially acceptable behavior. These considerations may help to explain why joint property ownership between husbands and wives has not altered the feudal households of many Americans.

On the other hand, women’s ownership of property may become a change of importance to the feudal household. Political power over property has enabled some women to alter the terms of their marriages or to resist them altogether. For example, women’s threat to withhold their property may lead males to reduce their demands for surplus labor from their wives. The portion of the day that the female works for herself may expand at the expense of the portion of the day that she does surplus labor for the male in the feudal household. Then the feudal rate of exploitation has been altered in her favor. To take a second example, women property owners may demand increased subsumed class payments from their feudal husbands (e.g. larger household budgets) for making their property available to them: a greater distribution of the surplus labor they produce for their husbands. In both examples, the household’s *feudal* class structure would not have changed. The quantitative dimensions of the housewife’s feudal exploitation in the first example, and her receipt of subsumed class distributions in the second, would have changed.

We might expect such developments if the change in property ownership happened within a social context where, for example, women’s liberation movements actively sought to alter the predominant concept of women as best suited to be society’s homemakers and childbearers. To the extent that their efforts changed the prevalent gender processes and generated laws to reduce sexual harassment, sexual discrimination, and barriers to employment, women might be decreasingly inclined to accept their feudal positions in the household. Were women’s acquisitions of property to provoke or at least to coincide with sufficiently changed gender processes that stress female independence and equality, and with complementary changes in other social processes, then it might become possible for women to force a fundamental change in the class structures of households. They might demand the dismantling of feudal households and their replacement, for example, by households in which men and women both perform necessary and surplus labor collectively, then also collectively appropriate their surplus and decide how to use it for their mutual benefit—Marx’s idea of a communist class structure. As we shall argue, in some households this has happened and is happening.

The point is that change in the political process of property ownership enabling women to own property does not either weaken or strengthen feudal class processes in the traditional home. It does both. It grants a new degree of freedom to women: it opens possible options. Yet, it also confronts them with the need to make decisions about how to use that property, to whom to entrust its management (themselves, husbands, others). It may threaten husbands who retaliate in various ways to pressure women more heavily into feudal subservience. In short, the impact of property ownership on class is contradictory.

There is no way *a priori* to assess the effects of this change in one political process on the class and gender processes inside households. Those effects depend on the influences of all the other social processes which have an impact on the household. We cannot reduce a change in household class and gender processes *merely* to the effects of property ownership (or any other single phenomenon).

Contradictions and changes

Our discussion of gender and class processes in feudal households in the United States cannot explore all the other economic, political, and cultural processes that condition those households. Our goal has been rather to launch the Marxist-Feminist analysis which we think is needed and then to focus illustratively on some processes that strike us as particularly worthy of attention. However, we wish to stress that our analysis is not functionalist; the conditioning of the feudal household is contradictory. In our view, the selfsame social processes that in some ways promote women's class positions in feudal households can also be shown to undermine them in other ways. While feudal households have been and remain widespread in the United States, they have been full of shifting contradictions and tensions and, consequently, always changing. The contradictions and changes emerge from the multiple, different, and often inconsistent influences exerted upon feudal households by all the social processes that produce them.

The contradictions within the feudal household appear to have intensified in recent decades. The tensions and changes in feudal households threaten the conditions of their existence and may transform both their class and gender structures. New ways of thinking emerged in part from these tensions and changes, and in part from a broader questioning and examination of women's social situation generally. The notion of the "naturalness" of women's traditional position has been exploded. One result has been a rich, new literature of social analysis to which we are indebted. The connecting of parts of that literature to Marxian class analysis generates new questions. In the remainder of this chapter, we apply our Marxist-Feminist approach to obtain answers to some of these questions: Do the contradictions and changes in feudal households suggest that a crisis point has been reached? Are gender processes and female/male social divisions being fundamentally altered? Is feudalism in the household being displaced by radically different class structures? Are we witnessing a revolution in a Marxist-Feminist sense in American households?

Women today live a virtually infinite array of contradictions both inside and outside feudal households. On the one hand, they confront the biologically determinist notions that God or nature created women to remain in such households because they are unfit physically and psychologically for the outside world of compensated labor and must be protected from its burdens. On the other hand is the reality that the majority of women work outside the home.²⁴ The gender processes that define women as the “weaker” sex needing protection thus contradict the economic processes putting double or triple work burdens (housework and childcare in addition to paid employment) on such “weak” shoulders.²⁵

Gender processes holding that females are intellectually and morally inferior to males contradict the practice of giving females the nearly exclusive role of moral and intellectual guides for young people as mothers, daycare staff, and elementary school teachers. Similarly, the idea that organically passive, nurturing women need male protection because they cannot manage in the world conflicts with giving women custody of children to manage alone while working outside the home. It conflicts also with the fact that alimony payments are no longer routinely granted.²⁶ Finally, it conflicts with the reality that it is statistically rare for women actually to receive the largely inadequate child support payments granted to them by divorce courts.²⁷ There is a legal contradiction between compelling women to care for their children while only nominally requiring financial support from fathers and historically condoning fathers’ evasion of such minimal responsibility.²⁸

Laws and regulations that oppose birth control and abortion, such as the recent decisions of several states to deny government funds for abortions, coexist in contradiction with government refusal to support the resulting, often unwanted, and hence at risk, children. Another contradiction finds opposition to abortion as an immoral violence to an innocent child’s life coexisting with opposition to systematic protection of that child through free healthcare, daycare, education, housing, and so on. Protective legislation is supposed to free women by limiting their lifting of heavy objects and working overtime, by requiring female rest areas, and so forth. Yet in practice, these regulations are widely and safely ignored, especially in the so-called female professions of nursing, childcare, house cleaning, and industrial and office cleaning. Nurses and aides routinely move and lift heavy adult patients and often must work overtime. Housemaids and industrial office cleaning women routinely lift heavy furniture, industrial vacuum cleaners, and other things. Housewives lift children, furniture, heavy bags of groceries, and work “overtime.”

The gender process that depicts males as sexually aggressive contradicts the weak protections for women against sexual harassment. Ostensibly aggressors against women, men are nonetheless supposed to protect them in traditional marriages while genuine support and financial alternatives for battered wives are nowhere systematically available. The ideological representation of women as passive and less sexual than men contradicts the media’s pervasive presentation of them as infinitely sexual.

Women are pressed simultaneously to stay at home to care for families and to earn funds outside to sustain proper family life. On the one hand, gender ideologies

and laws and regulations block birth control and abortion for women. They marry into and remain in feudal households because they cannot otherwise financially support the children. Yet in recent years, the lowering of real wages and the reduction of public services push housewives into the wage labor force.

Change emerges in feudal households through the contradictory interactions of their class processes, the gender processes in society, and the distribution of power within contemporary marriages. Marriage is a particular form of social contract between men and women, in which each is recognized to have responsibilities to the other. Mutual obligations are sanctified by religions, celebrated by the mass media, and enforced by laws. Each spouse becomes inscribed in a complex set of socially recognized and enforced rules, attitudes, and desires. Interwoven with the conscious ideologies of marriage that influence behavior are the unconscious meanings that people associate with marriage and that shape their behavior as well. A relationship in which the marriage contract is present gives each spouse specific powers over the other. Yet these specific powers are also constrained by the social construction of the marriage contract.

The male's recognized right and obligation to work hard outside the household to support his family and protect it from economic suffering is complemented by the female's understood right and obligation to work hard inside the household to support and protect her family. However, each spouse may respond to the contradictions we have noted in the feudal household by using marriage rights and obligations to improve his or her situation at the expense of the other spouse's authority, self-image, or class position.

These exercises of power can take many forms. They may include a woman's assumption of the design and decoration of the household to her tastes, not the male's. A wife may attempt to reduce the amount of surplus labor she performs or change the form in which she delivers surplus labor by arguing that marriage empowers her to order her own and others' behaviors inside the household. The exercise of power over children may be used by women to forge familial alliances of themselves and children against their husbands. This may exclude husbands from intimacy with children by presenting the father as someone to avoid and fear while presenting the mother as the channel for all personal information and contact.

The wife may perform her household labor with demonstrative suffering to generate guilt and exact penance from her husband. Sexual processes between men and women will not remain unaffected by such power struggles. When women plan their household labor, they may define that labor to exclude or minimize tasks they dislike and maximize those they enjoy. For example, a feudal housewife may define her primary task as child-rearing and education and so neglect household maintenance, including the surplus labor and products destined for her husband.

The male, as receiver of his spouse's surplus labor, may have his feudal household life threatened by this type of behavior. He may be unable to get to work on time, and thereby jeopardize his job, because his clothes are not clean and ready, or because there is no food in the house. If he begins to undertake household tasks, he may be unable to arrive at work rested, to function productively, to work

overtime, and to advance his career. He may be forced to purchase commercial laundry and food services which erode his financial base as a feudal lord and also erode, as we shall see, his capitalist role as a seller of labor power outside the home. Similarly, the power structure of marriage may translate a wife's illnesses, alcoholism, or other incapacitating conditions into demands upon the male for household labor and expenditures that effectively undermine his feudal and capitalist class positions. Illnesses and plagues likewise brought crisis to medieval feudalism and contributed in places to its disappearance.

On the other hand, the male's responsibilities and obligations to support and protect his family may be exercised inside the household in ways that maximize the female burden of performing feudal surplus labor. He may dictate that, as the "master" of the house, his tastes and preference must prevail regardless of their impacts on "his" wife and children. The man may decide not to spend on such labor-saving machinery as a microwave oven. He may decide that daycare or nursing help for elderly relatives are unnecessary expenditures, and instead pressure his wife into caring for them through more surplus labor exacted as her wifely duty. He, too, may be an alcoholic or ill and unable to hold the kind of job allowing him to provide means of production for his wife's labor in the household yet pressuring her to compensate through more surplus labor. He may be unemployed for any reason and do the same.

The rights and obligations of partners in marriage—the political processes within the relationship between them—are pushed and pulled in all manner of contradictory directions by all the other processes of the society in which the marriage exists. Marriage rights and obligations, and even the marriages themselves, become objects of conflicts and struggles. These struggles over power within the household are also complex causes and effects of struggles there over class and gender processes. On the one hand, resignation, depression, compromise, stalemate, separation, or violence may follow. On the other, crises in marriages and feudal households may also lead to transitions to new households and new marriages, to nonfeudal class structures there, and to new gender and political processes comprising new interpersonal relationships.

Among the possible results of such interconnected struggles is violence by one spouse, usually the male, against the other.²⁹ Many of the same institutions which help to create the conditions for marriage have increasingly had to support or create new mechanisms—religious family counseling, state social agencies, battered women's shelters—to address the tensions, struggles, despair, and often violence besetting American households. The marriage contract and joint property ownership mean that the male in a feudal household cannot easily replace a recalcitrant spouse with a more docile surplus labor provider. Females cannot legally be thrown out of such households or separated from their marriages and property without formal settlements and compensation. Similarly, a married female surplus labor producer, especially one with children, cannot easily escape a particularly hostile household.

Thus, the marriage contract serves in some ways to support the feudal class structure of traditional households and yet, in other ways, to undermine it. In part,

it drives the female to provide surplus labor for the male, while it also stimulates and enables her to push in the opposite direction. The resulting contradictions, in which female surplus labor producers and male appropriators are pulled in different directions, help to generate the dynamic of the feudal household. It may continue to exist, although with continually changing class and nonclass processes. Alternatively, the feudal household may reach a crisis point where its contradictions explode.

One result of crisis may be the destruction of the feudal household through divorce.³⁰ Another result may be the construction of entirely different, nonfeudal class processes within households. Divorces may be painful adjustments followed by remarriages in which new partners readily reestablish households with feudal class structures and traditional gender divisions. Or divorce may be a first step in establishing households with different class structures of the ancient and communist sort and different gender divisions. In any case, we may speak of the crisis of the feudal household as a moment when the survival of the feudal household is in jeopardy, and a social transition to radically different households is possible. Such a moment may be at hand in the United States today. However, to explore this possibility further, we need to consider the impact of capitalism on feudal households—how its particular influences contribute to crisis and change in those households.

Capitalist and feudal class interactions

Our thesis is that the United States has long included many feudal households of the sort we have been discussing.³¹ If we are right, it follows that any class analysis of the United States requires examination of the usually neglected interactions between capitalist class processes outside the household and the existence and possible crisis of feudal class processes within it. Women in the United States have often, and increasingly in recent decades, added to their feudal household surplus labor the sale of their labor power to capitalist enterprises. This addition has created the “double shift” in the household and the enterprise.³² These women move, on a daily basis, between two dissimilar class structures making dissimilar claims upon their time, energy, thoughts, and feelings.

To the contradictions we have noted within the feudal class structure of the household must be added those within the capitalist class structures of enterprises and those that arise between the two different social sites. A crisis of feudal households in the United States may be one result of the interactions between capitalist and feudal class structures. Such a crisis would represent a possibly transitional conjuncture—to nonfeudal households—the ramifications of which could transform the entire society, including its gender processes and the class processes at all other sites. The possible presence and qualities of a crisis in feudal households is thus an urgent problem and object for Marxist and Marxist-Feminist theory. After all, concern with historical transitions and class transformations such as Europe’s “passage from feudalism to capitalism,” current shifts from non-capitalist to capitalist class structures in the Third World, and socialist revolutions

have long been central foci of Marxist analyses. Is it possible that revolutionary transformations are underway in an unexpected site, the household?

To assess the possibilities of a revolutionary transformation arising out of the interactions between the two sites, we will examine how the existence of feudal class processes within households affects capitalist wage exploitation and how the existence of capitalist class processes within enterprises affects the exploitation of women within feudal households. Our goal is to clarify when and how the relationship between capitalist enterprises and feudal households could reinforce or destroy one or both of them.

The different class processes at the two sites depend upon and affect each other. However, their interactions are mediated by all the other processes in the society. No one particular outcome of their interaction is necessary or inevitable. For example, the existence of female surplus labor in feudal households may coincide with either high or low, rising or falling, wages. In our approach, capitalist and feudal class structures at different social sites are not necessarily either compatible with or hostile to each other. We must therefore disagree with other participants in current debates on the household who see a constant, predictable relationship between females' unpaid household labor and men's capitalist wages.³³

Let us consider first the example of a male occupying two dramatically different class positions. In the household, he appropriates "his" woman's feudal surplus labor; at the workplace, he performs surplus labor for his capitalist employer. On the job, he is exploited; at home, he exploits. The woman in this simplified example occupies only one class position, that of feudal serf. Let us locate this man and woman in the United States of the 1980s. There has been a war on taxes and the governmental services and service jobs they provide. Unions are increasingly under attack by state officials and capitalists. They have serious internal problems and declining memberships. They are losing strikes, credibility, and the initiative in industrial disputes.³⁴ Unemployment, by historical standards, has remained high across the decade. Low-wage service sector jobs partially replace high-wage jobs lost in manufacturing. Women, especially, enter the low-wage sectors as both an effect and cause of falling wages. One result of these and other conditions is a falling real wage for men selling their labor power.

To offset the impact of a falling real wage, this man may push this woman to increase her household surplus labor to maintain the standard of living that he derives from his two class positions. He may insist on more home cooked meals, more cleaning, and more care of relatives to replace costly conveniences such as dry cleaning, restaurants, nursing-home care, purchased entertainments, and so on. In this case, the feudal household functions to sustain lower wages and thereby higher enterprise profits. It enhances capitalist development. Looking at the situation from the vantage point of the household, enterprise capitalism can contribute to an increased rate of women's feudal exploitation in the household. Feudal households can help to make possible lower wages that might not have been tolerated otherwise.

The particular relationship between feudal households and capitalist enterprises depicted in our example has been recognized by other analysts of the household

(although in different theoretical terms). However, they tend to treat this one of many possible relationships as the *necessary* relationship. For them, the household labor of women is a straightforward, predictable affair that always benefits capitalists at women's expense (Eisenstein 1979; Gardiner 1979; Fox 1980; Seecombe 1980; Dalla Costa and James 1980; Coulson, Magav, and Wainwright 1980; Sokoloff 1981; Hartmann 1981b; Delphy 1984; Folbre 1987). We disagree. Under alternative conditions, feudal households (with or without increasing feudal exploitation) can contribute to rising wages. There are still other conditions in which capitalist class processes in enterprises (with or without increasing wages) help to reduce feudal exploitation in households, benefiting women at the expense of men.

We may illustrate the range of possibilities with a second example. In the United States in the late 1960s, the labor market was relatively tight. The Vietnam War had absorbed many workers while an inflated economy absorbed many others. President Johnson's "Great Society" drew many workers away from private employment and into government social services. Workers were able to use their then still effective unions to push up wages. At the same time, a militant and rapidly growing women's liberation movement made women's oppression its target. We may suppose that this movement decreased women's surplus labor production in at least some feudal households. Where men could obtain higher wages, they could thereby compensate for reduced feudal surplus labor from their wives at home.

Such male workers were both provoked by their wives and enabled by market conditions to charge their capitalist employers a premium over their previous wages. In this example, specific social processes shaped the interaction between feudal households and capitalist enterprises such that feudal exploitation was reduced at capitalists' expense.³⁵ The premiums paid to workers reduced the amount of surplus value available to capitalists to secure such other conditions of existence as management, research, and capital accumulation (Resnick and Wolff 1987: 109–230). Changes in the class structure of the household here contributed to a weakening of capitalist enterprises. Stated conversely, the capitalist enterprises had compensated for weakened household feudalism, but in ways that made their own reproduction more difficult. In contrast to our first example and to other theories of the household, this second example shows how the feudal household can function as a barrier to capitalist development.

To take a third example, we may return our attention to the falling wage situation of the 1980s. We have seen, in our first example, how this situation could contribute, in some households, to greater feudal exploitation of women. In other households, however, the lower wages could contribute rather to a lesser rate of feudal exploitation or even to a displacement of feudal class processes from households altogether. During the last decade, many more American women entered part-time and full-time employment. They have often been motivated by desires to maintain family living standards when faced with their husbands' declining real wages. They have also been influenced by those voices within the women's movement that extolled wage labor over unpaid labor in the household.

Many were driven by the financial consequences of divorce, then and now occurring at a rate of 50 percent among newly married people and at an even higher rate for those in second marriages (Blumstein and Schwartz 1983: 34).

Women who sell their labor power often have to reduce their performance of feudal surplus labor at home. Double shifts take their toll. Opting for capitalist exploitation in the enterprise, they may no longer tolerate feudal exploitation at home. Divorced women often break with feudal traditions and establish single adult households without lords or serfs—the ancient class structure cited above. Some women establish still another kind of nonfeudal household in which the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor is accomplished collectively—the communist class structure mentioned earlier. In these circumstances, falling real wages in the capitalist sector contribute to the transition of some households out of feudal class structures altogether.

Capitalist enterprises do not always profit from the feudal class structure of households, nor do the latter always flourish alongside capitalist enterprises. They may strengthen, weaken, or destroy one another. Gender processes will both influence and be influenced by the interactions between the different class processes at the two sites. Marxist-Feminists need constantly to reassess the varying interactions between the two sites and the two kinds of process to adjust accordingly their revolutionary strategies. An alliance of Marxists and Feminists will be more flexible, more durable, and more effective if it is aware of the range of possible interactions between feudal households and capitalist enterprises. Different interactions generate different relationships, thoughts, and feelings among household members—matters of importance to advocates and strategists of social change.

Changes in the amount of surplus labor produced and appropriated within feudal households do not occur without tensions, if not also struggles, between men and women. In our first example, where men compensated for reduced wages by exacting more feudal surplus from women at home, we implicitly presumed that women offered no effective resistance to those exactions. In the second example, where feudal wives produced less surplus for their men, the latter were compensated by obtaining higher wages; here we implicitly presumed that employers did not resist. Yet we need to question these presumptions.

For example, changes in the capitalist existences of males can produce contradictions and tensions in feudal households. If wages fall, and men pressure their wives for more feudal surplus labor, the women may resist and tensions may mount. To take another example, if women reduce their household feudal exploitation, contradictions, and tensions may intensify, especially if the husbands' wages cannot then be raised. Such contradictions and tensions can have far-reaching social significance.

Contradictions and tensions in the household

To the degree that women resist pressures to increase feudal surplus labor to offset men's falling wages, the men's living standards may fall. This may exacerbate contradictions and produce tensions inside and outside the household. If women

do not prevent an increase in their feudal exploitation while men's wages rise simultaneously, men's living standards may rise sharply. Still other contradictions and tensions will then arise.

Tensions in households will depend on and shape how men seek greater flows of goods and services within feudal households. Their options are: (1) increasing the rate of feudal exploitation by having wives work fewer hours for themselves and more for their husbands; (2) increasing the number of individuals who do surplus labor in the household; and (3) increasing the productivity of household labor so that more goods and services are produced in the same time. The first option directly pits man against woman and increases tensions between them accordingly (Rubin 1976; Westwood 1985). In terms of the second option, men can enhance the flow of surplus labor in feudal households by adding laborers such as children, relatives, or live-in servants. Where this option is pursued, another set of contradictions and tensions will arise in feudal households.

The third option involves increasing the productivity of household labor by improving the management and organization of housework tasks or by using more and improved means of production (Hartmann 1974; Vanek 1980). By these means, a feudal wife's surplus labor time can remain unchanged, while a larger quantity of goods and services are produced for the husband in that time. However, since these improved means of household production are usually capitalist commodities, the male would have to allocate portions of his wages to buy them. To afford them, he would have to reduce the purchase of wage goods for himself. Tensions can arise between men and women in feudal households over the quantity, quality, and timing of purchases of such means of production. Men may also press for increased rates of feudal exploitation to offset at least the initial impacts on their living standards of such purchases. In any case, the contradictions and tensions in households will influence the mix of options males pursue, and vice versa.

The money problems faced by husbands in feudal households are not limited to shifting from the purchase of required wage commodities to the purchase of household means of production. They must also pay taxes, donate to churches, and purchase commodities needed as inputs into household production (raw food, soaps, etc.). Where feudal households have been established on the basis of credit (home mortgages, automobile loans, credit card debt, etc.), husbands face large interest payments.³⁶

To secure his feudal class position, the husband must distribute household feudal surplus labor in all these *cash* forms. Yet that surplus is rarely supplied to him in cash; it is usually in the form of his wife's services or products. Thus, the husband uses his cash wages not only to buy means of consumption, to reproduce the labor power he sells to capitalists. He also transfers some of his wages to make the cash feudal subsumed class payments needed to reproduce his feudal household.

Spending a portion of wage revenues to maintain the male's feudal household class position raises another possibility of a clash between the feudal household and enterprise capitalism. What is left of his wages to buy goods and services may

not be enough to reproduce the labor power he sells every day. He may then try to divert some of his wife's surplus labor or products away from securing the household's feudal class structure and to the securing instead of his own capitalist class position (i.e. to his own consumption). If he fails to do this, perhaps because of his wife's resistance, his health may deteriorate and his productivity in the enterprise suffer. If he takes a second job, as so many Americans now do, he may maintain his consumption of goods, but at the cost of exhaustion and ill health. Were these conditions to impair productivity generally, feudal households would become obstacles to capitalist production and development.³⁷

There may be struggles in the household over how much of the male's wage revenues is to be used to secure the needs of the feudal household.³⁸ Men would be better off individually if they could receive more feudal surplus with a smaller transfer of their wages to feudal household outlays. Women would be better off individually if they could produce less feudal surplus and receive more transfers of wage income to pay for more feudal household outlays. Men are driven to give less of their wages to wives for household means of production, donations to church, consumer debt repayment, childrearing expenses, and so on, in order to maintain their capitalist position as wage-earners. Yet, they are also driven to give more of their wages to their wives to secure the requirements of their position as feudal lords. They are, of course, also motivated by their complex thoughts and feelings about other household members.

Feudal wives are also torn. On the one hand, they need to press their demands for the money with which to maintain the feudal household. On the other hand, they cannot push the feudal lords too far. Many fear violence. Most fear the loss of security of a feudal household and the males on which it, and hence they, are financially dependent.³⁹ Yet, women may rebel when husbands do not maintain their feudal obligations, particularly their financing of feudal means of production. In these circumstances, increased feudal surplus labor for the man may mean reduced necessary labor for the woman. Her standard of living will fall, and she may rebel. These rebellions are expressed in both open and subtle forms (Rubin 1976: 69–81; Westwood 1985: 177–83).⁴⁰ Rebellion threatens violence and the end of the feudal household. It is tempered by concern for the husband, the children, and the marriage. Women may want to compensate their husbands for financial difficulties and resulting emotional depressions. They may agree with the husband's view that it is the woman's task to make everyone happy, to hold the family together. That, after all, is their traditional role, the effect in part of the powerful gender processes that mold them.

Women are caught in a particular dilemma. To resist openly the demands of their men and their feudal position undermines their own understanding of their role in the household and in society at large. It can challenge certain prevailing gender processes. Women's identities are at stake. Yet, to yield to the demand for more feudal surplus labor, especially at a time when real wages are falling, also creates a difficult situation for them. Women could reduce their surplus labor within feudal households and compel children to become surplus labor producers alongside their mothers. Or, where children already perform feudal surplus labor,

women could increase their rates of exploitation.⁴¹ Many women both decrease the necessary labor for themselves and increase their total household labor hours: they quite literally work themselves to death (Delphy 1984: 50–53).

Others may resist such demands and “escape” their feudal household existence through separation or divorce. However, since divorced and separated women are often plunged into poverty, the most common choice for women is to seek new income-generating positions outside of the household, while usually remaining in feudal bondage. They may supplement their husbands’ wages with their own while still performing feudal surplus labor at home.

We do not want to suggest that unemployment, falling real wages, rising prices for household means of production or increased demands for household surplus labor are the only reasons for women to enter paid employment. Even in prosperous times, women may seek such employment because of their preferences for capitalist over feudal exploitation, given that the former was so often closed to them. At times (e.g. during the Second World War), the state has directly encouraged women to enter the wage labor force (Milkman 1987). In any case, just as the contradictions within and between feudal households and capitalist enterprises influence many women to enter paid employment, so such employment introduces its set of new contradictions and tensions into the household. The forces undermining the feudal household can be brought to crisis intensity when feudal wives move massively into wage employment.

Women, wages, and class struggles

When wives, as well as husbands, from feudal households sell their labor power for wages, both will need to make consumption expenditures to secure the conditions of existence of their wage labor positions. However, to understand the complex consequences of women’s wage labor, we must look beyond aggregate family incomes and expenditures to the many changes and perhaps even class transformations occurring in feudal households and to the changes in capitalist enterprises. Women’s wage labor may have changed the feudal class structure of the household, changed gender processes inside and outside the home, and changed the interaction between feudal households and capitalist enterprises.

In recent US history, women who have entered the paid labor force increased their total work week by 14–25 hours.⁴² The average non-employed wife spends 56 hours per week on housework, while the average employed wife spends 30 hours per week on housework, in addition to 40 hours in paid employment plus travel time to and from paid employment. The higher family income costs women an increased work week, as well as capitalist exploitation added to feudal exploitation.⁴³ When women do full-time wage labor, the evidence suggests that their husbands do not appreciably increase their participation in domestic work.⁴⁴ Instead, the burden on them more likely takes the form of reduced domestic services as their wives do less surplus labor (Strober 1980: 386–400). This adds strains to the feudal household as men and women struggle over the allocation of

women's wage revenues between household costs and their personal wage-earning needs (comparable to the tensions noted earlier over men's allocations of their wages). There may also be problems of guilt and anger about reduced female surplus labor.

Women's participation in paid employment can provide both financial and emotional support for women to make demands for change within the household.⁴⁵ Women on the job gain comfort and strength from the support of female co-workers.⁴⁶ They gain some measure of financial independence. Thus, two of the conditions of existence of feudal class processes in the household, women's nearly total financial and emotional dependence on husbands, may be eroded with their entry into paid employment. Women as wage laborers often develop new needs with respect to their home lives or are driven to express needs they felt earlier but repressed. The former acceptability of a steady, financially dependable husband gives way to demands that husbands value and provide supportive companionship, emotional sharing, and intimacy, in addition to equal sharing of the household labor tasks. With new personal support systems and new financial resources, women may challenge men's feudal lordship position or decrease their feudal production of domestic use-values or both. Men, in turn, may feel their feudal position to be threatened and may reinforce it by heightened demands for surplus labor.

These contradictory pressures can precipitate serious tensions and conflicts inside feudal households—more or less intense struggles over any aspect of relations between husband and wife, between parents and children or other household members. Shifting alliances among male and female adults and children can coalesce around the varying objects of struggle—childrearing practices, major commodity purchases, drinking habits, sexual behavior, and styles of dress, among other things. Under certain social conditions, they can become class struggles—struggles over the quantitative or qualitative dimensions of the feudal class processes themselves.

These are class struggles because their objects are class processes. Parents, children, relatives, and friends in varying combinations or alliances can take opposing positions on change versus stasis in the household's class structure. One side, perhaps led by the male appropriator, may seek to retain the feudal form of the class process and to increase the rate of feudal exploitation of women. The other side, led typically but not necessarily by the female surplus labor producer, aims at least to reduce feudal exploitation or sometimes even to change the household class structure to a nonfeudal form.

These class struggles become revolutionary if they move households toward a transition from feudal to nonfeudal class structures. Instead of women performing feudal surplus labor for their husbands, they can demand changes that involve an equal sharing of household tasks. If men and women together (collectively) perform both necessary and surplus labor, collectively appropriate their surplus, and collectively decide the distribution of that surplus, the households have accomplished a transition to a communist class structure (Resnick and Wolff 1988a). Household class struggles can become revolutionary in other ways—if

people leave feudal households (via divorce or separation) and establish new communist households (both gay and heterosexual), or if they establish one-adult households in which they perform and appropriate their own surplus labor individually.

The changed gender processes defining maleness and femaleness that are necessary for revolutionary changes in household class structures are themselves revolutionary alterations in the culture. Moreover, such changes in class and gender processes are also revolutionary in emotional terms. Relatively few contemporary women or men have had familial models of shared intimacy, shared decision-making, shared housework, and shared, mutually supportive companionship or models of one-adult households. Yet, many are now caught up in struggles and transitions for which they have been emotionally as well as theoretically ill-prepared.

The conditions of existence of such revolutionary changes evolved historically with much difficulty, pain, and danger. Statistics about domestic violence, alienation of children from parents, sexual activity, separation, and divorce are so many indices of this. We are struck by one other index. By the 1970s married women in the United States had become the prime users of psychotropic drugs and psychotherapy. Married women are the social group now considered to be most at risk for mental breakdown, while the second and third riskiest groups are single men and married men respectively. Single women have the lowest risk of mental breakdown (Chesler 1972; Berch 1982: 199–200; Showalter 1985: 195–250; Rapping 1987: 18). Although risk is overdetermined by many interacting causes, these rankings do suggest the pressures on married women.

The tensions and strains inside traditional households may drive women sooner or later to leave paid employment and resign themselves to lives within feudal households. There are certainly political, cultural, and economic processes pushing for that historical “solution” to the current crisis in the household. Political conservatism, gender processes resisting changes in the conception of woman, economic processes consigning women to poorly paid employment—these and other processes reinforce the feudal option for households. Yet, there are also processes supporting other options such as communist or ancient households. Political radicalism, new concepts of gender, and improving economic possibilities for women are among the processes making possible and favoring radically different “solutions” to households in crisis.

The struggles in feudal households may react upon the other sites in society in ways which deepen the crisis. For example, the religious ideologies that have long sanctified feudal households (as “the family”) are increasingly arenas of struggles over those ideologies and the personnel who articulate them. The burning questions include abortion, birth control, homosexuality, and the roles of women in church leadership. The churches have become social sites of struggle among individuals over the cultural, political, and economic processes that together comprise modern religion. These struggles, and their effects upon religion, can deepen the crisis of the feudal household by questioning and sometimes removing certain of its religious, gender, and other conditions of existence.

The federal, state, and local levels of government have also become sites at which conditions of existence of the feudal household are being contested. Literature produced and distributed by state agencies, curricula for all levels of schools, regulations, and laws are now objects of struggle. Groups with very different definitions of gender and very different preferences for and participation in particular household class structures confront the state. Their concerns include policies, regulations, and laws such as those governing abortion and birth control rights, gay rights, adoption procedures, domestic violence, spousal rape, child support by divorced parents, protected maternity and paternity leaves from employment, rights to guaranteed childcare, and social security provisions for the elderly and disabled. As with struggles to change religion, campaigns to alter state policies can also question or remove conditions of existence of household feudalism.

Despite crisis conditions in feudal households, men and women may hold on to them to avoid the threat and the consequences of their disruption. The feudal class structure and traditional gender divisions may then continue, although often leaving couples with feelings of alienation and loneliness, expressed as psychological depression, alcoholism, and extra-marital sexual activity among other ways.⁴⁷ Although millions of American couples remain in feudal households, we believe that they do so with ever greater difficulty. The mounting intensity of non-class struggles over gender processes and other cultural, political, and economic processes, inside and outside the household, is taking a heavy toll on the stability, tranquility, and viability of those households. In recent years, the addition of class struggles over reducing wives' feudal surplus labor and over the transition to non-feudal class-structured households has brought millions of households to a crisis state.

Beyond the pain and suffering this has meant for most Americans, an increasing number have reacted by establishing nontraditional households in which both feudal class processes and traditional gender divisions are absent. They thereby testify to the profundity of the social contradictions and tensions that have brought crisis to so many feudal households. Since we can show that the numerical growth of nonfeudal households has been significant in recent US history, and since this marks a revolutionary class transformation in households with far-reaching social consequences, we need to consider the two major forms of nonfeudal household.

The "ancient" alternative

We use the term "ancient" to acknowledge the formulation of the concept by Marxist writers to designate a form of producing, appropriating, and distributing surplus labor that was particularly significant in ancient Rome and also during the European transition from feudalism to capitalism.⁴⁸ In the ancient form of class structure, the performer and appropriator of surplus labor is the same individual. S/he does necessary labor to reproduce her/himself and also performs surplus labor which is individually self-appropriated. S/he then decides to whom to

distribute that surplus to secure the conditions of existence of this form of the class process. Common examples include peasants and craftspersons individually producing and distributing goods and services, possibly as commodities through market exchanges. There is an affinity between Marx's ancient class structure and what is loosely called "self-employment" in non-Marxian terminologies. There is also a direct link between ancient class processes and one-adult households.

One-adult households dramatically increased both absolutely and relatively in comparison to all households from 1960 to 1987 (US Bureau of the Census 1987: 43). While total households in the United States rose from 53 to 89 million, the one-adult households rose from 13 to 34 million. By 1987, one-adult households accounted for over 38 percent of all US households. Moreover, the growth in such households cannot be explained by the changing age distribution of the US population—such households are increasingly being established by all age groups (Waldrop 1989). Most of the people in one-adult households individually appropriate their own surplus labor; they participate in ancient class processes there. These individuals neither establish feudal households nor move into the feudal households of relatives, typical strategies in previous eras when feudal household structures were virtually unchallenged socially.

People may accept or choose to live in households with ancient class structures for many different reasons. Among some groups in the United States, one-adult households have been common for many decades. However, certain recently changed social conditions have made their number proliferate rapidly. The ideology of female independence is one such changed condition. For over two decades the women's liberation movement in the United States has exposed and opposed sexist ideas of all kinds and sexual discrimination in all areas, including inside marriages and households. It has denounced the gender processes which are among the conditions of existence of women's class positions in feudal households. It has celebrated alternatives to the feudal household and female dependence. One of these has been and continues to be a "single lifestyle" in what amounts to an ancient household.⁴⁹

Dissatisfaction with the traditional feudal household and advocacy of the ancient alternative are not restricted to women. Since the 1950s, American males have increasingly spoken out against marriage and the feudal household as an oppression of men because of the onerous obligations of their provider roles (Adams and Briscoe 1971: 38–39; Ehrenreich 1983: 42–87, 99–116). A diffuse movement for a kind of male liberation has emerged. Through the gender processes that it has advanced, this movement has provided conditions of existence for men to opt for ancient instead of feudal households.⁵⁰ Ideas communicated by magazines such as *Playboy*, *Hustler*, and *Penthouse* express one of the central themes of these gender processes. The sexual dependence of men on women and the economic dependence of women on men which traditional marriages and households impose are seen as obstacles to self-fulfilment, both occupationally and personally. Sexual need and sexual dependence become symbolic of the neediness trap which can enslave men in feudal domesticity.⁵¹

The crisis of the feudal household and the proliferation of the ancient household have, of course, many other conditions of existence in addition to the movements

for women's liberation and for male disentanglement from marriage. The weakening of orthodox religions amid the celebration of many kinds of individualism facilitates ancient households. The media, especially television, function as a powerful force combining programs with advertisements to promote commodities as the chief means to self-realization. They increasingly portray the single, sexy male or female as the *sine qua non* of adventure. They rarely depict the serious struggles of couples of all kinds for honesty, friendship, and intimacy. They also rarely treat the complex difficulties of being single.

A pervasive ideological condition of existence for ancient class households is the US cult of the individual from the "self-made man" to the "Lone Ranger" to the "Equalizer."⁵² Particularly after the Second World War, the intensified individualizing of all problems and their solutions has made it very difficult for couples to imagine jointly analyzing and solving their problems. Individuals rather fear group life, including family life, as conformity to another's needs. Single lifestyles are often romanticized as a necessary individual rebellion against that conformity. Few seem able to imagine, and still less to insist upon, the joint exploration of their respective needs and the solutions to them.

Finally, the intensifying contradictions and tensions of feudal households in the United States have apparently convinced many of their children not to replicate them in their own lives. Ancient households are not, however, the only alternative to the feudal households that significant numbers of Americans are exploring. The social processes that have brought crisis to the feudal household and the rise of the ancient household have also prompted the formation of communist class structures in some households.

The "communist" alternative

Communist class structures in households are now widely regarded as components of the definition of successful modern family life. Of course, what our analysis sees as a class structure is not understood as such by those for whom notions of class apply only outside the household, if they apply to society at all. For example, couples therapies increasingly encourage the equal sharing of the performance, management, and fruits of domestic labor and all household decision-making. The broad goal is to share wealth, work, power, and emotional intimacy, substituting what, in our terms, approaches communism for the relations of economic exploitation and sexual and emotional subordination that characterize feudal households.

Although the family ideal in principle has long been close to the communist slogan, "from each according to her/his ability and to each according to his/her needs," women's abilities and needs were defined by gender processes consistent with feudal households. Changed gender processes redefined women and men as having corespective needs for independence as well as dependence, for mutual friendship and mutual protection, and for generalized equality. Newly redefined in these ways, the old family ideal is now consistent with and a condition of existence for communist class processes in households.

Approximately 20 percent of two-adult households in the United States may be characterized now as comprising communist class processes.⁵³ Yet in spite of the widely acclaimed virtues and successes of the modern communist family, the recognition and examination of its particular class structure have been virtually nonexistent.

Our general notion of the communist class structure of the household is based on previous work in the Marxian tradition seeking to clarify and extend Marx's few and fragmentary discussions of communism (Resnick and Wolff 1988a). Communist class processes differ from feudal class processes since communist performers of surplus labor are also its appropriators, and they also differ from ancient class processes since the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor are accomplished collectively rather than individually. Within a communist household, then, all adult members (whether married or not, heterosexual or gay, two persons or more) do necessary and surplus labor collectively and collectively appropriate their surplus. All decide together as a collective household how (to whom) to distribute this surplus so as to secure the conditions of existence of such a communist household.⁵⁴ Examples range from communes and group homes of many kinds to heterosexual and gay couples who organize the class structures of their households in this communist way.

Communist households have their distinctive contradictions and tensions. The point is that they differ from the contradictions of noncommunist households and so impart correspondingly different qualities to them. For example, collective decisions about surplus distribution invite all sorts of disputes that are quite different from a class structure in which one person—the feudal or ancient appropriator—makes such decisions individually. Meetings and discussions among household members about all aspects of household life will often distinctively characterize communist households. To take another example, some members of communist households will occupy subsumed class positions inside the household such as household record keeping, managing housework, and so on. However, unlike feudal households, communist households may want to avoid inequalities and disputes that may arise if some members of the decision-making collective were consistently to hold different class positions from others. In short, a policy of regular, systematic rotation of persons across all the class positions in the household might well be deemed a condition of existence of household communism. This, too, would distinguish communist households from feudal and ancient households.

The transition from traditional feudal households to this communist alternative is, like all class transitions, complex. Since we have already discussed many of the conditions producing a crisis in feudal households and making possible the transition to ancient households, and since these served also to produce transitions to household communism, we need not re-examine them here. The processes that had fostered the feudal household changed in some ways that encouraged ancient households and in other ways that encouraged communist households. Those who reject feudal households, but do not want one-adult households, may find their solution in communist households. Those who seek

independence alongside, rather than instead of, dependence may do likewise. Buffeted by all the social processes that make them refugees from feudal households, the communist and ancient seem to be the major alternatives chosen in the United States today.

The substantial growth of communist and ancient households alongside feudal households adds new contradictions and tensions to society. Their different class structures will generate conflicts between them. They will struggle over the class and other processes at other social sites—state, enterprises, churches—since developments at those sites will influence household class structures in different ways. For example, communist households pay taxes out of their surpluses much as feudal and ancient households do. What distinguishes the subsumed class payments made by the differently class-structured households is the precise nature of the conditions of existence they seek to secure in return for these payments.

Feudal households will pressure the state to enact laws and regulations that support their class structures. Ancient and communist households will exert pressures for different and often opposing laws supporting their respective class structures.⁵⁵ While all the other social processes shaping state activities will determine which pressures predominate, two recent examples can illustrate the problem and what is at stake. First, between 1984 and 1987, eight states passed legislation outlawing spousal rape.⁵⁶ Second, in 1987, intense debates occurred in the US Senate over expansion of government-funded childcare facilities. Both of these developments may be dangerous for feudal households, as they contribute to changing power relations between women and men inside the household and to expanding women's economic opportunities outside the home. Those in ancient and communist households have little to fear from these developments and much to applaud.

Religious institutions have also recently been the sites of battle affecting the conditions of existence that they do or do not provide to religious households of differing class structures.⁵⁷ We may consider the case of the Roman Catholic Church (although similar conflicts agitate many other religious institutions).⁵⁸ During the Pope's 1987 visit to the United States, Catholic priests requested a reconsideration of the Church's bans on birth control and women's ordination into the priesthood. Mass protests in 1987 opposed papal efforts to oust Catholic University professor Charles Curran and Seattle Bishop Hunthausen for their generally "liberal" attitudes and teachings on birth control and abortion. There has been open, public controversy among Catholic bishops on the issue of AIDS prevention through the use of condoms. A Catholic homosexual group, Dignity, mounts regular public protests seeking to change the official attitude toward homosexuality and homosexual households.

These changes would not be likely to strengthen feudal families and would at least implicitly encourage ancient and communist households. Not only competing theologies, economic pressures on Church finances, and power struggles within the hierarchy, but also pressures from Catholic households of different class structures are combining to shape the movements for and against doctrinal change within Roman Catholicism in the United States.

The growth of communist households raises a special kind of problem for capitalist enterprises. Men and women from such households may become increasingly accustomed to collective power processes (decision-making), communist class processes, and gender processes stressing sexual equality. Many of them will leave such communist households daily to earn wages and salaries in capitalist enterprises with very different class, gender, and power processes. How will they experience, understand, and react to their daily occupation of such different and opposing class, gender, and power positions? More precisely, how will the interactions between capitalist enterprises and communist or ancient households differ from the interactions between those enterprises and feudal households?

Will capitalist employees coming from communist households recognize the different class processes at both sites as such? Will they apply such class consciousness to the definitions of their problems and their searches for solutions? Will they seek to extend the communist revolution in the household to one at the workplace? Will gender processes stressing sexual equality and political processes stressing collective decision-making, fostered in and by communist households, become parallel issues for struggles at worksites? For example, will the struggles for "comparable worth" (equal pay for equal work) evolve into struggles for equality and collectivity in all aspects of enterprises, including the production, appropriation, and distribution of surplus labor?

The class and gender revolution underway in households is profoundly changing the United States. How the causes, components, and possibilities of that revolution are understood will itself play a significant role in transforming our society. This implies a specific agenda for Marxist-Feminists: (1) to develop and apply a theory focused on the particular roles played by class, gender, and power processes in contemporary life; and (2) to intervene in social struggles by utilizing that theory and its findings.

Conclusion: a Marxist-Feminist agenda

By integrating Marxist and Feminist theories in a particular way, we can offer the beginnings of a new analysis of the class structures and class dynamics inside US households today. Presuming the interdependence and mutual transformation of gender and class and power processes, we can show how changing conceptions of woman and man have functioned as complex causes and effects of changing household class structures. The analysis has produced some preliminary hypotheses. Basic class, gender, and power struggles are underway in American households today. Revolutionary changes in class structures, gender definitions, and power allocations have occurred in millions of those households with profound social consequences. Specifically, communist class structures are developing where few had even thought to look for them, let alone to chart their actual and potential social impacts.

Marxists and Feminists need to remedy the neglect of the complex interdependence of class, gender, and power processes in general, and in households in particular. That neglect characterizes not only many other approaches to social

science, but also the practical political activities of many Feminists and Marxists. Marxist-Feminists need to stress that class processes and struggles occur in different ways at different social sites. Any a priori presumption that they occur only at some privileged sites, such as enterprises and states, is unwarranted. This is as true for gender and power processes and struggles as for their class counterparts.

The agenda of Marxist-Feminists must discard such a priori notions and replace them with a commitment to identify the class, gender, and power processes that may exist and interact at all social sites. On that basis, we can proceed to understand the ongoing contradictions, tensions, and changes within the societies whose class exploitation, gender oppression, and general social injustice we seek to abolish. In that way, Marxist-Feminists can contribute significantly to the efforts of all those seeking social transformations toward a communist, egalitarian, democratic system of economic, political, and cultural processes.